

Someone To Look Up To

a novel

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CHAPTER ONE

The House

The moving truck pulled away and left two tyre marks on the driveway and that was that.

He'd done this before. Four times as a father, including the one that counted as twice because the second move had been inside the same city, a bigger flat, Marcus four months old, the lease signed in the state of exhaustion that attends new parenthood and makes every decision feel both urgent and irreversible. He'd learned from that one: have a system. Know where the box with the kettle is. Know where the sheets are. Have a plan for the first night that doesn't require any decisions.

He had a system. The system was in his head, ordered, and it had been in his head since Tuesday when he'd walked through this house on the final pre-move visit and mapped it.

The system had not anticipated the moving truck being ninety minutes late.

He stood on the porch in his coat while Priya managed the truck men and Nali managed the children and he stood on the porch and did not manage anything, which was not his way and felt wrong, but there was nothing to manage because Priya had it and Nali had it and the truck men were actually fine. He stood on the porch and looked at Bishop Street and let it be the world.

It was a Tuesday in November. The light was the specific light of November in a place that knew what winter was — not the soft light

of somewhere temperate, but the considered light of a place that understood things were about to get serious and was already preparing. The silver maples had lost most of their leaves. A few remained, more orange than gold, the last of the season's argument.

He watched a car go slowly down Bishop Street. Then no cars. Then a woman walking a large dog, the dog investigating something at the base of a lamp post with the thoroughness of a professional. Then nothing again.

He thought about the furnace.

He thought about the mortgage figure. Not catastrophically — he wasn't catastrophising, he'd agreed with Priya that they weren't catastrophising — but running the number, the way he ran numbers, because that was how he managed things. The number was fine. The number was manageable. The furnace was sixteen years old, which was not the number he wanted, but sixteen-year-old furnaces were not inevitably failing furnaces. He had the inspection report. He'd read the inspection report four times. The word the inspector had used was *adequate*. He'd been sitting with *adequate* for two weeks.

He thought about his children inside this house right now. Marcus deliberately in a specific room, the contained self-management of a fifteen-year-old who had not asked to be here and was doing his best. Zara somewhere — probably already exploring, that was Zara, the systematic investigation of new spaces. Mateo with the figure, the bent-caped figure he'd had since he was three, held out at arm's length in some new doorway, giving it the view.

He thought about Priya. About the conversation they'd had three weeks ago in the old kitchen, late, the children asleep, when she'd said: *I keep asking myself if this is the right thing*. And he'd said: *me too*. And she'd said: *but we're doing it*. And he'd said: *yeah*. And she'd said: *because we decided*. And he'd said: *yeah*. It wasn't a romantic conversation. It was better than romantic. It was two people who'd been doing this for seventeen years acknowledging that doing things

together didn't require certainty, it required decision, and the decision had been made.

He thought about his mother. In there, already acquainting herself, already putting her hand against the walls the way she did, already doing the work of knowing a place.

He stood on the porch until he'd finished the thought. Then he went inside.

He stood in the empty kitchen for a long time.

He'd made his lists. He'd done his system. He knew where the kettle box was and the sheets box and the first-night box with the mugs and the coffee and the children's things. He'd been managing the practical question since Thursday and he was, he thought, managing it well.

The other question was different.

He'd known it was coming. It had been sitting in the back of his chest since September when they'd made the decision — not dread exactly, not guilt exactly. Something more patient than either of those. The specific weight of a man who had made a choice that was right for some of the people it affected and not all of them.

Marcus was fifteen. He had his court and his friends and Jordan, and Sibafuzi had watched him find those things — watched him come home from the first week of school at age twelve with the slightly undone look of a person who has found somewhere to belong, and had felt the specific relief of a parent who knows what they've been carrying. Three years since then. Three years of watching his son be somewhere. Know people. Sink roots that could hold him.

He'd pulled those roots today. He knew that.

Zara was ten. She had left Mrs. Pemberton. Zara had left Sophie, who called every Sunday, who would call next Sunday and the one after and then maybe once a month and then at Christmas. He knew how that went. He'd watched it go that way before.

Mateo was six. Mateo would be fine in a way that hurt to think about — Mateo would find the new house's sounds and learn them and attach himself to the new neighborhood the way he attached himself to everything, wholly, and by spring he would have forgotten that it had ever been otherwise. That was the mercy of six. It was also the thing that made Sibafuzi close his eyes standing in the kitchen in his coat — that his youngest child would just absorb it, and that this was in some way the saddest thing.

He was forty-one years old. He had three children who had not chosen this.

He thought about his own father. The one who'd left when Sibafuzi was eight. He'd spent years — embarrassingly many years, in retrospect — being careful not to become the version of that. But leaving was one kind of thing. And there were other kinds, more ambiguous, the ones that didn't have a clean name. The kind where you stayed, you were there, you worked hard for exactly the reasons you said — and still your children unpacked boxes in strange rooms because of decisions you'd made.

He wasn't sure how to hold both of those things.

She'd found a line somewhere — an article, something a man had written about what it meant to move a family, and she'd read it to him three weeks ago when the decision was as made as decisions get: you show them how to land. She'd held his eyes when she said it, the way she held his eyes when she was saying something she needed him to keep.

He didn't know if he was showing them how to land. He knew how to manage a move. He knew the system. He didn't know if the system was the same thing.

He stood in the kitchen until the house was quiet.

The house smelled like other people. He noticed it immediately — the accumulated smell of lives lived here, cooking and warmth and the particular human trace of a house long-inhabited. Not unpleasant.

Just not his yet.

Getting less so, he thought. Already.

Sibafuzi stood in the open doorway watching it go. He still had his coat on. The keys were in his right hand — he'd been carrying them for three weeks now, ever since the lawyer slid them across the desk in that office on Hurontario Street with the particular brand of professional warmth that conveys neither congratulation nor condolence but is somehow both at once. He'd been carrying them in his coat pocket, then his trouser pocket, then his coat again, and they still felt borrowed. Still felt like something he'd be asked to return.

He looked down at them now. Three keys on a plain ring. The large deadbolt. The Yale. A smaller one he hadn't yet identified — it opened something in this house and he didn't know what, and that felt exactly right for where they were.

He put them on the little shelf by the front door. Someone had screwed that shelf there once, at some point, for their own keys. He thought about that person briefly — who they were, what their mornings looked like, whether they'd felt this same strange mixture of arrival and not-quite-belonging — and then he stopped thinking about it and went to find the kitchen.

* * *

The house on Bishop Street was a four-bedroom Victorian with a covered porch, set back from the road behind a pair of silver maples that had grown large enough to make the house feel discovered rather than visible. Pre-war, the realtor had said, twice, as though Sibafuzi hadn't heard or hadn't understood, when actually he'd heard and was still deciding what to make of it. Pre-war could mean solid bones or it could mean a hundred years of problems patiently biding their time behind the plaster.

Bishop Street was quiet in the way that Collingwood streets were quiet in November — not peacefully quiet, not summery-cottage quiet, but the quiet of a town that had been something and was still working out what it was now. Half the houses on the block were full-time residences, families who'd been there for generations. The other half had the particular look of weekend properties whose owners had stopped coming as regularly as they once had — lawns done by a service, lights on timers, driveways empty from Monday to Thursday. Three doors down, a house that had been a bed and breakfast had closed in the spring and sat with a polite little for-sale sign that looked like it had given up expecting interest.

At the far end of the block, on the corner, stood the church.

St. Andrew's Presbyterian. 1889, according to the stone above the door, which you could read clearly because the silver maples on that corner had been cut back to almost nothing after the ice storm four winters ago and nobody had replanted. The building was handsome in the way that small Ontario churches were handsome — plain limestone, tall narrow windows, a steeple that had been modest to begin with and was now modest and faded. The parking lot beside it had twelve spaces marked and Sibafuzi had not yet seen more than two of them occupied at once.

He'd looked up St. Andrew's when they were considering the offer on the house. The congregation was listed as active, which was technically true. What the listing didn't say was that active, for St. Andrew's in the present year, meant Sunday services with perhaps twenty souls in a space built for one hundred and forty. The families who'd filled those pews for three generations had been drifting south for a decade — to Barrie, to Vaughan, to Mississauga, to the specific gravitational pull of the 400 corridor that was slowly repositioning where life happened in this part of Ontario. The town still had its coffee shops and its ski hills and its summer. But the things that had once held a community in place — the church, the curling club, the

hardware store that had closed and become a yoga studio — were quietly becoming museums to a version of Collingwood that was mostly memory now.

Sibafuzi had looked at all of this and decided it didn't matter. What mattered was the house.

He'd made the decision on a Thursday afternoon in September, standing in this same kitchen with the realtor hovering diplomatically near the back door. The kitchen was wrong — too small, no island, a window that looked directly into the neighbor's fence. But the study off the hallway had those built-in shelves, the kind you could see someone had made carefully and not in a hurry, and he'd stood in front of them for a long moment and thought: whoever built these planned to stay. They built these for a life, not a rental.

He'd called Priya from the car on the way back. He'd said: I think it's the one.

A long pause. She'd been at her desk. He could picture her — chair turned slightly from the screen, pen in hand out of habit, the specific quality of her thinking silence.

She'd said: tell me.

He'd told her. The shelves. The east-facing kitchen window. The little key ledge someone had put there for no good reason except that they always put their keys somewhere specific and wanted a proper place for them. Priya had said nothing for a while and he'd thought he'd lost her, misread it, said the wrong thing. Then she'd said: that's the one, Fuzi. Let's go.

That had been two months ago. Now here he was. Now here they all were.

The place smelled like other people. Not bad. Just — other people. Someone else's cooking was in the walls, their particular way of doing things, maybe an argument they'd had once by the furnace, the residue of twenty years of ordinary life that doesn't leave with the furniture. You could feel it in the rooms — a warmth that wasn't quite yours yet,

a comfort that had been broken in by other bodies and would need time to accept new ones.

That kind of smell. The kind that takes weeks to become yours.

* * *

The moving truck had been booked for eight. It had arrived at nine forty-five, driven by two men who'd worked with the particular efficient silence of people who moved other people's entire lives for a living and had long since stopped being interested in the contents. Which was fine. Which was the professional thing. But it had given the morning a strangeness — all this careful accumulation of years being carried past in cardboard boxes and furniture blankets by people to whom it meant nothing at all.

Priya had directed. She always directed the practical things because Sibafuzi's approach to logistics was too theoretical — he could see where everything should end up but found the intermediate steps frustrating in a way he couldn't fully explain and so preferred, when Priya was available, to let her manage. He'd carried things. Heavy things. He was good for that.

Nali had sat in the front passenger seat of their car for most of it, because she'd said she was staying out of the way, and when Nali said she was staying out of the way she meant it completely. She had a book. She read. Every so often she looked up and watched the house from behind the windscreen with a particular expression that Sibafuzi recognized from his childhood — the face she wore when she was reading a thing that couldn't be read in a book.

His mother had always seen houses the way some people see people. She had opinions about them that she'd formed in her first five minutes inside and rarely revised.

He hadn't asked her yet about this one. He was waiting.

* * *

He heard Mateo before he saw him.

That little-kid thunder on the bare floorboards overhead — irregular, purposeful, the sound of a six-year-old navigating a new space with the particular confidence that comes from not yet understanding that unfamiliar things are supposed to feel unfamiliar. Mateo moved through new places like he'd agreed to arrive there. Like he'd been consulted.

He came round the bottom of the stairs with his arms out slightly for balance and the superhero figure in his right fist, cape bent all the way back from months of being held exactly like that.

"Dad. There's a door at the top that's really small. Like for a mouse."

"That's the attic."

"Can I go in?"

"No."

"Why?"

"Because I said."

Mateo looked at him. Looked at the figure in his hand. Held it up.

"Could he go?"

"No."

Mateo considered this seriously, the way he considered most things — fully and without rushing — and then appeared to accept it, not in the defeated way of someone who's been refused but in the way of someone who's filed the information and will return to it at a moment of their choosing. He turned and went back upstairs, already narrating something under his breath, the figure out in front of him on some kind of mission that didn't require a dad's sign-off.

Sibafuzi stood in the empty hallway a moment after he'd gone. The pipes were ticking somewhere. A sound like the house settling into itself, or possibly adjusting to them.

He went and turned on the kitchen tap. Stood there while the water ran, slow at first, then finding its temperature. Old pipes. Of course.

Old pipes were just the start of it. From the back of the house came a small sound — Monde, the puppy, in the utility room off the kitchen where Priya had set up his bed. Six months old and already the family's most reliable barometer: he could tell when a house was anxious. He went quiet again after a moment. Sibafuzi took that as a reasonable sign.

He didn't let himself think about the furnace yet.

* * *

She had been last out of the car. She'd stood on the path while the truck men carried the final boxes through — not directing, not helping, just standing with her handbag and looking at the front of the house for a long moment, the way she always looked at a new house, from the outside, before she committed to it.

* * *

Nali's room — the back bedroom, the one that ran along the east side of the house — had the best light.

This was objectively true and Priya had said it that way, and Nali had said of course, my dear, and that had been that. But they both understood — Priya because she'd chosen it, Nali because she understood everything — that the room was also the furthest from everywhere else. From the kitchen, from the living room, from the noise of three children and one stressed husband managing boxes. The back room was the room you gave someone when you loved them and needed them and also needed, just occasionally and guiltily and entirely reasonably, a door between you and them.

Nali was sitting on the edge of the bed when Priya came in. Coat still on. Handbag in her lap. Looking at the window — the east-facing window that caught the morning — with the expression she wore when she was reading something invisible to everyone else.

"You don't have to keep holding the bag," Priya said. "You live here now."

Nali smiled. Not the tired one. The other one — the one with something behind it, some private knowledge that she distributed carefully and only when it would land.

"I know, I know. I'm just sitting with the room small. Learning it, eh?"

Priya sat beside her on the mattress. Firm — she'd sort that, a topper, it was on the list. The list was on her phone. The list was in her head. The list was, at present, somewhat longer than felt manageable, and she was managing it anyway because she was Priya and that was what she did.

"Good house?" she said.

The question surprised her even as she asked it. She wasn't sure where it had come from — she'd done the viewings, she'd done the inspection, she'd read the report three times and made her peace with the hairline crack in the foundation that wasn't actually a problem, it was just settling, everything old settles. She knew this house. But she needed someone to tell her something about it that the documents couldn't.

Nali looked at the window. Then she reached out and put her palm flat against the wall beside her. Left it there a moment, the way you take someone's temperature.

"The bones are good. You feel it in some houses, my dear — this one doesn't want to be left. That one that wants to be left, you walk in and you know straight away. It's tired. It's done. This is not that."

"You can actually feel that?"

Nali gave her the look — the one she reserved for questions she considered already answered by the universe. Priya had been getting that look for seventeen years and had made a kind of peace with it, the way you make peace with the weather.

"I have lived in enough houses," Nali said simply. "My dear."

Priya nodded. She wanted to say something real — something about how frightened she'd been driving here this morning, how the whole thing had felt suddenly enormous in a way it hadn't when it was still a plan, still theoretical, still a set of numbers on paper. She wanted to say: I keep waiting for it to feel like ours and it doesn't yet and I'm not sure when it will. She wanted to say: I don't know what I'm doing half the time and I keep acting like I do and I'm very tired.

She didn't say any of it. The moment was there for it but it was also the kind of moment that could go either way and she was too tired to chance the wrong way.

She said she'd go find the box with the kettle, and Nali said now you're talking, now we're talking, and Priya stood up and smoothed the back of her trousers the way she did when she was collecting herself, and went out into the hall.

She stopped just outside the door. Put her back against the wall and her eyes closed. Not crying. Just stopping — ten seconds of standing completely still in the middle of all the not-being-still, the way she'd learned to find those ten seconds over the years, in hospital waiting rooms and school parking lots and the bathrooms of houses full of people who needed things from her. Ten seconds. Then she opened her eyes.

Marcus's door clicked shut down the hall.

She went to find the kettle.

She sat with the room after Priya left.

Not because she was tired — she was seventy-three and her hip was a negotiation but she was not, despite what her children seemed to fear, fragile. She sat because the room needed sitting with. Every new room needed it. You couldn't know a place by moving through it. You had to stop. You had to let it come to you.

This room. East-facing, the window above the radiator, the particular angle of the afternoon light across the bare floorboards. A smell she was still identifying — old house, old paint, and underneath

it something she had no English word for, only the Silozi one her mother had used: a quality of belonging. As if the molecules of the air had been rearranged by long occupation into something that contained everyone who had ever slept here.

Her mother had talked about houses that way. As though they were alive. As though they remembered.

She put her hand flat against the wall again. Left it there. This was her own private thing — she had done it in every house she had ever entered, for as long as she could remember. Her mother had done it too. Esther Imakando, who had grown up in Mongu in a house of nine children and died in a house she'd made her own over forty years and knew by then the way you knew a body, every creak and settling and cold draft. Who had said to Nali once, when Nali was young enough not to understand it: *most people look with their eyes. You have to look with your hands. The hands know before the rest of you does.*

She had been twelve. She hadn't understood. She'd understood it by her third house, which was the first one she'd chosen alone. She'd understood it completely by now.

She pressed her palm against the plaster. Cold, then warming slowly to her temperature.

Good bones, she'd told Priya. True. But more than that. The room had been loved. She could feel it the way her mother had taught her to feel things — not mystically, not woo-woo as the children said now, but in the plain physical evidence of care over time. The window had been re-caulked, recently. The radiator was recently bled — you could see the slight rust stain where someone had done it themselves rather than called a plumber. Someone had put a small hook on the back of the door at exactly the height that said they knew this room, knew themselves in it, knew what they needed when they woke and needed something to hang on.

Small things. But you could read a life in small things. Her mother had taught her that too.

She thought about Sibafuzi. Standing in the doorway of the kitchen when she'd arrived, coat still on, keys in his hand, looking at the house with the expression she'd been watching him carry for thirty years. Not unhappy. Not happy. The look of a man running a calculation that didn't come out even. She'd seen it the first time when he was eight years old and his father had left — left the country, left without a conversation, left in the way that leaves questions with no answers — and Sibafuzi had stood in the doorway of *that* room, in that house, with those keys in his hand, and tried to make the numbers add up.

He was still doing it. Forty-one years old, a good man, a complicated man, and still standing in doorways doing the math.

She took her hand off the wall.

She would not say any of this to anyone. It was enough to know it. Knowing it meant she would be here when he needed her to be here, the way her mother had been here for her — not with speeches or interventions but with the kettle going and the chair in the right corner and the quality of her silence, which was not absence but a very full presence that said: *I am here. I see you. You don't have to explain.*

That was all heroism was, her mother had said once. Not the speeches. Not the moments. Just: *I see you. I'm here.* Again and again and again, for as long as you were needed.

She had been twelve. She hadn't understood. She understood it completely now.

* * *

Marcus had the second biggest room.

Everyone kept saying it like it was a prize, and he understood why — they were trying to give him something, trying to find the bright side and hand it to him with both hands — and he couldn't explain why it made things worse rather than better. The room was fine.

Decent, actually. Walk-in closet, bay window, good afternoon light. He could see a corner of the backyard and part of Bishop Street from here, including the far end where St. Andrew's sat on its corner with its faded steeple and its empty parking lot.

He sat on the floor with his back against the wall and opened his phone.

Jordan had sent a voice note.

He held the phone up and pressed play but didn't put it to his ear, let the voice come out small and tinny from the speaker instead.

"Bro where are you. Everyone's at the court. It's a good day out. Marcus, man. When you coming back?"

He played it twice. The same voice note he'd played probably a dozen times since Jordan sent it four days ago. Listening for something different in it each time, or listening for the same thing — he wasn't sure anymore. Jordan's voice with that thing it always did, always slightly surprised by life, like the world kept failing to match his expectations and he found this more funny than annoying. Jordan who'd been his person since grade eight. Jordan who'd covered for him and he'd covered for Jordan and neither of them had ever needed to discuss what that meant.

He put the phone face down on the floor beside him.

The thing he hadn't told anyone, the thing that lived in the specific silence under everything else: he knew. He'd known for two months before it happened. That Kwame was carrying product to school, nothing dramatic, weed and something else once, the something else once being the part that changed things. He'd known and he'd said nothing because Jordan was his person and Kwame was Jordan's brother and you didn't do that to your person.

And then Kwame got caught. And then it escalated the way those things escalate when the school gets involved and the school gets the police involved and the police don't know which way to go with it. And in the middle of that, Marcus had said something to a boy named

Terrell — not a lie, just the truth, just what he'd seen, because Terrell had asked and Marcus was terrible at lying and the truth just came out.

And Terrell told someone. And that someone told the school. And the school told the police. And the police talked to Kwame. And Kwame knew where it had come from.

Jordan didn't say anything to Marcus about it. He didn't have to. Marcus saw it in him the next day at school — the way Jordan looked at him for one moment and then stopped looking, and after that didn't look at him the same way at all. Not angry. Just — recalibrated. Like he'd updated his understanding of what Marcus was.

And the thing that Marcus couldn't resolve, the thing the voice note kept bumping up against every time he played it: Bro where are you. It was warm. Jordan still called him. So either Jordan didn't know it was Marcus who told Terrell, or Jordan knew and had decided to let it go, and Marcus couldn't tell which was worse. Because if Jordan didn't know, then Marcus was sitting on something that would eventually surface and would be worse for having been sat on. And if Jordan knew and had let it go — then Marcus had cost his best friend's family something real and Jordan had forgiven him anyway, and that was a different weight entirely.

He turned the phone face down on the floor and didn't look at it.

The thing about the third move in five years was that you stopped believing it was temporary. The first two had been close together — within a year of each other, the kind of consecutive disruption that made you give up unpacking properly the second time because you already knew. That had been when he was ten. Then three years in the same place, three years long enough that he'd almost forgotten what it felt like to be new somewhere, and now this. This time they'd bought the house, which meant no more reasons to go back. This was it. Collingwood. The high school he hadn't seen yet. These streets.

From his window he could see the church. He'd noticed it when they arrived — how could you not, it sat right at the end of the block with that particular presence old Ontario churches had, stone and steeple and a weight to them that said: this has been here longer than any of the people in it ever were. But there was something else about it. The parking lot. The peeling paint on the noticeboard by the door. The way the building sat with its lights off on a Saturday afternoon, not closed exactly — you could see from here that the door had a posted schedule, that it was technically open, technically active — but with the unmistakable air of a thing that had been fuller once.

He thought about the town they'd left. What it had felt like to know every corner of it. To have the court, and the shortcut through the ravine behind Morley Street, and the specific Timmies where Jordan's older brother worked and would sometimes leave extra Timbits in the bag. To know where things were. To be known.

He stared at the church at the end of Bishop Street.

He didn't reply to Jordan.

* * *

Zara had already done every room by three o'clock.

She wasn't being nosy — she'd learned to say this pre-emptively because her approach to new spaces was often mistaken for that. She couldn't settle in a place until she knew its shape. Until she'd stood in every corner and felt the light from every window and knew where the sound went when you closed a door. Long enough that everyone in the family had stopped trying to change it and had simply incorporated it: before Zara settles, give her an hour. It's fine. It's just Zara.

The house on Bishop Street had more rooms than a first glance suggested. Zara had counted them in order: the living room, the front hall (she was counting it), the kitchen, the utility room off the kitchen

which was small but had a window and a distinct smell and qualified in her system, the small study off the hall with those shelves her dad kept talking about, and four bedrooms — hers, Mateo's (north-facing, the small one with the single window and the radiator that knocked), her parents', and Nali's at the back. Plus Marcus's. She hadn't been in Marcus's yet because Marcus's door was shut and she respected that. And there was the room she hadn't been in at all: at the top of the narrow back staircase — not the main staircase, the other one, narrower and steeper, the kind of staircase that had a different purpose once — a small landing and a door painted the exact same color as the wall around it.

She stood at the bottom of that stair and looked up at the door.

Someone had painted it deliberately. That was a choice — you matched a door to a wall when you wanted to minimize it, when you wanted the eye to slide past it. You didn't do that by accident.

She could hear her dad in the kitchen below, opening and closing drawers in that methodical way of his — trying things in different positions, building his system for the new space. He did this in every house she could remember. It was one of the things she found reassuring about him: that he adapted by organizing, that he made the unfamiliar familiar by putting it into order, one drawer at a time.

She looked at the painted door.

Then she went back downstairs to help with the boxes.

She had a list. She'd made it on the last night in the previous house, sitting on her bare mattress with the room half-packed around her and the window she'd spent three years looking out of still showing her the same tree, the same angle of street, the last time it would be her window.

The list was called *Things I Am Taking And Things I Am Leaving*. She had a formal relationship with lists. They did not upset her. They organized her. Cataloguing what she was losing was not the same as mourning it — it was the precondition for being able to carry it

properly. You couldn't carry what you hadn't named.

Taking:

Sophie, who had her number and had made her promise to call every Sunday — both of them had promised, on the last day, standing on the pavement outside Sophie's house, which had been awkward but also necessary. Zara believed Sophie would keep it. She also knew, from the two moves before this one, what the shape of keeping a promise across distance looked like over time: the calls every week at first, then every other week, then *I've been meaning to call*, then Christmas. She knew this. She'd watched it. She put Sophie under taking anyway. The decision stood.

The notebook with the pressed leaves from the park on Elgin Street. The park itself was under leaving.

Her route — the way she walked to school that went past the mural on the side of the laundromat and then through the alley with the painted windows and then past the house with the dog who always ran to the fence. Every part of this route was under leaving.

Mrs. Pemberton, the librarian, who had been giving Zara book recommendations since she was eight and who had, on the last visit, handed her a book with a folded note inside that said *for the long journey. you'll know when to read it*. Mrs. Pemberton was under taking. The note was in Zara's bag right now, the book half-read, the note still folded. She had not yet decided when.

The smell of the library. Under leaving, obviously. Smells weren't portable. But she'd stood in it deliberately on the last visit, noting it, the specific combination of old paper and dust and the particular cleaning product they used on the floors, because naming it meant she'd have something accurate to miss.

The smell of her own room. Also under leaving. She was in the process of learning the new one.

Her tree. Under leaving. It was outside her bedroom window and she had, over three years, spent approximately forty-six hours in it —

not climbing, sitting in a specific branch that had grown at an angle that made it a natural chair. She had read three novels and had two important thoughts and once seen an owl in it at four in the morning. It was not portable. It was under leaving.

Then she wrote: The feeling of knowing where I am.

She'd sat with that one. It was accurate. You could know a place the way you knew a person — not all of it, but the parts that mattered to you, the way they worked, what they needed, what they gave back. She'd known her previous town. She'd been in the middle of knowing it, the specific phase where you'd moved past learning it and into inhabiting it.

She'd had to put that under leaving.

Then she'd added, at the bottom: *But I learned to know it. Which means I know how. Which means I can do it again.*

She'd folded the list and put it in the notebook with the pressed leaves. It was in her bag right now, along with Mrs. Pemberton's book and the attic hatch that she'd been back to twice and the painted-over door she was planning to go through on the right day.

She had a lot to carry. She was good at carrying things. The list had helped her understand what was hers.

Three things she knew about the painted door, in order of certainty:

One: it had been done on purpose. You could see in the quality of the paint job — careful, two coats, the brush strokes horizontal on the door and vertical on the wall around it, like the painter had taken their time making them indistinguishable. That wasn't an accident. Accidents looked accidental. This looked considered.

Two: whoever painted it wasn't hiding something shameful. If it were shameful you'd put a lock on it, or move to a house without an attic. The painting-over was different — it was the thing you did when you wanted something to be found by the right person. The door wasn't locked. It was just patient.

Three: she was going to go through it. Not today. When the house was quiet and she knew which sounds were the house and which sounds were her family and which sounds meant someone was coming up the back stairs. She needed to know those apart first. Maybe two more days.

She filed all of this under attic hatch, door, patience, right time, and went back down to help carry boxes. The boxes weren't interesting. But the house was.

But she kept thinking about it. All evening, quietly, the way she held most things — not in the front where they'd need to be managed, but just present. Available. The door painted the color of the wall.

* * *

CHAPTER TWO

The First Week

The furnace worked fine in the day.

At night it had other ideas.

On Tuesday, at eleven o'clock, Sibafuzi was in the kitchen in his coat with the laptop open. The HVAC company's website had a cost calculator — he'd found it at half past ten and had been on it for thirty minutes, working through the options with the specific concentration of someone who already knows the number and is not yet ready to fully know it.

He closed the laptop.

He sat in the kitchen in his coat and listened to the pipes knock and settle around him — old pipes having their nightly conversation with the cold, a language he didn't speak yet but would learn — and he did the math he'd been avoiding for three weeks.

The down payment had pushed them. Not broke them — the mortgage broker had been very clear about that, patient, the numbers work Mr. Sibafuzi, the numbers absolutely work. And they did. They just worked with nothing spare. They worked in the way that a sentence works when every word is load-bearing and you can't take any of them out.

The furnace was sixteen years old. The inspection report had noted it. In the measured, non-alarmist way that inspection reports noted things when they wanted to flag something without committing to urgency. He'd read that section twice and decided to believe the

non-alarmist version. He'd been believing the non-alarmist version for two months.

Outside on Bishop Street nothing moved. The church at the end sat dark and patient in the November night, its steeple cutting the sky above the roofline. He'd seen, earlier in the week, a light in one of the side windows on a Tuesday evening — someone in there, doing something, maintaining the idea of it. He'd found himself grateful for that. For the fact that someone was still in there keeping it going, even now, even quietly.

Mateo noticed that his dad only laughed with his whole face when Nali was in the room. When Nali wasn't there he laughed differently — with his mouth and sometimes his shoulders, but not his eyes. He didn't know what that meant. He filed it under things to think about later. He had a lot of things in that file.

Something creaked above him. The house settling — he'd decided to call it that. Settling was fine. Settling was what old houses did. He was going to call everything settling for at least the first six months.

He finished his tea. Made a second one. Sat there until midnight with the pipes talking around him, working out what he'd tell Priya and how, and what he'd keep back and why, and whether those were the same thing.

* * *

The first real argument was Wednesday, and it was about paint, which meant it wasn't about paint.

They'd agreed on the front hallway first — neutral ground, good place to start, set the tone for everything else. Priya had bought the paint on the weekend, three cans of a warm off-white she'd found after considerable research. The thing about Priya and research was that she did it properly, and when she arrived at a conclusion it was a considered conclusion and she was not immediately thrilled by the

prospect of revising it.

Sibafuzi asked whether it needed a primer coat first.

He'd asked it plainly, practically, a question with a straightforward answer — and Priya had looked at him the way she looked at him when a question didn't have a straightforward answer and they both knew it but only one of them was pretending otherwise.

She said: yes, it needs primer.

He said: can we skip it? Two coats of this, we'll be fine.

She said: that's not how it works.

He said: I've done it before.

She said: when.

He started to say something about the kitchen in their last rental and she said that was a completely different surface and he said the principle was the same and she said —

And then he'd said: I don't need this right now.

He knew as he said it that it was wrong. Not untrue, but wrong — wrong in the way things are wrong when they're really about something else and you've said the something else out loud instead of the actual thing. I don't need this right now was not about primer. It was about the furnace. It was about the laptop at eleven o'clock. It was about three weeks of carrying something quietly that was getting less quiet.

And Priya said: I don't either.

Which was also not about primer.

It ended the way those arguments ended between them — not with resolution, not with either of them saying the thing underneath the thing, but with a gradual drift to different parts of the house. Sibafuzi to the garage, where there were boxes he could move around with purpose. Priya to the laundry room off the kitchen, where she could do something useful that didn't require conversation. They moved around each other all evening like something orbital — present, proximate, never quite meeting.

He'd stood in the hallway after she went upstairs. The paint tin on the floor. The brush still in the tray. The hallway half-undercoated, one wall done, the other not, an unfinished thing between them.

He knew what the argument had been about. He'd known it as he was saying the words — the specific clarity of *this is not about what I'm saying, it is about the five months of pressure and the furnace and the mortgage number and the move and the children and the distance I've been and the way she has been carrying things that I should have been carrying*. He'd known all of that. He'd said *I don't need this right now* anyway.

Because the knowing didn't stop the saying. That was the thing. You could know something completely and still do the other thing. This was the ongoing human problem and he didn't have a solution to it and neither did anyone else, as far as he could tell. You just tried to get better at the gap between knowing and doing. He was fifty percent better at this than he'd been at thirty-two. He expected to be fifty percent better again by the time he was fifty. By sixty he'd probably have it mostly under control, which meant he had about twenty years of this to go.

He cleaned the brush.

He put the lid back on the paint tin.

He went to the kitchen and made tea and stood at the window.

The garden in November. The lilac at the back fence, enormous and leggy, not particularly beautiful at this time of year, just there and large and committed to existing. He understood the lilac. He was also just there and large and committed to existing, and some days that was the most he could offer.

He heard Priya moving upstairs. The specific sound of her in the bathroom, then the bedroom, then the sound of the house settling around her in the way it settled when she was reading — a particular stillness, a held quality. He knew her sounds. He'd known them for seventeen years. He could track her through a house by her sounds

without meaning to.

He drank his tea and stood at the window until the guilt had done what guilt does when you give it the right amount of time — reduced itself from an event to a fact, from something that needed immediate action to something that needed a right moment. He would say something later. Tonight or tomorrow. He would say: I know what I said wasn't about primer. She'd say: I know. And they'd both know the shape of it and wouldn't need to go further unless they needed to, and probably they wouldn't need to.

Mateo came in, got a glass of water, looked at him.

"Are you sad?" Mateo said.

"No. Thinking."

"That's what sad looks like from outside."

Sibafuzi looked at his son.

"Does it."

"Sometimes." He drank his water. "Not always. Sometimes it looks different."

"What does happy look like from outside?"

Mateo thought about this seriously.

"Taller," he said.

He put his glass in the sink and went back to whatever he'd been building. Sibafuzi finished his tea. He felt, fractionally, taller.

Zara had been watching from the stairs. She always watched from the stairs when she was processing something. Both of them knew. Neither said anything about it.

Mateo had missed the whole thing, as Mateo often missed these things — not through inattention but through a kind of wholeness that made it impossible for him to hold two emotional registers at once. He'd been in the living room with his figure and a large cardboard box that had become, without any announcement, a fortress. Something complex and structural, with interior rooms and what appeared to be a watchtower made from a toilet paper roll, and the figure was in there

doing whatever figures did when they had the run of a fortress.

He brought the figure to dinner and put it beside his plate.

The table had the particular quiet of a family that has had a tense afternoon and is attempting, by collective unspoken agreement, to not still be having it.

Then Nali said, with the perfect timing she deployed like a scalpel:

"Eh, what's his name, this one?"

Mateo considered the question with full seriousness. He set his fork down. He looked at the figure. He appeared to consult it.

"He doesn't have one yet."

"How come?"

"I'm still finding out what he's like."

Nali pointed at him across the table — a gesture that combined pointing and acknowledging and approving all at once.

"That is sense, oh. You can't name a thing before you know it. Smart boy."

Mateo went back to his dinner looking quietly pleased.

Nobody else said anything. But something in the room shifted — small, warm, the kind of shift you don't name until after, you just feel it go and think: something is slightly better than it was. Nali had reminded everyone at the table, with one question, that they were still a family that could eat dinner together without it being a wound.

Sibafuzi looked at her across the table. She didn't look back. She was eating.

* * *

Marcus started the new high school on Thursday.

He'd been given the dress code the day before — Priya had looked it up, the website was specific: no hoodies in class, collar required, dark pants. He'd looked at the items laid out on his bed and felt the particular flatness of someone looking at the costume for a role they

didn't audition for.

He ate breakfast alone. Nali was up but she didn't talk at him and he was grateful. She put a plate in front of him and a glass of juice and didn't say anything about the first day, and he ate and thought about the bus route he'd walked twice yesterday just to know it.

Knowing the route was the only thing he could control. So he knew the route.

The school was smaller than he'd expected. One main building, one gym wing added in the eighties, portable classrooms in the back lot. It had the particular atmosphere of a school in a town whose best and brightest increasingly left at seventeen or eighteen and didn't come back — not run-down, not uncared-for, but with a quality of something in mid-sentence. Like it was still figuring out who it was for.

He arrived seven minutes before the first bell. Found the homeroom. Took a seat third row, one from the aisle.

The boy already sitting beside that seat looked at him and said, without preamble:

"Sit here if you want. Doesn't matter."

His name was Jamie. Marcus found this out when the teacher called the roll fifteen minutes later. He had the kind of face that looked like it was privately amused by almost everything — not unkindly, just constitutionally pleased by the world in a way that Marcus found both baffling and, against his better judgment, immediately likeable. He'd grown up in Collingwood, you could tell — not in the way that made people small but in the way that made them settled, like they'd made a decision about where they were and were getting on with it.

The English teacher kept getting the names wrong. Not the students' names — the authors'. They were doing the Canadian literature unit and he kept calling Munro Monroe, and Jamie kept making these small dry observations under his breath to nobody in

particular — or to the desk, or to the general principle of accuracy — and Marcus had to look away three times to avoid laughing out loud.

After the second time he looked away, Jamie said, still quietly, still to the desk:

"You don't have to do that."

"Do what?"

"Look away. He's been doing this since September."

Marcus looked at him. Jamie shrugged — not the dismissive shrug, the kind that meant: this is genuinely low stakes for me, I'm just reporting what I know.

He'd wanted to ask: how do you do that? Just not care whether things land? He'd been watching people for whom the room didn't cost anything and trying to understand the mechanism for years. Jamie seemed to have been born with it — or grown up in a place small enough that he'd just run out of room to be anxious.

He didn't ask. He just, carefully, let himself not look away the next time.

He came home just after four and went straight upstairs and closed his door. Came down for dinner. Said about three words through the whole meal, not rude, just closed. Everyone left him alone because they all knew, in their own ways, what that first day cost. The particular expenditure of walking into a room where everyone already had their people.

He lay on the floor of his room instead of the bed. The floor was different. Harder. He needed the harder thing.

He lay on the floor of his room with the lights off and finally let himself think about it.

He'd been not-thinking about it for months. Not the forgetting kind of not-thinking — the managed kind, the deliberate kind, where you know the thing is there and you choose the angle you approach it from, carefully, always slightly oblique, never straight on, because straight on is not something you're ready for yet.

But this room. This house. And Jordan's voice note on his phone, the one he had still not listened to.

He thought: I should have said something earlier. That was the actual thing. Not what he'd said to Terrell — that was a true thing, the thing needed saying, the only way to stop the particular escalation that was already underway. But he'd waited too long. He'd waited until the situation was already moving and then said the true thing and the true thing had been heard by everyone but delivered too late to not be connected to the movement of the situation.

He knew this. He'd known it from the next morning. He'd been sitting with it since.

Kwame wasn't his closest person. But Kwame was in the group, and the group mattered, and what had happened to Kwame — what nearly happened to Kwame — had to do partly with a chain of events that Marcus had information about and had held onto. Not because he was scared. Because the information was complicated, because the person he'd have had to go to was not straightforward, because the right moment for it kept being not yet and then it was too late.

He had told himself: I said the true thing when I could. That was what he had. He had said the true thing and the thing had landed and Kwame was okay, in the end. Not unmarked. But okay.

But Jordan.

Jordan didn't know, or did know, whether Marcus had known earlier. The voice note, sitting on his phone, held that information. Listening to it meant receiving whatever Jordan thought. Not listening to it meant: not yet. Means: he was managing it.

He was still managing it.

He thought about being fifteen. The specific fact of it. Not as bad as he was carrying it. But not nothing. Both things true at the same time, neither cancelling the other out. He hadn't found a way to say that out loud yet.

His situation was: it wasn't as bad as he was carrying it. But it wasn't nothing. Both things. At the same time.

He thought about Jordan. About the specific feeling of finding someone who didn't require you to perform anything. He hadn't known you could have that until he did. He hadn't understood, until this week, how much of what he did was performance.

He'd had that with Jordan. For three years. The room where nobody was trying. He didn't want to find out it had a condition on it.

He lay there for a while longer. Then he got up and went down for dinner and said about three words and that was enough for one day and he went back to bed and he slept, which surprised him, and when he woke up in the morning the house was quiet and the snow was still coming down and something had shifted enough that he thought: maybe soon.

Not yet. But soon.

Collingwood. Okay. New school. The homeroom with the smell of dry-erase markers and something else underneath, industrial cleaning fluid, the same as every school ever. The teacher who kept calling Munro Monroe. The boy. Jamie.

He didn't know what to do with Jamie. Not yet. Jamie was the kind of person who took up the exact right amount of space — not too much, not an absence — and Marcus had been standing next to that kind of ease his whole life wondering how you got there. Jordan had it too. Jordan could walk into a room and just be in it. He'd watched Jordan do it for three years and still couldn't reverse-engineer the mechanism.

He pressed his back against the floor and stared at the ceiling.

The ceiling had a small crack running diagonally from the light fitting to the window. Old house, old crack, probably fine. His dad would see it and start calculating. His dad saw every structural imperfection in every space they'd ever lived in and filed it somewhere behind his eyes and carried it. He could tell because of the

slight tension around Sibafuzi's jaw that appeared whenever they entered a new house and didn't fully leave for months. He'd never said this out loud to anyone.

He thought about Jordan. About the specific quality of Jordan's voice in the note — surprised at life, like always, like the world kept failing to match his expectations and he found it funny. Jordan who had forgiven him. Or maybe hadn't known to forgive him. Or had known and forgiven him without saying.

He didn't know which.

He got up. Went to the window. The church at the end of Bishop Street sat under the November sky like it had always been there and would always be there, which, actually. He thought about what was in it right now. What it held. Whether anything.

He went down for dinner and said about three words and that was fine and nobody pushed and he was, quietly, grateful for that.

What he didn't say: one person had been alright.

The last hour in the previous town he'd spent at the court.

Not playing. Just there. It was a Sunday morning and the court was empty and he sat on the bench at the sideline and looked at it for about an hour, which was the right amount of time and also not enough time, both at once.

He'd played on this court for three years. He could read it — the way the light came off the west backboard in the afternoon, the specific drag of the east service box where the surface had been repaired and the texture was subtly different, the branch of the tree at the north end that had grown in a way that occasionally meant a very specific arc of shot had to account for it. He knew this court the way you knew a place where something real had happened. The way you knew a face.

He didn't know who he was going to tell this to. He hadn't told anyone. He'd told his parents he was going to say goodbye to some people, which was technically true — he'd walked past three houses,

not stopped, and gone to the court instead. He felt bad about the not-stopping. He also knew that if he'd stopped, he'd have had to say things out loud that were not yet ready to be said out loud, and the not saying would have been worse than the not stopping.

Jordan lived two streets from the court.

He'd looked at the corner where you turned toward Jordan's house. He'd looked at it for a while. He'd thought about going. He'd thought: I could knock. I could stand on that doorstep and say the thing and then I would know whether he knows and I'd know whether I've been carrying this for no reason, which is the worst kind of carrying.

He didn't go.

He sat on the bench for the rest of the hour and watched the court be itself without anyone on it and then he went home and got in the car with his family and they drove north on the 400, past the city limits, past the familiar names, into the part of the highway that was just highway, gray and neutral and heading somewhere else.

He'd looked out the back window until he couldn't see anything he recognized.

His mother had turned around at that moment and looked at him and said nothing, just looked, with the expression that meant: I see you. He'd turned back to face forward. Mateo was already asleep beside him. The figure in Mateo's hand, the cape. The highway going.

He lay in his room in the new house and thought about the court and about the corner he hadn't turned toward and about Jordan's voice in the note, warm and surprised at life, the way it always was. He thought about Terrell, who had made the decision and taken the consequence and was fine. His first feeling had been good for him. His second feeling had been envy — not of the thing, but of the decision. The ability to just move.

He'd stayed. He'd not knocked. He'd made a decision by not making one, which was its own kind of deciding.

He didn't know yet whether it had been the right one. He was beginning to think it didn't have to be the right one. It just had to be one he could work forward from.

He turned his phone over on the floor.

Face up.

Not calling yet. Just face up.

He lay in his room that night and thought about Jamie and didn't know what to do with the thought so he just left it there, turning it over the way you turn over something you've found and aren't sure yet what it is.

* * *

Nali walked the garden on Friday morning, early, everyone else still inside.

It was a long garden for this kind of house — longer than the width of it, with a cedar fence along the back that someone had maintained properly until recently, two panels sagging now from a winter heave. The grass was long, the beds were gone to wild, and someone had planted a lilac against the back fence a long time ago that had grown into something enormous and leggy and was clearly doing whatever it wanted. She liked it. She'd prune it in the spring. But for now she left it.

She went slowly along the back edge, heel to toe, the way she walked when she was reading a place. Her hip was better in the morning than the evening — she'd negotiated with it as a fixed condition of being seventy-three, the same way she'd negotiated with everything that came with the number. You adjusted. You didn't stop.

She could see St. Andrew's steeple from here, just visible above the roofline at the end of the block. She'd noticed the church the moment they turned onto Bishop Street. She'd been to services at a Presbyterian church in Zambia for many years — not from conviction

exactly, but from community, from the particular function that a gathering place serves when you're a long way from the place that made you. She knew what a half-empty building felt like. She recognized the specific quality of a place that was still trying.

She'd lived in eleven houses in her life. In Zambia, in England for four years when Sibafuzi was small, in Zambia again, in two different cities since. She'd lived in houses that made her well and houses that hadn't, houses that fit her like something chosen and houses that were always a size wrong. She'd learned to read them early, not by their surfaces but by the quality of their silences.

England had been the fourth house. She'd gone for a man who turned out to be wrong in ways that took four years to become undeniable, which was the usual amount of time it took for that kind of wrongness to become undeniable. She'd come back from it with Sibafuzi and a clarity about herself she hadn't had before, which was not how she would have chosen to learn it but was how she learned it.

Sibafuzi had been seven when they left for England, eleven when they returned. Four years was not nothing at that age. Four years at seven to eleven was a whole era, a geological layer. He'd grown it there, on that island, in the particular grey light of the Midlands — a light that was nothing like Zambian light, which was the first thing she had noticed and the last thing she had stopped noticing. The light there was patient. It arrived slowly, like something being negotiated. She'd eventually understood it was just the latitude, but for years it felt like the weather was uncertain about committing to the day.

Sibafuzi had loved it. She remembered being surprised by this, then not surprised. He had the quality — she'd seen it in him already at seven — of entering a new place and treating it as the given facts of the world. He'd never said I miss home. He'd said, the first week: can we get a dog? He'd said: there's a boy in my class called Kevin who knows everything about trains. He'd said, in the grocery shop on the third day, looking at a shelf of things neither of them recognized: we

should try all of these.

She had tried them all. Some were terrible. Some were fine. Two were things she still bought occasionally, thirty years later, in shops that now stocked them in Lusaka. The world had caught up with her accidental discoveries.

The particular memory she came back to, the one she'd been turning over since they arrived on Bishop Street: a Saturday afternoon in December. Sibafuzi was nine, maybe ten. He had a friend from school — she couldn't remember the name now, one of the Kevins or a Daniel or a James, the parade of small English boys who came through their flat over those years. They were making something. A model, a city, something elaborate on the floor of the front room out of cardboard and bottle caps and things she recognised as having come from her recycling pile and therefore apparently been useful after all.

She'd been reading in the kitchen, and then she wasn't reading, she was listening to them. The sounds of children building something — that specific sound, not playing, building, which has a different quality. Measured. Considered. The sounds of small voices deciding.

She'd come to the doorway without knowing she was going to. She stood there and watched.

Sibafuzi had his tongue slightly out the way he did when he was concentrating. He was cutting something with scissors, carefully, not fast. The other boy was narrating what the city needed. Sibafuzi was making it.

He looked up and saw her in the doorway. He didn't stop cutting. He said: Mum, we need more bottle caps. Then he looked back down at his work.

She'd stood in that doorway for a moment after he looked away. Just stood there. Watching her son with his tongue out, carefully cutting something, at home in the world without knowing he was.

That was the moment. Not a dramatic one. Not a milestone. Just: *there he is*. That's who he is. Whatever comes, that's the person.

She'd gone back to the kitchen and found the rest of the bottle caps in the drawer where she kept things she hadn't yet decided whether to throw away — that drawer that every household has — and brought them through. Sibafuzi took them without looking up. *Thanks Mum*. Back to the work.

She'd stood in this new garden on Bishop Street, thirty-something years later, and thought: the drawer is the same. Different houses, different countries, different everything, but the drawer of things you haven't yet decided is in every house. She had one in Lusaka. She'd have one here in the back bedroom when she'd arranged herself. Some things were constant.

Sibafuzi still had that quality. Entering a new place and making it the given facts of the world. Standing at the kitchen window in his coat at six in the morning, looking out at a buried street, and not flinching from the fact of it. *Getting less so*, he'd said about the smell of other people. Not wishing it were already done. Just noting the direction.

She hoped he knew she'd been watching him do it for more than thirty years. She suspected he didn't. She would tell him, she thought. Not today. Before she left. She'd find the moment and say the thing.

This house was quiet in the way that meant it had been well loved. Not always maintained — you could see the deferred maintenance, the sagging fence, the window in the study that was just slightly out of true — but loved. A maintained house was a managed thing. A loved house had a different quality, something in how the rooms held themselves. This one had been lived in properly. People had argued here and made up here and had their children here, and it had absorbed all of it and was still standing.

She found the stone near the back fence. Flat, smooth, slightly warm from a patch of thin November sun. She turned it over in her

palm. Put it in her pocket.

Her mother had kept a stone. A river stone from the Zambezi, smooth and flat, the same grey as early morning. She'd carried it for forty years in her apron pocket, then her cardigan, then the small dish by the front door of the last house where she could reach it when she needed to. Nobody asked about it. It was just there. Part of her, the way a person's habitual gesture becomes part of how you see them.

After her mother died, Nali had looked for the stone. She'd looked everywhere, through the whole house, through every pocket and drawer and the dish by the door. Gone. Either lost in the move to the hospital or taken by someone inadvertently or just quietly gone the way some things went — not missing exactly, just finished. Her own small private grief had been that. Not the larger things, the furniture and the photographs. That stone.

She turned this one over in her palm. Flat. Smooth. Slightly warm in a patch of thin November sun, which had no business being warm but was. A November miracle.

She put it in her pocket.

Mateo had been watching Nali's stone since she found it. He'd tracked it: pocket on the first day, on the table beside her tea on the second morning, in her hand while she was reading in the armchair on the second evening, in her pocket again but a different pocket on the third day (he noticed because the pocket was on the other side), on the windowsill of her room once when he'd walked past and the door was open and she wasn't there. The stone had its own life now. It moved through the house the way the figure moved through the house. He thought Nali and the stone were probably doing the same thing he and the figure were doing — finding out what the new place was like. Checking in. Making sure it knew they were there.

She would find out, later, what this stone knew.

She'd known what she was looking for. She hadn't known she was looking until she found it.

She went back in. Put the kettle on.

She washed her hands at the kitchen sink, looking out at the garden.

Her mother had done this. Stood at a kitchen sink looking out at whatever was there. In the Mongu house it was a narrow strip of yard with three guava trees her mother had planted when she was first married and which by the time Nali was born were already old enough to be considered permanent features of the world. Her mother would stand at that sink and look at those trees the way Nali was standing at this window looking at this garden, which had an enormous lilac at the back that was doing what it wanted, and two silver maples visible above the fence line, and a small bird on the top of a fence post that had been there for several minutes without moving.

Her mother had said, standing at that sink, looking at those trees, when Nali was about seventeen: *You know what I notice about the people worth noticing?*

Nali had said what.

Her mother had said: *They're paying attention. That's all. They're just paying attention when everyone else has stopped.*

Nali had been seventeen. She'd filed it, the way you file things at seventeen — not in the place where you use things, somewhere further back, somewhere that turns out over the decades to be a more permanent location than you expected.

She was seventy-three now. She had been paying attention her whole life, and she kept finding her mother had been right. Not because paying attention was rare — there were plenty of people paying attention. But because there was a specific quality to the paying attention that mattered, which was: without agenda. Attention for its own sake. The attention that said: I want to see what's here. Not what I expected to find. What is actually here.

That was what she'd felt in Sibafuzi's kitchen on the first morning. Looking at her son standing at the window in his coat. Looking at his house beginning to become his. Looking at this family she had helped make, this whole specific complicated human outcome of decisions and accidents and luck, sitting around a coffee table about to open a stranger's box.

They're paying attention when everyone else has stopped.

She'd paid attention her whole life. She did not think she had been wrong to.

She dried her hands. Heard the others beginning to move above her, the sounds of morning in a house full of people, which were her favorite sounds. She put the kettle on.

Sibafuzi came through at seven. She could read him the way she always could — he was carrying something this week, had been since the move, maybe before. She'd watched him come back from the garage on Wednesday evening with that particular set to his shoulders that meant money, or something near money. Or something that money named.

She poured his tea and put it on the counter without being asked.

"How's the furnace," she said.

Long pause.

"Being assessed," he said.

"Mm."

"Could be fine."

"Could be."

They stood together in the kitchen, drinking their tea, watching the backyard be November. The lilac at the back fence moved slightly in the wind, ungoverned.

"Good house," she said. Not a question.

He looked at her. She was still looking at the garden.

"Yeah," he said.

"Good bones."

"Yeah."

"Give it time, Fuzi."

He nodded. She finished her tea. He finished his. Then he went to find his laptop and she started thinking about what to do with the eggs.

* * *

CHAPTER THREE

The Snow

It started Saturday night.

Nobody was expecting it — the forecast had said flurries, which was the forecast's way of covering itself without committing, and it had delivered not flurries but six hours of steady, purposeful snowfall. It arrived at nine in the evening and was still going when Sibafuzi checked at midnight and still going when Priya looked out at two and still going when Nali, who didn't sleep well in new houses and hadn't told anyone, sat at the kitchen table at four-thirty and watched it through the window above the sink.

Collingwood knew how to snow. That was the thing. The town sat at the base of the Niagara Escarpment on the southern shore of Georgian Bay and the geography meant that when winter arrived it arrived with intention — lake-effect squalls off the bay, the hills funnelling cold air down into the basin, the Blue Mountain ski runs already white up there in the dark. This wasn't that kind of dramatic snow, not the blizzard kind, not the kind that made the news. This was the patient kind. The kind that didn't announce itself and didn't stop.

By morning Bishop Street was buried. Eight inches at least, maybe more, still being calibrated by snowflakes. The parked cars were shapes. The gate posts were pillars. The gardens were unreadable. Even the lilac at the back fence had become something dignified and still, its unruly branches smoothed into sculpture. And at the end of the block, St. Andrew's Presbyterian sat under its white mantle with

the steeple rising clean above it, and in the early morning light with the whole street erased and silent, it looked for a moment exactly as it must have looked a hundred years ago when the building was new and the town was full and the parking lot didn't exist because nobody needed one.

Sibafuzi was already up. He'd been up at six, standing at the bedroom window with his tea, watching the garden be white. He'd tried to remember what snow had felt like when he was small — his mother pulling thick socks onto his feet in the house in England, the terraced street outside, the horse-chestnut tree in the small back garden with snow on its branches which had seemed impossible to him, nine years old and from Zambia, proof that the world could do things nobody had warned you about. He almost got there. He almost had the feeling.

Then he went downstairs to check the pipes.

The pipes were fine.

He stood in the utility room listening to them tick and settle in the way of well-made old pipes that knew their business, and was reassured, which was not nothing at six in the morning.

He went to the garage.

It was orderly in the way of a space that had been recently and thoroughly emptied — the previous family's hooks still on the wall, the pegboard with the shadowed outlines where tools had been. Someone had used this space with care. He could read the care in the pegboard, in the clean floor, in the workbench along the back wall that was exactly the right height, which was a detail only a person who worked at a bench got exactly right.

He had boxes in here. Moving boxes, not yet unpacked — things that were going to the garage eventually, sports equipment and seasonal items and the category of things that didn't fit anywhere else. He'd been meaning to go through them. He hadn't had the right state of mind for it until this moment, six in the morning in the first real

snow, standing in a cold garage that smelled like wood and oil and possibility.

He worked for two hours.

Not unpacking — he wasn't ready to fully commit, the boxes weren't sorted enough for that. He sorted. He made categories on the floor. He made a list on the back of a moving receipt of the tools he'd need to deal with the porch step properly. He found the box with the router he'd been looking for since Tuesday. He hung two hooks where there was a logical gap on the pegboard — not his tools yet, just the hooks, the framework for the eventual arrangement.

There was a crack in the garage floor. Not structural — superficial, the kind a house got after enough winters. He could repair it. He wouldn't today. But he looked at it and thought: I know what to do with this. And the knowing was a thing.

He stood in the cold garage with his breath visible in the air and his hands dirty from the moving boxes and thought about the house. His house. Not rented. The mortgage that was manageable, the furnace that was adequate, the garage with its pegboard and its workbench and its crack in the floor that he was going to fix in the spring.

He went back inside and made tea and stood at the window in his coat and watched the snow come down on Bishop Street, and he felt, for the first time since they'd signed the papers, that the house was not an ongoing problem to be managed. It was a project he was invested in. He knew what to do with it.

That was enough, for now.

* * *

Mateo knew before he even opened the curtain.

You could feel it. The way the world went quiet and soft when there was snow — a specific quality of silence, fuller than ordinary

silence, as though the snow had absorbed all the regular sounds and left only this: the particular stillness of a world temporarily paused. He'd felt it through sleep and had woken already knowing.

He pulled the curtain back.

There it was. The whole yard white. The fence posts wearing their small white hats. His own breath coming out as fog against the cold glass. And at the end of the street — he could see it from his window if he pressed close — the church on the corner with the snow on its steeple and its roof and its stone walls, looking like something from a card someone sends at Christmas.

He made a noise. Not a word. Just a noise that came from somewhere low in his chest and meant: this.

He grabbed the figure off the bedside table.

"You've got to see this," he told it, and held it up to the glass.

* * *

By lunchtime the house had its own weather going on inside it.

The satellite dish had a fault they'd been meaning to fix — hadn't been a priority in the chaos of moving — and now there was no TV reception. The internet was buffering on anything above text. Sibafuzi's phone kept dropping signal. He stood in three different spots in the house holding it up like a divining rod and determined that the best signal was at the top of the main staircase, which was fine if you wanted to make a call while looking like you were making a point.

Marcus came downstairs and figured all of this out in about ninety seconds and went back to his room, which Priya chose to interpret as neutral rather than hostile.

He lay on his floor with his headphones on and the music loud enough.

He'd made a playlist a month ago — the last week before they moved, sitting on the floor of his actual room, his real room, the one he'd lived in for three years with the crack in the ceiling and the radiator that made a sound on cold nights like a small animal trying to get in. He'd made the playlist like a document. Like evidence. Here is what I was listening to when I was in that place. Here is what that period of my life sounded like.

He'd added to it this week. Carefully. Not everything — some things felt wrong to add yet. But a few. The song he'd heard coming from Zara's room on the second night, through the wall, a song he didn't know and had looked up. Something Nali had been humming in the kitchen — not a song he could find, but he'd recorded three seconds of it on his phone, just the hum, just to have it. The sound of the snow on the window at three in the morning when he'd been awake and the house had been completely still.

He lay there and let the music organize the week. That was what music did — it didn't resolve things, it put things in order. The order wasn't rational, it wasn't chronological, it was something else, an emotional sequence, the music finding the shape of the thing you hadn't been able to shape yourself.

He had not called Jordan.

He was not calling Jordan today. Today was a snow day. Today was for lying on the floor with his headphones on in a house that still smelled a little like other people, going through the week in music, putting it in order.

He thought about that feeling. Being found by a song. He'd known it since he was eleven, standing in the kitchen while his dad played something from his phone and the song had done the thing that songs occasionally did when everything was right: it had explained something that hadn't been explainable before. You didn't go looking for it. It arrived. And afterwards you were different.

He put a new song on the playlist. Didn't name it. Just let it sit at the end of the document, the current chapter.

Outside, the snow kept coming. He could feel it through the floor — the specific quiet of a buried house, the world reduced, contained. He lay there and let it be that.

After a while he took the headphones off and went downstairs.

Not for any reason. Just to be in the house with people.

She'd tried to work. She had a deadline on Tuesday, something she could access from anywhere, which was supposed to be a feature. She sat at the kitchen table with her laptop for forty minutes and then gave up because she couldn't hold the thread of it — the thing that connected her to the work that needed doing — and she didn't know whether that was the snow or the house or Marcus or Sibafuzi or the list on her phone or just the accumulated weight of two months of a plan that was now the reality and had to be lived in rather than planned.

She made food instead. This was what she did when she didn't know what else to do with her hands — she made food nobody had asked for and put it places where people would find it. She made two kinds of soup. She started a loaf of bread.

She made soup because she had potatoes and half an onion and a tin of something that turned out to be tomatoes, and because making soup was the activity that most closely resembled work without being work, which was what she needed today.

She made the soup and while it was simmering she reorganized the spice cupboard, which was the new house's spice cupboard and currently had her spices jumbled in with the previous family's spice residue — the tail ends of jars, the things they hadn't taken, the specific archaeology of another household's cooking habits. She sorted through it. Some things she kept, because useful was useful. Some things she didn't recognise and set aside for later research. One jar had no label — she opened it and it smelled like the memory of

something. She kept it.

She wiped the shelves. She put her own things back in the order she kept them: the ones she used daily in the front, the occasional ones behind, the things she'd bought once for a specific recipe and hadn't used since at the back where they could live out their days.

The new spice cupboard looked like hers now.

She stepped back and looked at it.

That was the thing about houses. You claimed them a cupboard at a time. A shelf, a corner, a drawer. Each small act of arrangement saying: I live here. This is organized for my way of doing things. The house understood this, she thought — it didn't resist, it received. Each thing placed was a small conversation between her and the house, and the house said yes, and gradually the house was theirs.

She went back to the soup.

She tasted it. It needed more time.

She stood at the window while it cooked and watched the snow and thought about the thing she needed to write — the actual work, the article that was due Tuesday, not the kind of piece she wrote by routine but the harder kind, the kind that needed her to be somewhere specific in herself. She'd been trying to get to that place for a week. The move had knocked her sideways. She needed one good morning, the chair, the right conditions.

Tomorrow, she thought. Her notebook tonight. Tomorrow, early, the piece.

She was making a deal with herself and she intended to honor it.

The soup was ready.

She called up the stairs. Heard the specific sounds of each person registering food — the particular acoustic signature of her family, every one of them distinct, all of them hers.

Mateo noticed that his mom touched things in the new house like she was asking permission. The counter, the cabinet handles, the edge of the windowsill — each one briefly, her hand just resting for a

second, like she was introducing herself. He thought that was probably the right way to enter a place. He'd been doing the same thing with the figure. Touching it to new surfaces. Letting it know where it was.

Nali was reading in the armchair. She'd arranged it in the corner of the living room where the window and the bookshelf met, so she could see both the door and the yard simultaneously — Sibafuzi had a memory of her doing this in every house he could recall, always the corner that let her see both the door and the outside at once. He'd asked her about it once, when he was about twelve. She'd said: I like to know what's coming and what's already here. He hadn't fully understood it until he had children of his own.

Mateo came and sat on the floor beside her chair. He didn't ask permission. He just came and sat, which was the relationship they had.

She put her book down.

He was holding the figure. He'd had it since the first morning — the bent-caped thing he'd been naming and watching and giving the views of each new room. He'd been very deliberate about this. He hadn't named it yet. He'd told Nali, the first evening: *I'm still finding out what he's like*. He was still finding out.

"Can I ask you something?" he said.

"You can ask me anything," she said. She meant this, fully, which Mateo knew and had always known and was part of why he came and sat beside her chair.

"Did you miss your house? When you moved?"

She considered this. Mateo's questions deserved consideration. He asked the ones that were actually worth answering.

"Yes," she said. "Every time."

"Every time?"

"I've moved many times."

"Did it stop?"

She looked at the window. The snow, the maples, the far-off steeple of St. Andrew's just visible above the roofline.

"The missing stops," she said. "The knowing it stays."

He turned the figure over in his hand. Looking at the cape. The bent arms.

"What does that mean?"

"It means," she said slowly, finding it as she said it, "that after a while you stop aching for the other house. But you don't forget it. It becomes part of you. Like a room inside you that you can go into. The other houses — they're rooms I can still walk around in."

He looked up at her.

"In your head?"

"In my — yes. Somewhere in here." She put a hand on her chest.

He thought about this for a long time. The snow came down. The house settled around them.

"So every house makes you bigger," he said.

She looked at him.

"Yes," she said. Quietly. "That's exactly it. Every house makes you bigger."

Mateo nodded. Filed it. Turned back to the window.

She picked up her book. But she held it without opening it for a moment.

Every house makes you bigger.

She'd said it and he'd understood it immediately, this six-year-old, because he was the kind of person for whom things either made complete sense or made no sense at all, with very little territory between. She had lived seventy-three years to understand what she'd just said. He'd gotten there in nine seconds by asking the right question.

She opened her book. But she was smiling.

Mateo was Mateo. He'd converted a new cardboard box into something architectural.

Zara had been quiet all morning. Priya had checked on her twice. Got I'm fine both times in its two different registers. The third time, Zara wasn't in her room.

"Zara?"

Nothing. Then from somewhere above: a scraping sound. Then a soft thump, controlled, careful.

Priya looked at the ceiling. Then at the narrow back staircase.

The house was doing something in the afternoon.

It wasn't a sound. Or it was sounds, but not alarming ones — the settling, the creak, the pipes, the specific voice of an old house in its first real freeze with new people in it. More like — a quality of the air. Priya had been feeling it since morning and hadn't been able to name it.

She'd been trying to work and failing, which was her own fault and she knew it. The deadline was real and the work was accessible and there was no material reason she couldn't sit at the kitchen table and do it. The material reasons were not the issue. The issue was that she kept stopping and listening. Not for anything in particular. Just — listening to the house.

She'd lived in enough houses to know that they had personalities. Not mystically — she wasn't a person who dealt in mysticism — but practically. A house that had been unhappy had an edge to it. A house that had been well loved had a quality of giving, as if the walls remembered being given to and were inclined to continue. This house had that quality. Whatever had been here before them — and something had been here, she'd felt it from the first step through the door — it was generous. It did not resist them. It was not waiting for them to leave.

She'd told Sibafuzi on Night Two, lying in the dark listening to the pipes: *this house is on our side*. He'd been quiet for a moment. Then he'd said: *yes. I thought I was imagining it*. She said: *you weren't*. She heard him nod.

She was thinking about that now, listening to the sounds above her. Zara in the attic again — she'd heard her go up twice already this week, the specific sounds of the narrow stair, the attic hatch on its well-maintained hinges. Whatever Zara was looking for up there, she was patient about it. She'd find it on the right day. Priya trusted Zara to know her own pace.

The snow outside. The house around her.

She put the laptop away. She'd get it done tomorrow. Today the house needed her to be in it, and she was going to be in it.

She picked up her phone.

She went to Deepa's name. Deepa's last message: a photo from the red kitchen, the one with the yellow curtains, the wooden table that had been there since before either of them lived in it. A photo of a full glass of wine and the text: *miss you. just that.*

That had been the last message — months ago now. Priya had written four replies and sent none of them. Not because she didn't have things to say. Because the things she had to say required more than she could shape on a moving day, a packing day, a driving day, a first-night-in-a-new-house day. She'd been waiting for a day when she had enough of herself to give the conversation what it needed.

She started typing now.

Deepa. I've been meaning to call. This week has been—

She stopped.

The house was doing its thing around her. The sound of Zara somewhere above. The specific quality of the air, the house that was on their side.

She couldn't do it in a text. That was the truth of it. Deepa deserved the voice version, the real version, the one where Priya could say: this is what it's like and this is what I've been thinking and I miss the red kitchen and I need to actually talk to you, not type at you.

She put the phone down.

Thursday, she thought. I'll call her Thursday. A real call. Not a half-thing in a snow day afternoon.

She'd been telling herself Thursday since before they left.

She believed it this time.

* * *

The attic hatch came down easier than she'd expected.

She'd come back to the narrow stair three times this week — once on Tuesday evening, once on Thursday, once on Friday morning when the back corridor was quiet. Each time she'd stood at the bottom looking up at the painted door, doing the thing she did when she was deciding something. Not deciding yet. Just being with the decision. Letting it develop. By Saturday morning she knew.

The ladder was fold-down, built into the hatch, the hinges well-maintained in a way that suggested someone had been up here regularly and cared that it worked. She climbed carefully, both hands, and her head came through into a different kind of cold — dry and still, smelling of dust and something older underneath the dust, like the smell of paper and time.

She waited for her eyes to adjust.

Bigger than she'd thought. The roof sloped on both sides down to where the eaves began, making it a room with two low walls and a high middle, and it was properly floored — boards, not just rafters — which meant someone had put work into it, had made it into a usable space. One small skylight at the far end, covered in snow now, letting in a white diffused light. She could see the outline of things: stacked chairs with blankets over them, boxes along the walls with tape gone yellow, the general accretion of a house's life over decades.

She went carefully to the far end. Behind the chairs there was a panel that didn't sit right. You'd miss it if you weren't looking. She was looking.

She moved the chairs — solid dining chairs, heavier than they looked — and got down on her knees and looked at the panel. Fitted into the eave properly on the left side, but on the right held only by pressure, set into a groove rather than nailed. A slight difference in how it sat. A seam instead of a solid edge.

She pressed it on the right side. It gave. Swung inward, hinged, opening onto a shelf built right into the gap of the eave. Levelled, fitted. Deliberate. Not a forgotten space. A chosen one.

She stopped.

The shelf was levelled and fitted, purpose-built into the eave gap with the same care she'd found in the built-in shelves downstairs. Whoever made this had made it the same way — not in a hurry, not improvising. They'd thought about what would go here and built accordingly.

On it: a wooden box, lid fitted tight, no lock. It sat in the center of the shelf as if it had been placed and then considered and then left exactly where it was. Around it, arranged with intention — each item given its own space, not crowded:

A photograph folded in half, face inward. The fold was old — the paper had set itself into that shape, was comfortable there, didn't want to open.

A small medal on a faded ribbon. The ribbon had been a color once; it was the color of a long time ago now. The medal itself was bronze, the size of a large coin, with a figure engraved on its face that she couldn't make out clearly in this light. On the back, she tilted it toward the skylight: words, worn smooth by decades of handling, readable only at an angle. *In recognition of service*. A year. Someone had touched this many times.

A cassette tape in a cracked plastic case. No label on the tape itself — just the brown magnetic ribbon visible through the clear window. The plastic case had cracked on one corner and been held together by what appeared to be decades of hope. The paper insert had been

handled so many times it had gone soft, the way paper goes soft when it has been folded and unfolded and reread many times over many years. She could see it had once had writing on it. The writing was gone now except for one faint mark — a shape that might be a letter or might just be two lines someone drew without thinking.

And the drawing. Last. Done in blue crayon on paper gone as soft as cloth.

She picked it up. She could see it had a figure in it, a figure with a cape — the cape extending from its shoulders all the way to the ground, so the figure was either flying or standing very still and either way going somewhere. But that wasn't all of it. In the bottom corner of the drawing, so small she nearly missed it: a yellow square. A house. And in one of the house's windows, a small yellow circle with lines radiating outward. Not the sun in the sky. The sun inside the house, shining out through the glass.

The light coming from within.

She held the drawing carefully. She carried everything down the ladder one-handed, and she didn't drop a thing.

* * *

CHAPTER FOUR

The Box

She came into the living room holding the box out in front of her with both hands.

She'd thought about how to do this on the way down the ladder — not what to say, there wasn't a right way to say it, but how to carry it. How to arrive. How to make the moment feel like what it was: something that required everyone.

Nali looked up first. Then Priya from the hallway. Then Mateo, who looked at the box and then at Zara's face and decoded, from her face alone, that this was serious — the kind of thing that required you to set down whatever you were doing and be present.

"Where'd you get that?" Priya said.

"Attic. Hidden shelf behind a panel in the eave. Someone put all this here on purpose."

Priya came fully into the room. She was still holding a dish towel from the soup.

Zara set the box on the coffee table and laid everything else out beside it: the photograph, the medal, the cassette, the drawing. She'd found she couldn't stop looking at the drawing — down here in the light she could see it properly. A child's figure with a cape, done in blue crayon, flying or falling or maybe just going somewhere fast. The paper as soft as cloth, folded and unfolded many times over many years.

The family gathered around.

Nobody spoke for a moment. They stood or sat at the edges of the coffee table looking at the things on it, the snow light coming through the window, the items laid out like something that had been waiting a very long time to be seen.

Nali reached for the medal first. She picked it up by the ribbon, turned it slowly. The bronze face — a figure seated at a table with others, heads bent toward each other, the specific posture of people engaged in something that mattered. On the back she tilted it toward the window and moved it until the light caught the worn lettering: *In recognition of service*. A year. Something had been done, over time, that had been worth recognizing.

She set it back down carefully. Her face neutral. Something moving behind the neutral.

Priya picked up the cassette. Turned it over. Shook it slightly — the instinct of someone trying to get a machine to remember it had a job to do.

"No label," she said.

"No," Zara said.

She set it down. Looked at it.

Marcus had appeared in the doorway at some point — nobody had tracked when, he was just there, leaning his shoulder against the door frame with his hands in his pockets. Not quite in the room. He was looking at the photograph.

It was still folded. Face inward, the fold old and settled.

He reached out and touched the edge of it. Then didn't open it. Left it.

"How come it's folded?" he said.

"They put it that way," Zara said.

"But why."

She looked at the photograph. The old fold, the paper comfortable in that shape.

"Maybe some things you don't want face-up all the time," she said.

Mateo had been very still. He'd been still since Zara came in, which was unusual for Mateo — stillness was something he deployed for important occasions. He was looking at the drawing.

He reached for it. Not asking. Just reached.

He picked it up and held it the way he held things he wanted to understand — two hands, slightly raised, the way you hold something that might be delicate. The blue crayon figure with its cape. The small yellow house in the corner with its inside-out sun.

He looked at it for a long time.

"The light's going out," he said.

Everyone looked at him.

"The sun in the window. It's going out through the glass. Out of the house. Not in." He looked up. "Like the house is the one with the light in it."

The room sat with that.

Nali reached out and put her hand flat against the wall beside her chair. Just for a moment. The way she did.

"Mm," she said. Very quietly. Like something had been confirmed.

"Open it, my dear."

She was about to when she heard it — the specific sounds from the garage that meant Sibafuzi was wrapping up. She went to the hall doorway instead.

They heard his footsteps in the garage — the specific pattern of someone wrapping up work, the sorting sounds, the step up into the utility room. Then silence for a moment. Then his footsteps on the kitchen floor.

"Fuzi."

He came through from the garage in the padded jacket he wore out there, expecting lunch. What he got instead was his family arranged around a coffee table with their faces arranged around a box.

He looked at the group of them. Then at the things on the coffee table. He went still in the way he went still when processing something he hadn't prepared for.

"What's all this," he said.

"Zara found it." Priya gestured at the attic. "A hidden shelf."

He came into the room properly. Stood at the edge of the table. Looked down.

The drawing, face-up. The medal. The cassette. The photograph, still folded. The box, open, a cloth-covered book sitting inside it.

He looked at each item. His face was doing the thing it did when he was taking inventory — careful, specific, unhurried. He bent slightly to look at the photograph without touching it.

"Has anyone opened it?" he said.

"Not yet," Priya said. "The photograph is still folded. The book is still closed."

He nodded slowly. He looked at the drawing. The crayon figure with the bent cape. The small house in the corner with the circle-and-rays.

"Mateo read it," Nali said, in the quiet that meant: correctly.

Sibafuzi looked at Mateo.

Mateo was watching him with both hands on the figure in his lap.

"The light's going out," Mateo said again, for him. "Through the window. Not in."

Sibafuzi looked at the drawing again. Then at his son.

"How d'you know that?" he said.

Mateo looked at the drawing.

"Because of where the house is," he said. "The house is behind him. The light is from inside. He's taking it with him, not bringing it." He paused. "That's the hero part. He's going somewhere and he's taking the light."

Nobody spoke.

He took his jacket off and sat down on the sofa. Same as yes.

Priya reached into the box and lifted out the book.

It was a journal. Dark blue cloth cover, worn pale at the spine. Elastic closure gone slack with age. She lifted it out — lighter than it looked, and also heavier, the weight of something read many times and loved many times. The cloth was smooth under her fingers.

One other thing in the box: a letter. Folded once. Nothing on the outside. Not addressed, not named. Waiting.

She put the letter aside. Held the journal.

"Should we open it?" Zara said.

"That's the question," Priya said.

A moment. Everyone looking at the thing in her hands.

"It was left here on purpose," Zara said. "Someone wanted it to be found."

"We don't know that," Marcus said.

He still had the glass of water he'd come down for. Still hadn't drunk any of it.

"The panel was painted to match the wall," Zara said. "They hid it. But they didn't lock it."

"Maybe they just forgot it."

"They left a letter with it. You don't leave a letter with something you forgot."

Silence. Marcus leaned his shoulder against the door frame, not quite committing to the room.

Nali reached out and put her hand on top of the journal, over Priya's hands.

"Open it. If it was meant to be private, it wouldn't be here. Whatever it is — it's been waiting a long time. Give it a chance to be read."

Priya opened it.

First page — no title, no name. Just a year. The ink faded at the edges. And below it, in the handwriting of someone very young, still working out how letters went:

* * *

November

Tuesday

today was good

* * *

"That's it?" Zara said.

Nali made a small satisfied sound.

"Turn the page, eh."

Priya turned the page.

* * *

Thursday

my dad carried me on his shoulders at the market so I could see over all the people.

I could see everything from up there.

I think thats what it feels like to be tall.

* * *

Nobody said anything for a moment. The snow pressed its quiet against the windows.

"How old is he?" Sibafuzi said.

"Six, maybe," Priya said. "From the handwriting."

He nodded slowly, looking at the journal in her hands.

Marcus had drifted off the door frame without anyone marking the moment. He was on the floor now, back against the sofa, knees up, the glass of water beside him. He hadn't announced the decision. He'd just made it.

Nobody pointed it out.

* * *

THE JOURNAL

Priya just started reading. The room needed someone to go first and she was holding the thing.

* * *

Saturday

we watched cartoons this morning for a long time.

Spider-Man saved a whole building full of people and didn't even tell anyone it was him.

My mum was making breakfast and the smell came through and Spider-Man was on the TV and I didn't want it to stop.

I don't know how to say it. I just didn't.

* * *

The fire that Sibafuzi had coaxed to life from the last wood in the garage popped once and settled.

Mateo had gone very still. He was sitting on the rug with the figure in his lap and his hands around it, completely still, with the expression he wore when something arrived before he'd prepared a response to it.

* * *

Monday

I asked my dad how Spider-Man gets to work.

He said he doesn't.

I said how does he have money then.

My dad laughed for a really long time.

I didn't know what was funny but I liked it.

* * *

Sibafuzi made a sound — the kind that comes out before you've decided whether to let it. Not quite a laugh, the cousin of a laugh. His hand went up slightly like he was going to cover his mouth and then didn't.

Marcus was watching him from the floor. The expression on his face was the one he wore when he caught his dad being a person — not a dad, not a function, but an actual person who found things funny — and didn't quite know what to do with it.

Wednesday
we moved.

I have a new bedroom now.

It's smaller than my old one. It smells different. I don't know how to explain the smell. Like someone else's house, which I suppose is what it is.

I counted the steps from my room to the bathroom. It's seven. My old house was four.

I keep getting it wrong in the night.

* * *

The fire gave a small sound. Not dramatic. Just present.

Nobody spoke for a moment.

Priya kept reading.

* * *

Friday

I found a mark on the wall behind my door.

Somebody had drawn a small figure there. Not like a good drawing. Just a stick person. With a circle head and lines for arms.

I think a child made it. I don't know whose child.

I keep thinking about them. Did they know, when they drew it, that someone would find it one day.

Maybe they just wanted to leave something.

* * *

September, a year later

* * *

Wednesday

my mum explained something today that I thought I already knew.

I thought being brave meant not being scared.

She said no. She said brave was being scared and doing it anyway.

I said what if you can't.

She said then you try again tomorrow. That's what brave looks like.

I thought about it for a long time after dinner.

* * *

The room went quiet in a different way. Not the waiting quiet of before but the kind that happens when something lands somewhere it wasn't expected and has to be absorbed.

Nali hadn't moved since Priya started. She was in her chair with her hands folded in her lap and that expression she wore when she was being confirmed in something — not surprised, never surprised, but confirmed. Like the world was still bothering to prove things she'd always known.

"His mum knows something," Zara said.

"Mmm." Nali nodded once, slowly. "That woman knows."

The fire settled. Outside the snow came down in that patient way that suggested no plans to stop.

* * *

Sunday

I watched my dad fix the sink today.

He had to lie under it on the floor, I could only see his legs.

He was talking to himself and sometimes saying words I'm not allowed to say.

Then he said come here, and I went, and he gave me the torch and told me which bit to point it at.

We fixed it together he said.

I mostly just held the torch but I think that counts.

* * *

Marcus laughed. A proper one — caught off guard, out before he'd decided to let it go. He put his hand up like it wasn't him, which made Zara laugh, which made Mateo laugh because the other two were. The room was warm with it, the kind of warmth you can't manufacture.

Sibafuzi was looking at his hands in his lap. Something had happened to his face that wasn't visible if you weren't watching for it.

"My dad did that," he said. Quiet. Talking to his hands. "Come hold the torch. Every time. Said it like it was the most important job going."

The laughter settled. The room held what it held.

"Was it?" Zara said.

He thought about it. Really thought — she could see him going back somewhere, finding the actual answer.

"Yeah," he said. "Actually. Yeah, it was."

* * *

Friday

there is a boy at school called Devon who said his dad could beat up my dad.

I said my dad wasn't like that.

He said what do you mean.

I didn't know how to explain it.

My dad isn't the kind of person that beats people. He's the kind that fixes things.

I think those are different kinds of strong.

I think mine is the better kind but I didn't know how to say it to Devon so I just said whatever and went in.

* * *

Priya went to say something but Nali got there first:

"Ah!"

Just that one sound. Not surprised. Just — there it was. As if the boy had confirmed something she'd been waiting for him to confirm. She was shaking her head slightly, something private happening on her face.

Thursday

there's a teacher at school called Mr Hargreaves.

He's old. He has a beard that's mostly grey and he walks slow.

He stays after school every day. I know because I forgot my bag once and went back and he was still there at his desk. He didn't notice me. He was just reading.

I don't think anyone stays behind to tell him he did a good job.

I think he just does it anyway.

* * *

Zara had her pen hovering above her notebook but hadn't written anything for the last three entries.

She was just listening.

* * *

Two years on

* * *

Monday

I came home and my mum was crying at the table.

I didn't know what to say so I didn't say anything.

I went upstairs and got my big soft blanket and brought it down and put it round her.

She held on for a long time.

She didn't say what was wrong.

I didn't ask.

I think sometimes you don't have to know what's wrong to help.

* * *

Priya stopped reading.

She stopped because she felt it and because the room needed a moment before anyone spoke. She sat there with the journal open on that entry.

Sibafuzi was looking at the floor.

Nali reached over — she was in the armchair and Priya was on the sofa and she had to lean — and put her hand on Priya's knee. One moment, there and then gone, but it landed.

"Read on," she said softly. "He's not finished yet."

* * *

Saturday

today was one of those days.

Mum and Dad were both in the kitchen at the same time.

Dad was fixing the shelf that's been broken for weeks.

Mum was at the table reading with her tea.

I sat in the doorway on the floor.

They didn't know I was there.

I just wanted to stay.
Didn't want to talk or ask for anything.
Just that.
Just them.

* * *

The fire popped once. Outside the snow came down in that slow patient way that meant it wasn't done yet, wasn't close to done.

Mateo had ended up against Nali's side at some point without anyone tracking when. The figure was in his hand but hanging loose, forgotten. He was looking at her the way he looked at her when she was about to say something he wanted to hear.

"Why'd he sit in the doorway?" he said.

"Because he wanted to be near them," Nali said.

"Why didn't he just go in?"

She thought about it — really thought, not performing the thinking but doing it.

"Sometimes you don't want to change what you're looking at, you hear me? You're scared if you go in it becomes just a normal thing. And you don't want normal right then. You want to hold it exactly like it is, just a little bit longer."

Mateo sat with that the way he sat with things — seriously, completely, without the hurry to resolve it.

"I do that," he said.

"I know," said Nali. "Me too, my dear. Me too."

Marcus was watching his grandmother. He was on the floor three feet from the armchair and he was watching her sideways, through a slightly different angle of his head. He looked away before anyone caught him. Or thought he had.

* * *

Nobody moved for a moment. The fire. The snow outside. The specific stillness of a room in which something true has been said.

Marcus was quiet for a long time. Then:

"I did that." His voice even. "Last Sunday. At the court. Sat on the bench and didn't want to get up. Not because I was tired." He paused. "I just didn't want to be the thing that ended it."

Nobody spoke.

He looked at the journal in Priya's hands. Back at the ceiling.

"Keep going," he said.

* * *

Wednesday

I asked my mum who her hero was.

She said what do you mean.

I said like on TV. But a real one.

She thought for a long time. She said there was a woman on her street when she was little. A neighbour.

She used to sit with the old people and just listen to them. When nobody else would.

I said was she famous.

Mum said no. She said most of them aren't.

I said how do you know who they are then.

She said you feel it. When someone's doing something that's costing them something and they do it anyway — you feel it. Even when you're small. You always know.

* * *

The room went completely still.

Marcus said it quietly. Half to himself, the way he tried things out:

"When someone's doing something that costs them something and they do it anyway."

Like he was deciding where to put it.

Sibafuzi looked at him. Marcus didn't look back. But the room felt it — that shift when a sentence lands and everyone knows it and nobody marks it out loud, because marking it would make it smaller than it was.

"Keep going," Marcus said.

Priya looked at him.

"Please," he said.

She looked at her fifteen-year-old, on the floor of this new house with the glass of water he'd technically come down for, asking please for the first time in possibly weeks. She felt something she didn't have a name for on short notice.

She kept going.

Tuesday

Mum got a letter today.

She read it at the table and then sat very still for a long time.

I watched her from the hallway.

I didn't know if I should go in.

After a while she folded it up and put it in her pocket and started making dinner and everything was normal.

I still don't know what was in the letter.

I wonder if knowing would help or just give me something new to carry.

* * *

Zara looked up from her notebook.

Sibafuzi was very still. The fire behind him going steady. He was looking at the book in Priya's hands.

Priya was quiet for a moment. "The writing's changed," she said softly. "He's older here. You can feel it."

Nobody said anything to that. It didn't need anything.

Priya read on.

Wednesday

my parents have a way of talking in the kitchen late at night.

I can hear them from my room. Not the words — just the sound.
The back and forth of it. Sometimes one of them laughs, quietly, like
they're trying not to wake us up.

I used to get up and try to hear what they were saying.

Now I just listen to the sound of it.

It's the same sound wherever we live.

That's the part I take with me.

* * *

The room was very still. Outside the snow had been going for hours
in that patient way.

Nali had both hands around her mug.

Marcus had come slightly closer to the group without anyone
marking when. He was still on the floor, still by the door frame, but
the glass of water was on the floor beside him now. He wasn't
pretending to be leaving anymore.

Priya read on.

* * *

Friday

My dad has a way of doing things.

Like when he fixes something in the house he doesn't say anything
after. He just puts his tools away and goes and has his tea.

He doesn't make it into a thing.

I noticed it for the first time today.

The dripping tap. He fixed it before anyone asked him to.

And then he just — went.

There's something about that.

Doing the thing and not needing anyone to see you do it.
I want to be like that one day.

* * *

The room had a particular quality of quiet that it had been developing over the last hour. Not silence — you could hear the fire, the snow outside. But a kind of attending. Everyone in their position, leaning in without leaning in.

Marcus, from the door frame.

"What did his mum do?" he said. "With the letter."

"What do you mean?" Zara said.

"She put it in her pocket. She didn't tell him. He's been wondering about it since."

The room sat with that.

"Maybe she was protecting him," Priya said.

"Maybe she just didn't know how to say it yet," Sibafuzi said.

Marcus was quiet for a moment.

"She fixed dinner though," he said. "She didn't — she fixed dinner."

Priya read on.

Saturday

my dad came to pick me up from school today.

He was early.

I came out and he was just standing there. Not on his phone or anything. Just looking at the door, waiting.

When he saw me his face did something.

I don't know what to call it.

* * *

Mateo had moved closer to Priya without anyone noticing. He was against her side now, her arm around him, both of them looking at the

book.

Nali had the stone out of her pocket. She was holding it in her palm.

"Read on, my dear," she said quietly.

* * *

Tuesday

I've been thinking about what makes someone good.

Not good like at football or maths. Good like a person.

I think it might be the small things.

Not the big ones. The big ones are easy to see.

The small ones are the ones nobody's watching for.

Sunday

my dad taught me to tie a proper knot today.

Not a bow. A real knot. A reef knot. He said sailors use it.

He showed me three times. Slowly. His hands over mine the third time.

He said: you'll use this your whole life.

I don't know if that's true. But I hope so. I want to have things from him that I carry.

* * *

Thursday

I don't know how to write this.

My dad did something today that was wrong.

Not big wrong. Small wrong. He said something to my mum that wasn't fair.

He knew it wasn't fair. You could tell.

And then he just went to the other room.

I kept waiting for it to be okay.

It took a long time.

At dinner I kept looking at him like something about him would be different.

He looked the same.

I always thought my dad was one kind of person.

I think maybe everyone is more than one kind.

I don't know if that's good or just true.

maybe it's the same thing.

* * *

Nali set the journal on the arm of her chair when Priya finished.

The quiet after that entry was a different shape to the others. Not warmth, not laughter — something more honest. The kind of quiet that happens when a child tells the truth about a parent and everyone in the room who is a parent feels it land.

Sibafuzi had his hand over his mouth.

"Must've been hard to write that," Zara said. "About his dad. When you can see in every other bit how much he loves him."

"Why?" Marcus said.

"Because — you know. One thing doesn't cancel out the other. But still."

"That's the thing though, isn't it," Marcus said. "You don't stop. Loving someone. Just because they do something wrong."

The room sat with that.

Marcus seemed to become aware of what he'd said and where he'd said it. He looked down at the edge of the rug and started picking at a loose thread with his thumbnail.

Sibafuzi looked at his son. Really looked — the back of his head, the set of his shoulders, fifteen years old and carrying something he hadn't put down yet. Then he looked at the journal. Then at the middle distance where you look when you're trying to get something straight.

"He kept writing though," Sibafuzi said. "Whatever happened. He just kept writing."

"He did," Priya said.

She ran her thumb across the cover of it. All these entries. All these days.

"He just kept writing," she said again.

The room was quiet in the way it had been getting quieter all evening — the specific hush of people who have been somewhere together and are still in it.

Mateo was fully asleep. He'd slid at some point from upright to sideways, the figure still in his hand, his face turned toward the fire. The small house in Collingwood around him, the snow outside.

"He'd write that," Zara said quietly, looking at him. "If someone gave him a journal." She thought about it. "Today was good. I held a figure. The snow came."

Priya looked at her daughter. The notebook. The pen still in her hand.

"You would too," she said.

"Mine would be longer," Zara said. Which was true and they both knew it.

"Good," Priya said.

She picked up the journal one more time. Turned it over in her hands. All these entries. All these days. Someone who started at six and kept going.

Outside the snow had perhaps eased slightly — it was hard to tell, the world beyond the window still so uniformly white. Nobody in the room was checking.

Zara looked at the fire. At the journal. At her family arranged in the positions they'd drifted to over the course of the afternoon — Nali in her corner, Sibafuzi and Priya on the sofa, Marcus on the floor like he'd been there all day. Mateo asleep against Nali's side, the figure still in his hand.

"Same time tomorrow?" Zara said.

Nali looked at her.

"Same time tomorrow, eh."

* * *

They were last to bed.

Not unusual. The children were asleep, Nali was asleep — she'd gone to bed an hour ago with the quiet finality of someone who had done enough for one day and knew it. Priya and Sibafuzi sat at the kitchen table with the last of the tea and the journal between them and the particular quality of nighttime silence that belonged to them specifically, the silence they'd been accumulating and refining for seventeen years.

"He was just a kid," Sibafuzi said. He'd been looking at the journal.

"He was six when he started."

"Writing things down at six." He looked at the cover. The cloth worn pale at the spine. "Someone gave him the language for it young."

"His dad," Priya said. "The one where he was up on his father's shoulders at the market. He was already — already noticing things worth keeping.""

Sibafuzi nodded.

"Do you think he knew," he said. "When he was writing it. That he'd keep doing it for forty years."

"I don't think anyone knows that."

"No."

A pause. Outside the snow was still down, settled and patient on Bishop Street.

"I've been thinking about what Marcus said," Sibafuzi said. "About not wanting to leave the court."

Priya looked at him.

"He didn't say that."

"He said it the way he doesn't say things. The way he said — the thing I was looking at. Not wanting to change it."

She looked at the journal.

"He's going to be all right," she said.

"I know."

"I mean I actually know. Not — I'm not saying it to say it."

"I know." He looked at her. "Me too."

She reached across the table and put her hand on his. He turned his hand over and held hers. Both of them looking at the journal.

"He's a good kid," Sibafuzi said.

"They're all good kids."

"Yeah."

They sat like that for a while. Then she said: "Bed."

He nodded. She picked up the journal — gently, both hands, the way you carry something that belongs to someone else — and put it back in the center of the coffee table where it had spent the day. Where it would spend tomorrow and the next day and the day after.

She turned the light off.

They went to bed.

* * *

CHAPTER FIVE

The Second Day

The snow was still down in the morning but it had stopped falling.

The snow had done what snow did when it had made its point — it had stopped. Settled. Gone patient and permanent on Bishop Street, making the world smaller and quieter and, in the way of the first proper snow of the season, making the world temporarily a better and simpler place.

Sibafuzi had been up before everyone again. He'd stood at the kitchen window with his tea and watched the garden, which looked different under snow — tidier, like the mess of it had been smoothed away. The lilac at the back fence had gone from something ungoverned and leggy to something that looked almost considered. The church steeple at the end of the block caught the light first — always fifteen minutes before everything else went blue. He stood there in the early morning quiet with the mug in both hands and thought about what Nali had said about the bones of the house. He was starting to see what she meant. Under the damp and the not-quite-right and the smell of other people slowly becoming their smell, there was something solid. He just hadn't felt it yet as his.

Monde was at his feet.

The puppy had been sleeping in the small utility room off the kitchen, curled up near the furnace, where Priya had set up his dog bed and a water bowl and a blanket that had been Mateo's until Mateo decided Monde needed it more than he did. He was young, Monde —

six months, seven maybe, they'd had him barely three weeks — a brown and black thing with ears still working out which direction they were supposed to go. He had a tendency to sit directly on your feet, which Sibafuzi had initially found irritating and had since, without ever announcing the change, stopped finding irritating at all.

The puppy looked up at him. Then at the window. Then back at him, as if checking whether the window was worth the investigation.

Sibafuzi said nothing. Monde put his chin back on his feet.

He thought about the journal. He'd been thinking about it since he woke — the weight of it, the fact of it, someone's whole life laid out in those handwritten entries, those small true sentences, sitting in his living room on the coffee table next to a photograph and a medal and a cassette he still couldn't play. He'd gone to sleep thinking about the torch entry and woken thinking about the boy who'd sat in the doorway and just wanted to stay. There was something in that — something he needed and hadn't named yet.

He went and knocked on Marcus's door.

Silence.

He knocked again.

"I'm awake."

"Breakfast."

More silence. Then the familiar sound of Marcus getting up — the specific creak of his floor, his particular footfall, the sound of him being fifteen and carrying something and not saying so.

Sibafuzi went back downstairs.

* * *

They were all at the table by nine.

That hadn't happened in a while — all of them, together, at a table, before ten in the morning, not because something was wrong or they had to be somewhere but because the snow had erased the elsewhere

and left only here. Nali had got there first, which meant the tea was already made and there were eggs on the go, which she was managing in her way — very calm, very in charge of the pan, like the pan had been designed specifically for her and was grateful to finally be used correctly. Mateo was already eating. He was always already eating. Zara was reading something, turned sideways in her chair with her knees up, the way she read when she was comfortable enough to forget she was at a table.

Marcus came down last. He'd combed his hair, which nobody commented on. He sat down, looked at his plate.

"Morning," Priya said.

"Morning."

That was about as much as anyone managed for a while. But it wasn't a bad quiet. It was just morning. Morning had its own quality in this house that was different from the morning quiet in their last place — this one had more texture to it, more sound in the walls, old pipes and old wood making their own slow conversation in the cold.

Monde put his chin on Marcus's foot under the table. Marcus didn't look down.

Nali put a plate in front of Sibafuzi without being asked and sat down with her own. She reached into her cardigan pocket and her hand came out with the stone — the smooth flat one she'd found in the garden that first Friday. She put it on the table beside her plate, the way she did every morning now, the way some people put their phone. Just having it there.

Mateo noticed that Nali's stone was warm even when the house was cold. He'd touched it once when it was on the table and she was in the other room. He didn't know how that worked. Maybe the stone had been warm for a long time and it just stayed that way. Maybe that was what happened when you kept something close to you for long enough. It started being warm on its own.

"So, Fuzi," she said, picking up her tea and looking at him. "We are continuing today, eh? The journal."

It wasn't really a question.

"I want to," Zara said.

"Yeah," said Mateo, through eggs.

Priya looked at Sibafuzi. He shrugged, which for Sibafuzi meant yes — had always meant yes, a particular small upward movement of one shoulder that she'd been reading correctly for seventeen years.

Marcus was looking at the table. He had his phone face down beside his plate — another small thing nobody mentioned. Jordan's voice note had been there for five days now, six, and he'd played it probably twenty times and still hadn't replied and still didn't know what to say. The phone stayed face down.

Mateo noticed that Marcus never put the phone down. He turned it over. Those were different things. When you put something down you were done with it. When you turned it over you were still holding on but just not looking. He understood that. He did it with the figure sometimes — held it face-down when he wasn't sure what he wanted it to be yet, when he needed more time to decide.

"Who reads it?" Marcus said.

"We take turns," Priya said.

He nodded. Went back to his breakfast.

"You can read one," Zara said to him.

"Maybe."

"The next part is about when he's your age," Priya said.

Marcus looked up.

"How do you know?"

"I looked ahead a bit last night. Couldn't help it."

Something moved across Marcus's face that wasn't quite interest but was adjacent to it. The particular expression of someone who has been trying not to be interested in something and has just been given a reason to stop trying.

"Fine," he said. "I'll read one."

* * *

They settled back in the living room after breakfast.

Same formation as the night before, near enough. Priya and Sibafuzi on the sofa — she'd made tea, he'd put another log on from the small pile Sibafuzi had found in the garage that might last another two days if they were careful, which meant he was thinking about it and not saying anything about it. Nali in the armchair she'd quietly claimed as hers on the first night, the stone in her pocket or in her hand, her book on the arm of the chair but not open. Zara on the floor with her back against the armchair, the notebook from her bag open on her knee — she'd spent the last hour before bed the previous night going back through it, reading what she'd written, adding things she'd been turning over since.

Mateo was on his stomach on the rug, figure stood up in front of him facing the room, as though it was watching too.

Marcus came in last and sat on the floor near the fireplace. He sat with his back against the wall, not quite in the circle, still with one foot in the hall. But he sat.

Priya passed him the journal.

He looked at it. The cloth cover worn pale at the spine. The weight of it in his hands — lighter than it looked and also heavier, which he didn't try to understand. He opened it where they'd left off.

The section heading was handwritten in the same careful script as everything else, slightly larger:

THE JOURNAL

Age 11 to 15

Marcus read the heading and stopped.

"The Crew?"

"Keep reading," Zara said.
He did.

* * *

September — first week of high school
different school now.
everything is bigger.

I don't know anyone except Ryan from elementary and Ryan has
already found some older kids
to hang around with so that's probably that.
I sat by myself at lunch.
it wasn't as bad as it sounds.
I had a book.
but it was kind of bad.

* * *

Marcus read it straight. Didn't comment.

Nali made a small sound. Sympathetic. The sound of someone
who had seen this particular form of aloneness many times across the
full span of a life and had never stopped feeling the weight of it.

"First days," she said. To nobody.

Sibafuzi glanced at Marcus. Marcus didn't look up. He was
reading ahead.

Monde had crossed the room and settled against Marcus's leg.
Marcus still didn't look down. But his hand dropped, found the puppy,
rested there.

* * *

October

there's a group of boys I've been eating lunch near.
I don't really know them yet but they let me sit there.

there's one called Darius who is funny in this way where you can't tell if he's joking or not.

* * *

November

Darius has this quality.

when he talks to you, you feel like you're the only person in the room.

not because he's not paying attention to everyone else.

he is.

but when he's looking at you, he's really looking.

I've never met anyone like that.

I've been trying to understand how he does it.

I think it's because he's interested.

not performing interest.

actually interested.

like he genuinely wants to know what you're going to say next.

I want to be like that.

I've been practising.

it's harder than it looks.

* * *

January

we stayed late after school on Friday.

the five of us in Darius's kitchen.

his mum was home but staying out of the way, which I later understood was her version of being present without being intrusive.

we weren't doing anything.

that's the thing.

we were just — there. in the kitchen. talking. eating whatever was in the fridge. the conversation going from serious to stupid to serious

without anyone managing it.

I've been trying to figure out what made it feel so different.

I think it's because nobody was trying.

we weren't trying to be interesting or cool or anything.

we were just there.

I didn't know you could have that.

I thought you had to perform.

Darius doesn't perform.

Darius just is.

I'm learning.

* * *

Marcus had stopped reading. He was looking at the page.

"He's fifteen," he said.

"Thirteen, fourteen here," Priya said.

"Still." He paused. "He's already — he's thinking about this stuff. At thirteen."

"He was paying attention," Nali said.

"Most people don't."

"Most people are working very hard at being seen," she said. "He was working hard at seeing. They're different jobs."

Marcus looked at the journal.

"Darius was real," he said. It was almost to himself. "Like — that thing where someone's actually interested. Not performing it. He had that."

He didn't say: I know someone like that. He didn't say: or I did. He didn't say anything about Jordan.

But Sibafuzi noticed. He filed it. Said nothing.

"Keep going," Zara said gently. "He loses him."

"What?"

"Darius. You'll see."

Marcus looked at her. Then back at the journal. He kept reading.
I think I want to be his friend.
I don't know how to make that happen.
I just keep sitting near them and hoping.

* * *

"That's so real," Zara said.
"Shh," said Marcus. He kept reading.

* * *

* * *

November

I'm in the group now I think.
it happened slowly and then all at once.
Darius started calling me by my last name and that meant I was in.
I don't know how I know that but I know.
there's also Joel and a boy everyone calls Wheels even though his
name is something else.
I didn't ask why.
you don't ask that kind of thing.
September — new year
Wheels moved schools.
some new people came in.
there's a boy who reminds me of no one I've ever met.
I can't explain it.
he just does whatever he wants and nobody seems to mind.
not in a bad way. he just doesn't seem to be worried about whether
people mind.
I've never been like that.
I want to know how he does it.

* * *

Marcus laughed softly at that one. Just to himself. Something private happening on his face.

"What?" Zara said.

"Nothing. I just —" He shook his head. "I know what he means."

"Jamie?" Priya said.

Marcus looked at her. The particular expression of someone whose thought has been read out loud and who hasn't decided yet whether to be annoyed about it.

"I didn't say that."

"No," she said. "I know."

He looked back at the journal. Kept reading.

* * *

November — later

I told my mum about the group.

she asked what they were like.

I said they were funny and good at football.

she said that's nice and then she said are they kind.

I said yeah I think so.

she said good. because funny and good at football is fine but kind is what matters.

I thought she was being a mum thing about it.

but I've been thinking about it.

* * *

Sibafuzi smiled at that one. Just slightly.

"His mum again," Priya said.

"She's something," Nali said. "That woman doesn't waste words, oh."

Marcus stopped. He'd been moving faster through the entries but this one he stopped at. He read it again, quietly, something working in his face that he hadn't decided what to do with yet.

"What?" Zara said.

"Nothing." He kept going. But something had settled on him — something had changed the quality of how he was sitting.

Nali watched him. Said nothing. The stone turned over once in her hand.

* * *

February

there's a footballer I've started watching properly.

not just watching — studying.

the way he moves before he gets the ball.

he's always already thinking about the next thing.

I've started trying to do that in PE.

it doesn't work yet but I think it might eventually.

I think watching someone who's really good at something makes you want to be really good at something.

even if it's not the same thing.

* * *

Sibafuzi leaned forward at that one. Not consciously — he just found himself closer to the edge of the sofa.

"Yeah," he said. Quietly. Like he was agreeing with something the boy had said directly to him across the years.

* * *

March

Darius did something.

I'm not going to write exactly what.

but he took something from a shop.
I was there.
I didn't do it but I was there.
and I didn't say anything.
after, he was laughing about it and I laughed too.
I don't know why I laughed.
I came home and I felt bad.
not terrible. just bad.
I don't know if that makes it better or worse that it was only a bit bad.

* * *

Marcus read it. Put the journal on his knee.
Nobody said anything for a moment.
"He laughing," Zara said. Not accusingly. More like she was working it out.
"Yeah."
"Why?"
Marcus looked at the page. Looked at Zara. The firelight between them.
"Because Darius was laughing. And when someone you want to be around is laughing — you laugh. Even if you don't want to. Even if you know you shouldn't. There's something in you that just does it."
Priya looked at him.
"I'm just saying what he meant," Marcus said.
"I know," she said. "I know you are."
Nali was quiet for a moment. The fire. The snow-light through the window. The particular patience she had for this kind of moment — the kind that needed time and not words.
"The boy knew it was wrong, eh?" she said finally. "He wrote it down. You only write a thing down like that when it's sitting on you."

When you can't put it anywhere else."

Marcus nodded. Read on.

* * *

May

Darius and Joel had a fight.

not a real fight. a falling out.

something about a girl and something said and now they're not talking.

the group feels different.

like when one thing is wrong in a room and you can't figure out what it is but something is.

I didn't take sides.

Darius asked me to and I said I wasn't in it.

he didn't like that.

I didn't like him not liking it.

but I still didn't take sides.

I don't know if that was brave or just scared of getting it wrong.

* * *

"Ooh," Zara said.

"What?" said Mateo, who had turned over onto his back on the rug and was looking at the ceiling.

"He didn't pick a side. In the group."

Mateo thought about this. He had an expression that meant he was filing it — not for later, but for now, for somewhere in the present.

"Is that good?"

"Depends," said Sibafuzi.

Everyone looked at him.

"Sometimes not picking a side is the right thing. Sometimes it's just the easier thing. They don't always look the same from the

outside. Or the inside."

"He knew that though," Marcus said. He tapped the page. "He wrote it. He didn't know which one it was for him."

"That's honest, at least," Priya said.

"Honest is the start of something," Nali said. She said it like a statement of fact, not a comfort. Like: this is the architecture of things.

* * *

June

things are okay with Darius now.

we didn't talk about it.

we just sort of started talking about other things and then it was fine.

maybe that's how it works when you're this age.

I don't know if I handled it right.

but it's fine now.

I think fine is okay sometimes.

* * *

October

I've been thinking about what makes someone a hero at this age.

when I was little it was people who were strong or fast or could fly.

now I think it might just be people who aren't afraid of the room.

like some people walk in and they're already thinking about what everyone thinks of them.

and some people walk in and they're just — there.

I want to be that second one.

I don't know how to get there from here.

* * *

Nobody rushed to say anything after that one. It sat in the room with the fire and the snow-light and the sound of the house.

Then Mateo said, still on his back on the rug, as though he was simply reporting something he'd observed:

"I think Nali walks in like that. The second one."

Everyone looked at him. He was staring at the ceiling, the figure on his stomach, apparently unaware of what he'd just done to the room.

Nali looked over at him. Her face did something — something that moved through it quickly and settled into something quiet and held.

"Ay, Mateo," she said softly. Just that.

* * *

November

my dad came to watch football on Saturday.

he doesn't usually.

he stood on the side in his big coat and I could see him from the pitch.

I played badly.

really badly.

I kept looking over at him and every time I looked I played worse.

after, he said you were working hard out there.

I said I was rubbish.

he said yeah you were. but you were working hard.

I didn't know if that was good or bad.

I think it was just true.

I think he just wanted to say something true.

* * *

Sibafuzi rubbed the back of his neck. A gesture Priya recognized — it meant something had landed near something real.

"What?" she said.

"Nothing."

"I said that to you once," Nali said to Sibafuzi. "Or something like it."

Sibafuzi looked at her.

"You don't remember," Nali said. "You were maybe twelve. You'd had a terrible math test. Came home looking like the world had ended. I said something like that — not the same words. But the same thing. You don't remember."

"I don't," Sibafuzi said.

"That's fine," Nali said. "I do."

A moment. The fire. The stone in her palm.

Marcus was watching his grandmother and his dad with that sideways attention he deployed when he didn't want to be caught doing it. Then he looked back at the journal.

* * *

January

something happened with Darius.

I don't want to write too much about it.

but he wanted me to say I'd been with him somewhere when I hadn't.

to cover for him.

I said I couldn't do that.

he said why not, it's easy, just say it.

I said because it's not true.

he said so.

and I didn't have a better answer than that.

I said I just can't.

he didn't speak to me for a week.
it felt bad.
but the other thing felt worse.
I didn't know that about myself before.

* * *

Marcus stopped reading.

The room waited. Monde lifted his head from Marcus's leg, read the room, put it back down.

Marcus was looking at the page but not reading. Just sitting with it — with the particular quality of stillness that meant he was deciding something, not about the journal but about the room, about whether this was the room for it.

"You alright?" Priya said.

"Yeah."

He wasn't going to say anything else. Then he did.

"I had something like that. Before we moved. With someone in the group."

Nobody asked what. That was the right call — you could feel the room making it, everyone choosing the same silence at once.

"I said yes," Marcus said. "To my version of it. I said yes."

He looked at the journal.

"He didn't."

Priya opened her mouth. Sibafuzi gave the smallest shake of his head — nearly invisible, old married language. She closed it.

Nali spoke instead. Quietly, without urgency, the way she said things that mattered.

"And what happened, this boy. Did he stay with Darius after?"

Marcus turned the page. Found it. Read.

* * *

February

me and Darius are fine.
he didn't mention it again.
I don't know if he respects me for it or just got over it.
doesn't matter I suppose.
we're fine.
and I know something now that I didn't know before.
which is what it feels like when you don't.
and also what it feels like when you do.
they're different in a way I can't explain.
but I know them apart now.

* * *

Marcus closed the journal on his finger.

"Same," he said. Very quietly. Talking to nobody.

Sibafuzi looked at him properly for the first time all morning.
Really looked — not a glance, not the checking look, but the one that
had something behind it. The one that saw.

Marcus didn't look back. But the room felt it. The inch or two of
air between them had a different quality than it had had at breakfast.

Zara was looking at her brother the way she looked at people when
she was updating her understanding of them — carefully, without
announcement, filing the new version.

"Keep going?" she said.

"Yeah," Marcus said. He opened the journal back up.

* * *

March

I've been thinking about my mum and dad a lot lately.
not in a worried way.
just noticing them more.

my dad when he's tired but still shows up.
my mum when she's not okay but she deals with it anyway.
they argue sometimes.
sometimes it goes on.
I used to hate that.
I still don't like it.
but now I think — they're just two people trying.
that doesn't make it fine when they argue.
but it makes them human.
I think that's a different thing to fine.
I think it might be better.

* * *

Priya and Sibafuzi weren't looking at each other. They were both looking at the journal. But something had shifted between them — one of those small invisible adjustments that happen when a sentence goes into a room and changes the air pressure slightly.

Mateo had sat up from the rug. He was cross-legged now, the figure in his lap. He had the look of someone doing a calculation.

"Do they stop arguing?" he said.

Nobody answered straight away.

"Keep reading," Nali said. "You'll see."

* * *

May

I did something I'm not proud of.

Darius wanted me to go along with something again.

this time I did.

nothing big.

but I knew while I was doing it.

that's the worst bit.

not the thing itself.

knowing while you're doing it.

I keep thinking about that woman my mum told me about years ago.

the one on her street who used to sit with the old people.

when someone's doing something that costs them something and they do it anyway.

I wasn't doing that.

I was doing the opposite.

I don't like knowing that about myself.

I'm going to remember it though.

I think you have to.

* * *

Marcus read it slowly. Put the journal down.

"He remembers that," he said. "From when he was little. What his mum said."

"Mm," Nali said. Like she'd been waiting for him to notice that.

"It stayed with him."

"Things do," Nali said. "You don't always know which things when they're happening. But the ones that matter — they go in. And you don't find them again until you need them."

Marcus thought about that.

"He's harder on himself than he needs to be," Priya said.

"Maybe," said Sibafuzi. "Or maybe that's just what it looks like when someone's paying attention."

That surprised everyone slightly. Including Sibafuzi, by the look of him.

* * *

June

I've been listening to this one album basically every day.

* * *

June — end of the year

I've got the group. that's something.
I've got the music I found, which still feels like mine.
I messed some things up.
I didn't mess some other things up.
I'm not the same as I was in September.
I don't think that's only good or only bad.
I think it's just what happens.
I think you just have to keep going.
That's what my dad would say.
He wouldn't say it like advice.
He'd just be doing it.
I notice that more now.

* * *

Summer, year three

Darius is going.

* * *

his family is moving.

I knew this was a possibility. I didn't know it until it was a fact.
there's a difference.

* * *

The week after

we had one more Friday in his kitchen.
the five of us.

his mum had made the food that meant: I know this matters. the generous version of the food.

we ate too much and talked and tried not to notice that we were trying not to notice.

near the end someone said: we'll stay in touch.

and we meant it.

and we all knew what that meant.

it meant we'd try and it would be hard and it would change and then it would be something different.

I've been thinking about what he gave me.

he gave me: you can be interested in people without performing interest.

he gave me: the best rooms are the ones where nobody's trying.

he gave me: a way of looking at people.

I've been trying to look at people that way ever since.

I still am.

every day.

I'm still practising.

* * *

Marcus had his hand over his mouth.

Not dramatically. Quickly, then back down. But Priya saw it. Nali saw it.

He kept reading.

His voice was even. He'd always had that — the quality of being able to read something that was getting to him without letting it show in the reading. Priya had noticed it the first time he'd read from the journal, and then she'd understood: he was doing what Marcus always did when something arrived — holding it at a useful distance until he'd understood it, then deciding what to do with it.

But his foot was pressing against Monde's side. Monde was pressing back.

He finished the section. Set the journal on his knee.

"He lost him," he said.

"Yes."

"But he kept the — he kept what Darius gave him." He paused.
"The way of looking."

"Yes."

He nodded. Slowly. The private nod.

He picked the journal back up.

I won't write which one because if someone reads this they'll think I'm weird.

but it's like it was made for right now.

like whoever made it knew what it felt like to be in the middle of something you can't explain yet.

I play it walking to school and the walk feels different.

I feel like a different version of myself.

maybe that's what music does.

maybe that's why people need it.

* * *

Summer

I asked my mum something.

I said do you think I'm a good person.

she didn't answer straight away.

I liked that she didn't.

she said I think you're trying to be.

and I think you know the difference. which is most of it.

I said is that enough.

she said for now. keep going.

* * *

Marcus read that last line again under his breath.

"For now. Keep going."

He closed the journal.

Nobody spoke for a bit. The fire had settled into itself, burning steadier. Outside the snow was still, the whole street still, the church at the end of Bishop Street visible from where Sibafuzi sat — just the top of the steeple, just the stone cross, pale against the white sky.

Mateo had been very quiet. He looked at Marcus.

"Are you a good person?"

Marcus looked at his little brother. The full weight of the question. The full simplicity of it. He almost gave a quick answer — you could see him stop himself.

"I'm trying to be," he said. "I think I know the difference. Most of the time."

Mateo nodded like that was a perfectly good answer. He didn't look away. He was six and he didn't yet know that you weren't supposed to keep looking after you'd got the answer.

Nali was looking at Marcus with something that wasn't quite pride and wasn't quite love but was probably what those two things look like when they arrive at the same time, in the same face, unexpectedly.

"Eh, Marcus," she said softly. Just his name.

He looked at her.

She nodded once, slow. The way she did when words weren't the right tool and the nod was everything.

He looked away. But not quickly.

* * *

Priya made soup for lunch because there was nothing else to do with the potatoes and because the house needed a warm smell in it.

She was standing at the counter and she was also standing in Deepa's kitchen, which was how memory worked when you were forty and tired and trying not to think about things.

Deepa's kitchen. Red walls, which Priya had always thought were too much and had eventually been proved wrong about. The casserole dish with the chip in the lid. The exact height of the counter, which had always been two inches too low for Deepa and two inches too high for Priya, so they stood at it and complained, every time, across ten years. As if the counter were the actual problem.

She hadn't spoken to Deepa in four months. She'd meant to. She had the text half-drafted in her phone: *Settled in finally, can we call this week?* She'd been meaning to send it since November. It was December. She would send it. She would.

The thing about Deepa was that she was Priya's city, not just a person in it. She was the coffee shop and the shortcut through the park and the specific Saturday morning that felt like her real life. She was the woman who had sat with Priya in the hospital waiting room when Marcus was five and had a fever they couldn't explain, just sat there, four hours, not saying much, just there. She was the one who had laughed at the right moments at Sibafuzi's most exhausting qualities without ever making Priya feel disloyal for laughing with her. She was ten years of ordinary Tuesday evenings in a red kitchen.

You didn't replace that. You didn't transplant it. You didn't carry it with you in a box and unpack it in Collingwood. It was specific to a place and a time and it had happened and now it was in the past, intact and complete and unreachable, and that was the honest version of the move that Priya had not said to anyone.

She added an extra pinch of salt to the soup. Tested it. Added another.

She would call Deepa this week. She meant it.

The soup needed fifteen minutes. She had fourteen.

She'd been a person in that city in a way she was not yet a person here.

Not a better person. Not a worse one. A specific one. With a route through the market on Saturday mornings that she'd refined over five years to its optimal form — the fish first, then the cheese, then the vegetables in order of weight so the bread stayed on top. With a dry cleaner who knew her name and knew what she meant when she said *that one needs careful handling* and always, always handled it carefully. With a coffee shop where she went on Wednesday mornings when the children were in school and she had three hours that were only hers, where she sat in the same chair by the window and did the work she couldn't do at home — not because the house was loud but because she needed the chair by the window to do that kind of thinking.

She didn't know yet what the equivalent was here. She was, she supposed, in the process of finding out. But she hadn't known she needed to find out until she arrived and the absence of it was just — there. Not devastating. Just present. A gap shaped like herself.

She'd talked about this with Sibafuzi, once, a year before the move was real, when it was still hypothetical. She'd said: *it's not just leaving a city. It's leaving a version of yourself*. He'd looked at her with the look that meant he was hearing something important and was not going to rush past it. He'd said: *what do you mean?* She'd said: *I don't know exactly. But I think I leave some of myself behind whenever we move. And I'm not sure I always get her back*.

He'd been quiet for a long time. Then he'd said: *I think you get a different version. Not the same one back. A different one*. She'd thought about that. She'd said: *what if I liked the one I had?* He'd said, and this was the thing she kept coming back to: *you'll like the next one too. You always do. I watch you become the place. It just takes time*.

She hadn't known whether to believe him. She'd chosen to.

She was here now. In the middle of the becoming. It was uncomfortable the way becoming was always uncomfortable — the disorientation, the not yet knowing the route through the market, the dry cleaner, the chair by the window. But he was right that she'd been here before. Different city, different house, different chair. And she'd found the chair, every time.

You become the place. It just takes time.

She put the lid back on the pot. Called up the stairs that soup would be twenty minutes.

She heard the exact way each person registered this — Mateo's small affirmative sound, Zara's pen continuing to move, Marcus's floor creak as he shifted, Sibafuzi's silence that meant heard you, Nali's nothing because Nali's nothing meant she was already coming down.

She knew those sounds. She'd learned them in every house they'd ever lived in and she knew them here already, three days in, because some things you carried.

Zara sat at the kitchen table and talked to her while she made it, which Priya hadn't expected. She'd been braced, quietly, for another day of the slightly-too-careful quiet that had been between them since the move — not bad, not cold, just the quiet of a mother and daughter who loved each other and had run out of easy things to say. But Zara sat down with her notebook and started talking, and Priya found herself just — present. Just here.

"Do you think the boy turns out alright?" Zara said.

Priya stirred.

"I think so. I hope so."

"He seems like he will."

"Why?"

Zara thought about it. The specific quality of Zara thinking — unhurried, real.

"Because he notices. He writes it down even when it makes him look bad. You wouldn't do that unless you were actually thinking about it. Unless it mattered to you. The people who don't care don't write the bad bits. They just leave them out."

Priya looked at her daughter.

Sometimes Zara said something and Priya didn't know if she should be proud or slightly scared. Today felt like both.

"How'd you get so sharp?" Priya said.

"Nali," Zara said. Without hesitation.

Priya laughed. First real laugh in a while — surprised, full, the kind that comes out before you've decided to let it. It surprised her, how good it felt. Like something releasing.

Zara looked pleased. She went back to her notebook.

They worked in the kitchen together, the soup thickening, the bread Priya had started that morning doing something good in the oven, and outside the snow stayed down and the light stayed even and the house held them the way it was beginning to hold them, warmly, with something that was starting to feel like intention.

They were side by side at the counter and Priya was in her body and also slightly outside it, which happened sometimes when she was doing something simple with her hands and her mind went where it went.

She was thinking about something the journal man had written. the university entries. The bit about the lecturer's office — going back two years later, after everything, going back to say: *that thing you gave me, I used it*. She'd wanted to hear more of that. She'd wanted to know what the lecturer had said.

She thought about who she would go back to. If she were making a list.

Her mother's sister, Aunty Mira, who had told her at eighteen that she was capable of being excellent at something but she had to decide first that she was allowed to be, and that those were two different

problems. Priya hadn't understood it until thirty-two.

Her undergraduate supervisor who had written in the margin of her third-year dissertation: *you are doing something interesting here — don't undercut it by qualifying everything. Let the argument stand.* She had been qualifying things her whole life. She was still working on it.

Deepa, who had sat in a hospital waiting room for four hours and never once said *it'll be fine*, because Deepa knew that *it'll be fine* was something you said when you needed the other person to stop needing something from you, and she had never, in ten years, needed Priya to stop needing.

She would go back to all of them eventually. She was meaning to. The text in her phone. The card she hadn't sent. The call that was always almost scheduled.

The people who don't care don't write the bad bits, Zara had said.

Priya stirred the pot. Tasted it. It needed more time.

Her parents had met Sibafuzi on a Sunday in March, which had also been the first warm Sunday of the year, the kind of day that arrives in late winter and makes promises it may or may not keep. Her mother had made too much food, which was what her mother did when she was anxious and also what she did when she was happy, so the food itself was no guide to her interior state. Her father had been very quiet, which was also what he did when anxious and when not anxious, so he too was no guide.

Sibafuzi had been twenty-four. He had a quality at twenty-four that she'd noticed from the first time she met him and that she still noticed now, seventeen years later, though it had deepened and quieted: he was entirely, specifically interested in whoever he was talking to. Not performatively. Not networking. Just — interested. He asked her father about the shop, and her father talked about the shop for forty minutes, and Sibafuzi listened to every word. She'd watched her father notice this. The slight recalibration. The easing.

Her mother had asked Sibafuzi, over the food, about Zambia. She'd asked the way people asked when they wanted the polite version, the travelogue. Sibafuzi had given her something else instead — he'd talked about his mother's kitchen. The smells. The specific sound of the street outside. The way the light came in through the window in the late afternoon. He talked about it the way she would talk about her parents' house if she were trying to make someone understand what home felt like. Not facts. The feeling behind the facts.

Her mother had gone very still listening to him. Then she'd said, quietly: *yes, that's how it is*.

Nothing else. Just that. The recognition.

Priya had watched that happen across the table. Her mother — a woman she had never once seen moved quickly, who processed everything slowly and thoroughly and then arrived at a considered position — her mother had recognized something in thirty seconds and said *yes, that's how it is* and the room had shifted.

She'd known then. Not *this is the man*, which she'd known earlier — she'd known that the second week, standing in the library stacks arguing about whether Achebe was being ironic and realising she'd been arguing for twenty minutes and was enjoying every second of it. She'd known something else then. She'd known: *my mother sees what I see*. Which was, she realized now, the thing she'd been waiting for without knowing she was waiting for it.

She'd told Deepa that evening. Deepa had said: *your mother went still? She never goes still*. Priya had said: *I know*. Deepa had said: *that's it then*. Priya had said: *yeah*. They'd both known exactly what *that's it then* meant, which was the gift of a friendship long enough to have its own shorthand.

She stirred the pot. The soup was nearly ready.

She thought about calling Deepa. Soon, she thought. This week. Not the call where she drafted it and didn't send it. The actual call.

The one where she said: I've been thinking about you. I've been meaning to say it.

She reached for the salt. Added some. Tasted it. Added a little more.

The soup was good. The soup would be good. She was making it in a house that already knew what good soup smelled like, and that seemed right.

"Good call last night, Fuzi," she said, without looking up. He said nothing. She didn't need him to.

She added more salt. Put the wooden spoon on the rest. Thought about Deepa's kitchen with the red walls and the counter that was always the wrong height.

Thought: *I am going to call her this week. I mean it. This week.*

* * *

After lunch Sibafuzi found Marcus in his room. Door half open.

He knocked anyway. You always knocked, even with a half-open door. Especially.

"Yeah."

He went in. Marcus was on the floor with his back against the bed, knees up. Phone in his hand but face down. The room was his in the way rooms become yours when you spend enough time not wanting to be in them — things scattered in a system nobody else could read, the particular geography of a teenage boy's floor.

Sibafuzi sat down against the opposite wall. Same height as his son. Looked at the same patch of floor.

He didn't say anything straight away. He was good at that — the useful silence, the kind that says I'm here and not: say something.

"I'm not gonna talk about the thing I said this morning," Marcus said.

"Okay."

Silence. Just the house around them and the faint sound of Zara writing.

"I just wanted to say," Sibafuzi started. Then stopped. Then tried again, the way he tried things — plainly, without dressing them up. "I know I've been tight. Since the move. Since before the move."

Marcus said nothing.

"I'm working on it."

"Okay," Marcus said.

"That's it," Sibafuzi said. "That's what I came to say."

Marcus nodded. He was looking at the floor. Not dismissively — just the look of someone processing something, testing whether it was true or polite, deciding it was true.

Then after a moment:

"Dad."

"Yeah."

"That thing in the journal. Where he said his dad came to the football even though it went badly. And afterwards just said yeah you were rubbish but you were working."

"Yeah."

"I liked that."

Sibafuzi looked at him. His son. Fifteen. The particular strange beauty of fifteen — still a boy in the way he held himself, already a person in everything else.

"Yeah?"

"Yeah."

Sibafuzi nodded.

They sat there a bit longer. Two people against two walls, not talking, but the room between them a different size than it had been an hour ago. Monde came in at some point and went between them once and lay down roughly in the middle, which felt like something.

* * *

That evening, Nali found Mateo at the top of the narrow back staircase.

He was looking up at the attic hatch. The ladder folded back up into it, the hatch closed, the door above the landing repainted and ordinary-looking now that everyone knew it was there.

"Are you thinking about going back up?" she said.

"No. Just looking."

She came and stood beside him. Her hip was better today — the cold wasn't in it the way it had been in the night. She stood without leaning.

"Nali."

"Mm."

"Who put the box there?"

Nali had been thinking about this all day. She'd been thinking about it in the particular careful way she thought about things that had more than one layer.

"I think whoever kept the journal had a daughter. And the daughter grew up in this house and had to give it up at some point — maybe when she got older, or when life went in a different direction. And she couldn't take the journal with her. So she hid it. Here. For whoever came next."

"How come?"

"Because she thought it would be good for whoever found it. She thought someone might need it."

Mateo was quiet. He was looking at the hatch with that look of his — the one that meant he was doing real work, not just filling time with thinking.

"Did we need it?" he said.

Nali looked at him. Then she looked at the door of Marcus's room. At the sound of Priya and Sibafuzi talking quietly in the kitchen — actually talking, not working around each other. At the line of light under Zara's door where she was still writing.

"Yes, my dear," she said. "I think we did."

Mateo nodded like that was settled. He held the figure up toward the hatch.

"He's been up," Mateo said. "He's already seen it."

Nali looked at the figure. The bent cape. The worn paint on the hands from being held so much. Then at the boy holding it.

"Wait," she said. "I think I know his name now."

Mateo looked at her.

"Yeah?"

"Ay. You've been finding out what he's like for days. What do you think?"

Mateo looked at the figure. Turned it over once in his hands. Thought about it with the full seriousness he brought to everything that mattered.

"Not yet," he said. "Almost."

Nali smiled. The one with something behind it.

"Almost is fine," she said. "Almost is how it always goes."

They stood together for a moment, looking up at the hatch in the low light. Then Nali put her arm around him and they went back down to the kitchen.

* * *

They stayed at the table for a long time after the reading stopped.

Not talking, mostly. The fire. The window, dark now, the snow still coming but lighter, the kind that had given up on being impressive and was just doing its job. Mateo had fallen asleep in the armchair — not dramatically, just gradually, the way children fall asleep when they've been very still for a long time and the warmth of the room has done its work. The figure was in his hand, tilted.

Zara was writing. She'd been writing since the last entry about Ray and the new colleague, the saved seat, the thing you don't notice if

you're not watching. She wrote in the small deliberate handwriting she used when she was transcribing things she wanted to keep exactly, and then in the larger handwriting she used when she was working something out.

Marcus was on the floor. He'd migrated there at some point in the middle of the school entries — nobody had tracked the exact moment, he was just there now, back against the sofa, looking at nothing in particular, which was Marcus doing his processing.

Nali had her stone in her hand. She'd been turning it over at intervals all day — not compulsively, just regularly, the way you check something you want to keep track of.

Priya was looking at the journal on the table.

Sibafuzi came back from the kitchen with more tea and found them like that — each person at their own interior station, connected by the room, the fire, the ongoing fact of being in this house together.

He poured for whoever held a cup up. Sat down.

"He was good at his job," Marcus said. Into the room, not at anyone.

"Ray?" Priya said.

Mateo had been very still.

He'd been still since Marcus read that sentence. Since the three letters.

I'll call him Ray.

He looked at the figure. He'd had it since the first morning in the new house — the bent-arm, caped figure from the box in the attic, the one from the drawing, the light-going-out hero. He'd been calling it nothing, all week. He'd been waiting to find out what he was like.

He looked at the figure.

He looked at the journal.

There's a man at work. I'll call him Ray.

He looked at the figure again. The way he held things he was figuring out — both hands, slightly raised, looking at it from different

angles.

"That's his name," Mateo said.

Priya looked up. "Whose name?"

Mateo held the figure up.

The room was very quiet.

"The journal man named someone Ray," Mateo said. "A real person. Because that person was — " He paused, working it out as he spoke. "He was the one who was a hero and nobody knew it. That's why he picked that name. Because that was what that person was."

He lowered the figure. Looked at it.

"So that's his name," he said. "Ray. He's the same kind."

Nobody spoke for a moment. The specific quiet of a room in which something has been named correctly.

"The ordinary kind," Zara said softly. She'd been writing. She kept writing.

Mateo turned the figure to face him. Direct, the way he looked at things he was being serious about.

"Ray," he said. Confirming it.

He set the figure on the armrest beside him, facing the room.

He went back to listening.

"The journal man. The way he described Ray. The new colleague. The saved seat." A pause. "He noticed things other people didn't notice."

"He was paying attention," Nali said.

"Most people don't."

"Most people are very busy thinking about themselves." She said it without judgement. As a fact. "He wasn't. Or he trained himself not to be. Either way."

Marcus looked at the journal.

"I want to be like that," he said.

He said it simply. Not dramatically. The same tone he'd use to say: I want to try that restaurant. Clean and declarative.

Sibafuzi looked at his son.

Something moved through him — a feeling that didn't have a quick name, that was composed of equal parts pride and the specific emotion of recognising yourself in someone and seeing them at the beginning of the thing you've been working on for decades. He didn't say any of this. He poured his tea.

"You're getting there," he said.

Marcus looked at him.

A moment. Then he looked back at the fire.

"Keep going," Mateo said, from the armchair, without opening his eyes.

Everyone looked at him.

"In the morning," he said. "Keep going in the morning." Then he was asleep again.

Zara looked at her notebook. Wrote one more thing. Closed it.

They went to bed.

Zara noticed it because Zara noticed things that other people narrated later, when they'd had time to name what they'd seen.

Nali went still.

Not still in the way she went still when something landed — that stillness was active, receiving. This was different. This was the stillness of someone who has seen a thing they weren't expecting to see, and is deciding what to do with it.

It happened when Marcus read the entry about the journalist. The one the journal man wrote to. The name of the publication the journalist wrote for — Marcus had said it quickly, moving on, and Nali's hand had closed around the stone in her pocket.

Just for a moment. Then open again.

Zara watched her grandmother's face go through something private and settle back into its usual surface. Nobody else was looking. Sibafuzi was watching Marcus. Priya was watching the journal. Mateo was watching the ceiling.

Zara looked at Nali.

Nali caught her looking. Held it a moment. Then gave the smallest movement of her head: *not now*. Not a dismissal. More like a footnote:

ask me later. When it's right.

Zara turned the page in her notebook. Wrote: *Nali knows something.*

Underlined it twice. Then waited.

* * *

CHAPTER SIX

The Third Day

Bishop Street was still buried. Sibafuzi had checked twice.

Not really checking. Going to the window and looking, the way you do when you already know the answer but need the window to confirm it. It didn't tell him anything new. The road was white and still and the cars parked along it were shapes and the church at the end of the block sat under its mantle of snow exactly as it had sat the past two days — patient, present, the lights still off. He'd seen that Tuesday-evening light in the side window again last night, just briefly. Someone in there in the dark. Keeping something going.

He found a bag of rice at the back of a cupboard he hadn't opened yet. Priya found half a tin of tomatoes and a can of chickpeas and between them, standing at the counter in the morning quiet before anyone else was down, they'd worked out a meal for tonight. It was the kind of small problem-solving that had felt, this morning, almost like being a team.

Almost. He'd take almost.

He was thinking about Priya — about the way she'd stood there with the can in her hand reading the label like it was instructions for something more than chickpeas, the way she'd passed him the bag of rice without comment, the way the counter between them had felt like something you could put things on and have them held. He was thinking about the paint argument and what it had actually been about and what he hadn't said and what she hadn't said and whether any of it

needed saying now or whether this, here, was already the saying of it.

The journal was doing something to him. He'd been up before five, thinking about the boy's father — the big coat at the football match, the honest useless thing he'd said: yeah you were rubbish, but you were working. The fact that the man had come at all. The fact that he'd stood there in his big coat and been present and that was enough. That was the whole thing.

She let him have the silence first. That was the order of things: give him the silence, let him find his way to the beginning of what he wanted to say, then meet him there.

He'd always been this way. Even as a boy. He'd sit with a thing for a long time before he could give it language. She'd learned early that pushing produced not the thing but a version of the thing, edited, which was less useful than waiting for the actual one.

He stood at the window with his tea. She sat at the table with hers. The morning light, the particular November quality of it through the east window — thin, patient, honest. Not trying to make anything look better than it was. She respected that.

"I've been thinking about Dad," he said.

She didn't say anything. This required no response yet.

"The journal man writes about his father. The leaving and the coming back. The making of it into something workable."

"Yes."

"He writes about picking up the torch."

"Yes."

Long pause.

"I have his hands," Sibafuzi said. Quietly. Not looking at her. Looking at the garden.

She looked at her son's hands around the mug. She had noticed this too, years ago. The shape of the knuckles. The particular way the left hand held things. She had not said it. Some recognitions were better left to the person to arrive at themselves.

"I know," she said.

"Is that — good or bad."

"It's both," she said. "Same as him."

He turned from the window. He looked at her with the expression she'd been cataloguing for forty-odd years, the one that was trying to decide whether to go further.

"He was trying," she said. "In his way. With his equipment. I know that's not enough. It wasn't enough. But it's true."

Sibafuzi nodded slowly.

"The journal man figured it out," he said. "He wrote his way to it."

"Yes."

"I don't have a journal."

She looked at him. Her son. Standing in his kitchen in his coat, forty-one years old, a good man who'd been carrying things for a long time and had started this week to put some of them down.

"You have this house," she said. "You have this week." She paused. "You have me."

He looked at her for a moment. Something moved through his face. He crossed the kitchen and put his arms around her — not a quick hug, a real one, his head bent down to hers, both of them still.

She patted his back. Once. Twice. The way she'd patted it when he was nine years old and the world had confused him.

"Ay, Fuzi," she said softly. "Ay."

He stepped back. He was fine. She was fine. They were both fine, which was the word they used for the complicated territory between ordinary and exceptional.

"Now," she said. "What is for breakfast."

He laughed. Short, real, with his whole face.

She went to find the eggs.

He thought about Marcus. The floor, the two walls, the room between them.

Getting less so.

Zara came down first. She had a notebook.

It was from her school bag — the spare one she kept for things that didn't fit into the primary notebook, the one she used for ideas and questions rather than notes. She'd been up late writing in it, Priya had heard her, the creak of her floor and the scratch of a pen going past midnight. She'd said nothing this morning because Zara's late nights were always working nights and Priya had long since stopped treating them as a problem.

"What's that for?" Mateo said. He was already at the table.

"I'm writing things down. Things from the journal."

"Why?"

"Because I want to remember them."

Mateo thought about this seriously. He thought about most things seriously — this was one of the things about him that Priya had been watching since he was very small, trying to understand it, the way his attention worked. Not scattered, not distracted, but directed. When something had his attention it had all of it.

"Can I have a notebook too?"

"You can't write properly yet."

"I can draw."

Zara found him a spare notebook from her bag and he sat at the table with it, very serious, opened it to the first page and drew something that took several minutes and considerable concentration. When he was done he sat back and looked at it. It was either the house or the journal or the figure — it had elements of all three, hard to tell, but it had been done with intention and that was what mattered.

Nali came in, saw the two of them at the table with their notebooks, and stopped in the doorway.

"Eh," she said quietly. Not to anyone. Just the sound of something landing right.

She put her hand in her pocket and felt the stone, and came in.

* * *

Marcus came down late. He'd slept, which Priya noted without saying anything, the way she noted a lot of things about Marcus — stored them, held them lightly, didn't put them into words unless the words were needed. He'd been sleeping badly in the new house; she could hear him sometimes at two in the morning, the creak of his floor, the sound of him up and pacing. Not like he was troubled — more like he was working something out, like sleep felt like leaving something unfinished. But this morning he'd slept. She could tell by his face.

He got his breakfast and sat down and looked at Zara's notebook. He read what she'd written without being invited to and she didn't stop him, which was its own small thing.

"That's the bit about the music," he said.

"Yeah."

He didn't say anything else but he looked at it a moment longer before he went back to his breakfast. Monde put his chin on Marcus's foot. Marcus didn't look down.

Mateo noticed that Marcus and Zara had a language that didn't use words. He'd been watching it for six years. When one of them looked at the other a certain way, something got communicated that he couldn't decode yet, but he knew it was real because of what happened next — one of them would do something the other had apparently needed without the second one having asked. It wasn't telepathy. It was just: knowing someone very well. He was going to have this with them eventually. He was patient. Some things took time to grow into.

* * *

They settled again after. Same places, more or less. Priya had the journal.

While the others read, Mateo drew.

He had the notebook Zara had given him and a selection of the markers from his art box, which he'd found in the morning and arranged on the coffee table by color family, which was how he preferred them. He was doing this at the table while the family read, which meant he was both there and not there, both present and in his own country. He'd always been able to do this — occupy two places at once. He considered it useful.

He was drawing the house.

Not the outside — he'd drawn the outside already, on Day One, the silver maples and the porch and the fence. He was drawing the inside. Room by room. Not architecturally, not to scale. He was drawing what each room felt like. The kitchen warm and east-facing and first-light. The living room with the fire and the six people and the journal. The study with its built-in shelves and the box on the top shelf and the figure he'd placed there facing into the room. The narrow back staircase. The attic, which he'd been up to once, just to see.

He was drawing in each room the thing that was most itself about it.

The kitchen: the window, the light going through it, out, like in the drawing.

The living room: the fire, and around it, small figures, close together.

The study: the shelves, and on the shelves, shapes. Not books. The things that were on shelves because they needed to be held.

He worked for a long time. The others read. The fire crackled. The house made its sounds.

He finished the last room — his own room, which he'd drawn last because you always drew your own room last, it was more personal,

you had to earn it — and he looked at all the rooms laid out across the three pages.

The house, from the inside.

He thought: every room has something in it that's the most itself.

He thought: that's true of people too.

He looked at the figure on the windowsill across the room.

He'd figured out what it was like now. He'd been figuring it out since the first morning. He knew.

He picked up a marker. At the bottom of the last page, small, he wrote a name.

Not Ray. That was the figure's name in the house, which was its own thing. This was the figure's true name, its actual nature, the thing he'd been finding out.

He wrote: *someone who takes the light with them.*

He put the cap back on the marker. He went back to listening.

"This next part," she said, "he's older. Sixteen, seventeen, going on from there."

"He goes to university?" Zara said.

"Something like that. You'll see."

"Is this the boring part?" Mateo said.

"Mateo," Priya said.

"I'm just asking."

"No," said Nali, very firm. The firmness of someone who has been through the years in question and knows exactly what they contain. "This is not the boring part. This is when things start to get interesting, eh? When you start meeting the world properly. On your own terms. Sit and listen."

Mateo sat and listened.

Priya opened the journal.

THE JOURNAL

* * *

An afternoon thought

I've been thinking about heroes.

I keep writing about people.

but I walked home a different way today.

past a street of old houses.

one of them had a light on in the upstairs window.

the particular warm yellow of a lamp in the evening.

and I thought: that house has been here for a hundred years.

it has held — what. ten families. twenty. people being born in it
and dying in it and growing up in it and leaving it and coming back.

a hundred years of that and it's still standing and the light is on.

I think places can be heroes.

I haven't worked out what I mean by that yet.

but I think it.

* * *

"He was thinking about it," Zara said. "Even then."

"He gets there," Priya said. "In the later ones."

Zara wrote something. Nodded. "I know. But I like that he was
already starting to think it."

She wrote: *heroes take years to recognize sometimes. even when
you're looking at them.*

Age 16 to 22

She read the heading. The room settled.

They were forty minutes into the later section when Priya stopped
at an entry and didn't immediately read on.

The entry was about a professor — a small, fierce woman who had
returned a marked essay with a note in the margin: *you're being
deliberately vague here. Either you don't know what you mean, or
you're afraid of what you mean. Either way, fix it.* The journal man

had written: *I didn't go back to that office for two weeks because I was so irritated. Then I went back. She was right. I still think about that note.*

Priya was looking at the journal with an expression that had a specific quality — not sad, not happy, the expression of someone touching something that was also touching them.

Marcus noticed. He was watching her the way he watched his parents when he thought no one was watching him watch them — the private observation of a child who has spent fifteen years studying two adults in order to understand something about the world.

"What?" he said.

She looked up.

"I had a supervisor," she said. "Third year. He wrote in the margin of my dissertation: you are doing something interesting here — don't undercut it by qualifying everything. Let the argument stand." She paused. "I've been qualifying things my whole life. I'm still working on it."

"What does qualifying mean?" Mateo said.

"Hedging. Saying *maybe* when you mean *yes*. Adding *I think* when you already know. Not quite committing to the thing you're saying."

Mateo processed this. "Why do people do that?"

"Because if you're not quite committed, you can't be quite wrong."

Mateo looked at the ceiling. The thing he did when he was working something out. Then:

"But if you're not quite committed, you can't be quite right either."

The room held that.

"Yeah," said Marcus. Looking at the floor.

"Exactly that," Priya said.

She picked up the journal. She read on. But something had changed in the room — the kind of change that didn't announce itself, just settled, like a window closed against a draft. Quieter. Warmer.

Nali turned the stone over in her hand and said nothing and that was right.

* * *

September

sixth form.
different building. different feeling.
like someone turned the volume up slightly on everything.
the teachers talk to you different.
like you might have something worth saying.
I'm not sure I do yet.
but I like being treated like I might.

* * *

Zara looked up.

"Sixth form?"

"It's what they call it where he's from," Priya said. "The final years of high school. Before university."

"Where's he from?"

Priya looked at the journal. A small careful thing moved across her face.

"We don't know yet," she said. "Keep going."

* * *

October

we had to read something for English.
a speech.

I won't write who it was because I've been wrong about things like this before.

but I read it and then I read it again.
and then I went and found more things by the same person.

I've been doing that for three days.
I didn't know you could just — look up what people thought.
that their words were just there, waiting.
I don't know why that surprised me but it did.
it felt like finding a door I didn't know was there.

* * *

Priya looked up from the page.

"Finding a door he didn't know was there." She said it like she was tasting it.

"Yeah," Sibafuzi said.

"That's good," Zara said. She wrote it in her notebook.

Marcus was looking at the ceiling. Not bored — the thing he did when he was thinking hard about something and needed the ceiling to hold still while he did it.

* * *

November

I've been reading about people who changed things.
not famous in the way athletes are famous.
famous in the way that they said or did something that the world kept.
and some of them had terrible lives.
difficult in ways I can't imagine.
and they still did the thing.
I keep thinking about what my mum said years ago.
when someone's doing something that costs them something and they do it anyway.
it costs more than I thought she meant.
it cost some of these people everything.
I don't know what I would do.

I hope I would do the thing.
I'm not sure I would.
I think being honest about that is the start of something.

* * *

Nobody rushed that one.

Nali made a sound. Not a word. Just a sound that meant she'd felt something, something she recognized from a long distance.

"He keeps coming back to that," Marcus said. "What his mum said."

"Mm," said Nali. "The things that plant in you when you're small — you don't know they're growing. And then one day you look down and there they are. Full height."

Sibafuzi looked at her.

She caught him looking.

"What?"

"Nothing," he said. But it wasn't nothing.

* * *

January

I find it easier to admire people who are already dead.

I know how that sounds.

I just mean — you can't be let down by them.

what they did is done.

it's already paid for.

a living person can still mess it up.

a dead person has already finished.

you know all of it.

I think that's a kind of comfort.

maybe a bit of a cheat too.

I'm not sure.

* * *

"That's true," Zara said. "That's why people like historical figures. They can't do anything else wrong."

"Bit dark," Marcus said.

"Bit true though," said Sibafuzi.

"Both," said Nali. "It is both." She settled in her chair. "But I'll tell you something. The living ones are braver. Because they can still lose. Still be proved wrong. They haven't finished yet and they do it anyway. That is harder."

"He gets there," Priya said. "Keep reading."

* * *

March

I'm going.

I got in.

I didn't tell anyone I'd applied except Mum and Dad.

I was scared to say it out loud in case it didn't happen.
it happened.

Mum cried.

Dad did that thing he does where he doesn't cry but he goes very quiet.

I love that thing.

I love that I know what it means.

* * *

Sibafuzi made a sound — the same kind he'd made at the torch entry. Quiet. Caught off guard by something he recognized.

Priya looked at him sideways. He shook his head slightly. She looked back at the journal.

"What thing?" Mateo said. "What does the quiet mean?"

"Pride," Nali said. "When it's too big for your face." She glanced at Sibafuzi. "Your father does it too."

Sibafuzi looked at the fire.

Marcus looked at his dad. Just for a second. Then back at the journal.

* * *

September — first week at university

everything is too much.

too many people.

too many ideas.

too many conversations happening at once.

I sat in the library today for two hours just because it was quiet.

I felt bad about that.

like I was wasting it.

then I thought — no, I needed the quiet.

you can need the quiet.

that's allowed.

* * *

October

I've started actually talking in seminars.

not a lot.

but some.

the thing I've learned is nobody really knows what they're doing either.

some of them just talk louder.

I can talk louder.

I just don't want to say things I don't mean.

I'd rather say one true thing quietly than three loud things I'm not sure about.

I think.

I'm still figuring that out.

* * *

"One true thing quietly," Zara said. She wrote it down.

"You're going to fill that whole notebook," Marcus said.

"Good."

* * *

November

there's a lecturer.

I won't describe him too much in case this sounds like I have a crush, which I don't.

he just — talks about ideas like they matter.

not like they're on a syllabus.

like they're alive.

like thinking carefully about something is the most important thing you can do.

I've never seen someone be excited about an idea the way he gets excited.

not performed excited.

actually.

I didn't know you could do that.

be like that.

I want to be like that about something.

I don't know what yet.

* * *

Sibafuzi had leaned forward. Not consciously — just found himself further toward the edge of the sofa, closer to the thing being said.

"I had one of those," he said. "Not university. Work. A guy I worked under when I first started. He just —" He found the word. "He cared about it. Like it was worth caring about. And you'd think — it's just the job. But he made you feel like the job was worth something. Like the work mattered. Like you mattered for doing it."

Nobody filled the space after that.

"What happened to him?" Zara said.

"He moved on. Different company. We lost touch."

"Do you miss him?"

Sibafuzi looked at her. The way she asked things — directly, without performance, genuinely wanting to know. He'd always loved that about her.

"Yeah," he said. Like he was only just realizing it, the way realizations sometimes wait for the right question. "Actually yeah."

Priya read on.

* * *

February

I stayed after the lecture today.

I wanted to say something.

I don't know exactly what.

something about how the last few weeks had shifted something.

Mateo had been learning the sounds of the new house. This was something he did in every house. The old house had had a specific creak at the top of the stairs that meant someone was awake, and a sound from the kitchen pipes at around three in the morning that meant nothing but had taken him six weeks to understand meant nothing. This house had more sounds. Older sounds. Not scary. More like — the house had more to say. More history in the walls. He was learning the language of it. By the time they had to go back to normal life he thought he'd have the basics.

I was going to say it.
I stood there while everyone else left.
and then he got a phone call.
and then someone else came in.
and I just — went.
I didn't say it.
I still think about what I would have said.
I don't know if it matters.
I think it might.

* * *

"Oh no," Zara said.
"What?" Mateo said.
"He didn't say the thing."
"What thing?"
"The thing he wanted to say to the lecturer. He just left."
"Maybe it would've been weird," Marcus said.
"Or maybe the lecturer needed to hear it."
"You don't know that."
"You don't know he didn't."
Nali was smiling. Just quietly, to herself.
"What?" Zara said.
"Nothing, my dear. You're right." She pointed at Zara. "Say the thing when you have it. Life is short and people need to know when they've done something good. Write that one down."
Zara wrote it down.

* * *

March

I met someone.
I'm not going to write too much.

her name is Adaeze.

she is studying something completely different and talks about it like I talk about the things I've been reading.

which is to say — like it matters.

we talked for three hours the first time.

I don't think I've ever talked for three hours.

I walked home after and the whole city felt different.

like it had more in it than I thought.

* * *

Priya stopped. She smiled down at the page — the particular smile she had for certain kinds of sentences, the ones that got it right.

"Oh, here we go," Nali said.

"What?" Mateo said.

"He met someone," Zara said.

"Like a girlfriend?"

"Maybe."

Mateo made a face. The face of someone who considers this a narrative detour.

"Just wait," Nali said. "Just wait until it's you. Then we'll see that face."

Marcus said nothing but one corner of his mouth moved.

* * *

May

Adaeze said something that I keep thinking about.

she said — the people you look up to are just a map of who you want to be.

I said what do you mean.

she said every time you admire someone, you're admitting something about yourself.

what you think matters.
what you want.
what you're reaching for.
I said so your heroes are basically just you, trying.
she said — exactly.
I didn't have anything to say to that.
I just looked at her.
she laughed and said close your mouth.
I think she might be the smartest person I've ever met.

* * *

"She's right," Zara said. Firm. The tone of someone confirming something they already believed.

"About what?" Marcus said.

"The heroes thing. Every time you admire someone you're admitting something about yourself. What you think matters." She looked around the room. "That's what we're doing right now. With the journal. Seeing what he admires tells you who he is."

The room was quiet for a moment.

"When did you get like this?" Marcus said.

"I've always been like this."

"You were not always like this."

"I was. You just weren't paying attention."

Nali patted Zara's knee.

"She's always been like this," she confirmed. "Since she was very small. Always watching."

* * *

Summer

good summer.

me and Adaeze spent a lot of it just — being in the city.

going places.

talking.

she reads things I haven't read and I read things she hasn't and we trade.

she is also the first person I've said hard things to.

things I'd been carrying.

and she didn't fix them.

she just — held them with me for a bit.

I didn't know that was a thing someone could do.

I think I want to be that for people.

I want to be able to do that.

* * *

September — second year

I've started reading things I don't agree with.

on purpose.

Adaeze says you can't know what you think until you know what you're arguing against.

it's uncomfortable.

some of it makes me angry.

some of it makes me think.

the worst ones make me do both at the same time.

I don't have a tidy conclusion about this yet.

I just know I'm thinking harder than I was.

and it feels like exercise.

like something is getting stronger.

I like it.

* * *

Sibafuzi looked up.

"Reading things you don't agree with. On purpose." He said it like he was checking he'd heard right.

"Good idea or bad idea?" Zara said.

He thought about it.

"Depends what you do with it."

"He reads them and thinks harder," Zara said. "That's what he said."

"Then good idea."

"I don't do that," Marcus said. "I just scroll past things I disagree with."

"Everyone does," Priya said.

"He didn't," Marcus said. He nodded at the journal. Small quiet.

"Start small," Nali said. "One thing. One thing you wouldn't normally read. You don't have to agree. Just read it." She looked at Marcus. Then Sibafuzi. Then Priya. "All of you."

Nobody said no.

* * *

November

something happened.

I don't know how to write this.

me and Adaeze.

it's not — we didn't have a big fight.

nothing dramatic.

we just — started being in slightly different places.

and then more different.

and then she said I think we want different things.

I didn't argue.

that was the hardest bit.

that I couldn't argue.

because she was right.

I could feel it.
I just hadn't said it.
she had.
I walked home and the city felt the same.
that bothered me more than anything.
it should have felt different.
it didn't.
it was just the city.
and I was just in it.
and that was that.

* * *

Priya read it slowly. Put the journal in her lap when she finished.

Zara wasn't writing anything. She was just looking at her notebook, pen still.

"Are they done?" Mateo said. Very quietly, like he was checking something he already knew.

"Yeah," Priya said.

"That's sad."

"It is," she said.

"But she was right, wasn't she," Zara said. "Adaeze. She was right that they wanted different things."

"Sounds like it."

"So it was right. Even though it was sad."

Nobody answered that immediately. It didn't really need one. It was the kind of statement that existed on its own.

Nali reached over and took the journal from Priya's lap.

"Let me," she said. "For this part."

Priya let her take it. There was something right about that — Nali reading this part. Seventy-three years old, all those houses, all those things she knew that she distributed carefully.

Nali found the next entry. She read it quietly to herself first. Then aloud.

* * *

Two weeks later

I keep writing things I'd tell her.

it's been two weeks and I'm still doing it.

I'll read something or see something and my first thought is —
Adaeze would have something to say about that.

and then I remember.

I don't know if that gets better.

I think it does.

I think it must.

but right now it just feels like a gap.

not dramatic.

just — there.

like a tooth that's gone.

you don't think about it until you do and then it's all you feel for a
minute.

then it passes.

I'm going to be okay.

I just need to say that somewhere.

I'm going to be okay.

* * *

Nali put the journal down on her knee.

The fire had gone low. Nobody moved to fix it.

Mateo spoke first, his voice careful:

"Why does he keep writing to her if she's not there?"

Nali looked at him. There was something she did in these moments
— she found the version of the answer that was true and also a thing a

six-year-old could hold. She was very good at this. It required no adjustment for Mateo specifically because Mateo was very good at holding true things.

"Because the writing isn't really for her. It's for him. To get it out. To put it somewhere outside of himself so it doesn't stay rattling around inside."

"Does it work?"

"Mostly. Not always. But mostly."

Sibafuzi was very still. The kind of still that looked like he was listening to something nobody else could hear.

Priya looked at him. He felt her looking. He didn't look back but he reached over and put his hand on her knee. Not looking at her. Just — there. His hand. Available.

She put her hand over his.

Zara saw it. Looked away. Wrote something in her notebook.

Marcus saw it too. Said nothing. But something settled in his face — some small important piece of something came to rest.

* * *

Spring

I'm okay.

not just saying it.

actually okay.

I've been going to the library more.

found a whole section I hadn't been in.

started reading about — okay I'm going to write it — philosophy.

I know.

don't.

but there's this idea.

about how you can't control what happens to you.

only what you do about it.

I've heard that before but I read a version of it that — I don't know.
landed differently.
like I believed it this time.
like it went in.
I've been thinking about it on the walk to lectures.
you can't control what happens. only what you do about it.
okay. okay.
I can work with that.

* * *

"Okay, I like him again," Marcus said.

"You always liked him," Zara said.

"I liked him more in some bits."

"This is a good bit."

"Yeah."

Nali was nodding. The slow confirming nod.

"This is what that kind of pain does if you let it. If you don't just — seal it off. It teaches you something. It makes more room in you."

"More room for what?" Mateo said.

"Other people's pain. Other people's joy. More of everything. You become bigger." She held her hands out, showing the size of something. "Inside."

Mateo looked at his own chest, pressing gently against his ribs.

"I don't feel big inside," he said.

"You're six. Give it time, eh."

* * *

Final year — autumn

I went back to that lecturer's room.

I'd been meaning to for two years.

I just wanted to say — thank you.

thank you for the way you talked about things.
it changed something.
I knocked on his door.
he was packing up his office.
he's leaving. different university.
I told him what I wanted to say.
I just said it.
he looked surprised.
then he said — that means more than you know.
we talked for maybe twenty minutes.
I walked out and the whole corridor felt different.
just a corridor.
but different.
I wish I'd done it two years ago.
I'm glad I did it at all.

* * *

Zara put her pen down.
"He went back," she said.
"He went back," Priya agreed.
"Ay!" Nali said. One sharp, satisfied sound, like someone had just scored something.
"Two years later," Marcus said.
"Better late," Nali said.
"You said say the thing when you have it," Zara said to her. "He just took two years to have it."
"Better late," Nali said again. "Always better late."
Sibafuzi was quiet. He had the look of a man adding something up.
"What?" Priya said.
"Nothing. Just —" He stopped. Started again. "I should call someone. I'll do it after."

Priya didn't ask who. She looked at the journal and thought she might already know the shape of the answer.

* * *

June — graduation

done.

that's it.

three years.

Mum and Dad came.

Dad wore a tie I've never seen before.

I said I liked it.

he said your mother made me buy it.

she heard him say that and rolled her eyes but she was smiling.

I looked at them standing there.

the same way I looked at them in the kitchen when I was small.

through the doorway.

just wanting to stay in it.

some things don't change.

I don't think they should.

I'm going to carry this day.

not the ceremony.

not the bit.

the tie.

the eye-roll.

them just being there.

that's the bit I'm going to carry.

* * *

Twenty-one

went home for Christmas.

first time in two years.

things look different when you haven't been for a while.
not because they changed.
because you did.
the house is smaller.
not unpleasantly. just: I've become a different size.
the town is smaller too.
I drove past the school on the first day.
stood outside for a bit.
thought about who I'd been inside those walls.
thought: that boy needed some things he didn't have.
thought: he got some things he didn't know he was getting.
it's hard to see it clearly while you're in it.
maybe that's how it always is.

* * *

I saw Mr. Osei at the post office.
he's retired now.
he was my history teacher in year nine.
he changed something.
I haven't thought about what he changed in a while.
but being here I thought about it.
he had a way of making the past feel like something that was still
happening.
not over.
ongoing.
he said once: history is not what happened. history is what is still
happening because of what happened. the world you live in is a
continuation of all the worlds before it.
I was fifteen and I thought: that's a lot of pressure.
now I think: that's not pressure. that's possibility.
I went up to him at the post office.

I said: Mr. Osei. I don't know if you remember me.
he looked at me for a moment.
he said my name.
he said: of course. how's university.
we talked for ten minutes.
it was small talk, mostly.
but at the end I said: I wanted to say. that thing you said about
history still happening. I think about that a lot.
he looked at me.
he said: I'm glad. Keep thinking about it. That's all you have to do.
he went back to his post.
I stood on the pavement for a bit.
I thought: that's it. that's the whole job. plant the thing. trust that
some of them will keep thinking about it.
I'm going to try to plant things.
I'm going to trust that some of them keep going.
"History is not what happened," Zara said. She was writing it.
"History is what is still happening because of what happened."
She looked up.
"That's us," she said. "Reading his journal. We're history still
happening."
The room sat with that for a moment.
Marcus looked at the journal. Looked at the things on the table —
the drawing, the photograph, the medal. Evidence of lives that were
still happening through this moment, through the people who'd found
them, who would carry some part of them forward.
"Yeah," he said. Quiet. "We are."
Priya read on.
I wrote her another letter last year.
she wrote back this time.
Year eight of doing this
I got something wrong.

not morally.

professionally. significantly. publicly.

I wrote a piece that I thought was right and it was not right.

not because I lied.

because I didn't look hard enough at the parts I didn't want to be true.

I knew this, somewhere, as I was writing it.

I made the error of trusting the version I wanted over the version that was actually there.

I've been sitting with this for three weeks.

the editor was kind about it. the correction ran. the person affected was gracious, which they didn't have to be.

I've been reading back through my notebooks.

I found the moment. the exact paragraph where I stopped asking the harder question.

I can see it now. I couldn't see it then.

this is the only thing I can do with it: look at it clearly. understand exactly what happened. carry that forward.

not as punishment. as calibration.

the things you get wrong are as instructive as the things you get right, if you're willing to look at them.

I'm willing to look at them.

I wasn't always.

I'm learning.

Nobody said anything for a moment.

"He made a mistake," Sibafuzi said.

"Yes."

"And he said so." He was looking at the journal. "He didn't explain it away. He looked at where it happened. And he kept going."

"The correction ran," Marcus said quietly. From the floor. "That's—" He stopped.

"That's what you do," Sibafuzi said. "When you get it wrong. You don't — you don't explain. You say you got it wrong and you fix it and you keep going."

He said it with the weight of a person who was also talking about something else. Whose something else was sitting on the floor, back against the sofa, listening.

Marcus said nothing. But his expression was not the closed one.

Nali was watching them both. She touched the stone.

"Keep going," she said.

one paragraph.

she said — thank you for seeing it.

that's all.

I kept it.

of course I kept it.

Priya read it and didn't stop at the end of it. She finished it and just sat there for a moment with the journal open in her lap.

Sibafuzi had looked away. Window. The white street. The church steeple.

Nali didn't say anything. She sat with it the way she sat with things that were large — not sealing them off, not hurrying through them, just letting them be the size they were.

Mateo had fallen asleep on the rug, which nobody had noticed until now. Just gone, quietly, on his side, one hand under his cheek, the figure still held loosely in the other.

Marcus looked at him.

"He lasted well," he said.

"He did," Priya said.

They all looked at Mateo for a moment. Small and still and completely out.

"He's the best of us right now," Nali said.

"Sleeping?" Zara said.

"Peaceful. Not holding anything." Nali looked at the rest of them.
"We could learn."

Marcus got up, went to his room, came back with a blanket. Put it over Mateo without waking him. Sat back down.

Nobody said anything about that.

Which was the right thing.

* * *

They broke for the evening not long after.

Priya and Sibafuzi made dinner together in the kitchen. Not tense this time — just them, in a kitchen, making something. They'd done it a thousand times. But tonight it felt like that was the point. Not the food. Just the doing of it together.

At one point Sibafuzi said: I'm going to call him tomorrow. She looked at him. "Alex?" He nodded. "Good, Fuzi," she said.

Alex? she said.

Yeah.

She nodded. Good.

That was it. They went back to the cooking.

* * *

Zara came to find Nali before bed.

Nali was in her room, sitting by the window with the lamp off. Just the snow-light from outside — blue-white, very still, the kind of light that Ontario winters produce at their most serious, not romantic, just the world at its most fundamental.

She'd been thinking about a man she'd known in Lusaka when she was twenty-three. Not thinking in the painful way — she'd done that years ago, finished it, filed it. Just remembering the way you remember good things: with gratitude, with the specific warmth of something that shaped you and didn't hurt you and is just — there,

available, part of what you're made of.

"Nali."

"Come in, eh."

Zara sat on the edge of the bed. She had her notebook.

"I wanted to ask you something."

"Ask."

"Did you have someone? Like Adaeze? When you were young?"

Nali was quiet for a moment.

"Yes," she said. "I did."

"What happened?"

"Life," Nali said. "We wanted different things too. Not bad things. Just different things. And we were honest about it. Which is a kindness even when it doesn't feel like one."

Zara thought about this. She was good at thinking about things quietly — she didn't rush toward the next question, she let the first one settle.

"Do you still think about them?"

"Sometimes. Like a good book you read a long time ago. You don't need to read it again. But you're glad you read it. You're glad that's in you."

Zara wrote something down.

"Nali."

"Mm."

"The journal — do you think he was happy? In this part?"

Nali turned from the window to look at her.

"I think he was becoming himself," she said. "Happy comes and goes. Becoming yourself — that one stays. That's the better thing."

Zara wrote that down too. Then she said goodnight and went to her room.

Nali turned back to the window.

The snow had stopped. You could see a few stars now, through the gap in the clouds. The church at the end of the block was dark but the

stone of it held the light differently than the snow — it absorbed it, held it, gave back something warmer. She looked at it for a while.

She sat with the stars for a while, her hand around the stone in her pocket.

Then she went to bed.

* * *

That night Sibafuzi couldn't sleep.

Not anxiously — not the catastrophising insomnia, the running-numbers version. Just: awake. Alert. His body certain it had things left to do with the day and his mind in agreement.

He went downstairs at midnight. Stood at the kitchen window. The street was empty and white and still, the snow having paused at last, the town under a silence that was not absence but presence — the presence of a lot of cold air resting.

He'd been thinking about the journal man's father. The way he'd written about him — not at length, not centrally, but with the precision of someone who had spent years making peace with something and wanted to get the record right. The father who had tried in his way with his equipment and the way that wasn't enough and also wasn't nothing.

He'd been thinking about his own father.

About the specific character of the thing he'd been carrying. How long, and how quietly, and in how many ordinary moments — filling out forms, looking at his children, standing at various windows in various houses, late at night when the house was quiet and his body was certain it had things left to do.

He thought: I'm going to call Alex tomorrow.

Not later in the week. Tomorrow. First thing.

He thought: and I'm going to deal with Marcus's email situation. Directly. Without making it about myself.

He thought: and I'm going to fix the porch step before we leave. Because it needs fixing and I can fix it and this is my house and that's what that means.

He stood at the window for a while longer. The church at the end of the block, St. Andrew's, its steeple pale under the winter sky. He'd been looking at that steeple every morning. It had the quality of something that had been looked at for a long time — by this family, by the previous family, by the journal man who'd written *every evening the steeple catches the last of the sun about fifteen minutes after everywhere else has gone gray. I've been watching it for three months. I don't know what to do with that.* He didn't either. But he was beginning to understand that not knowing what to do with something wasn't the same as it being meaningless.

He went back to bed.

He woke at two in the morning to the specific cold that meant the furnace had stopped.

He knew it before he'd fully surfaced from sleep. Knew it the way you knew your own house — by its breath, its temperature, the quality of the air. The furnace ran at a background hum that had already become so familiar in five days that its absence was louder than its presence.

He lay still for a moment. Forty-one years old. Twenty-six years of paying attention to what could go wrong. Sixteen-year-old furnace. Inspection report that had said, in the measured language of people paid to be careful: *serviceable, but approaching the end of its expected useful life.*

He got up.

The hallway was eleven degrees. He could feel it through his socks. He went down the stairs — not rushing, not catastrophising, moving with the specific care of a person who had decided to be competent about this — and into the utility room, where the furnace was not running and the pilot indicator was off.

He checked the obvious things first. The thermostat. The circuit breaker. The air filter, which he found and cleared because it was past due and occasionally that was all it needed. He reset the pilot twice. The furnace made sounds both times — exploratory sounds, trying — and then went quiet.

He stood in the utility room in his coat, which he'd put on from the hook by the door on instinct, and he thought: this is the thing.

The actual thing. Not the anxiety about it. The thing itself, right here, at two in the morning.

He thought about the inspection report. He thought about the number he'd had in his head since October — the worst-case replacement cost, the figure he'd been managing around. He thought: we'll be cold tonight and it'll cost something and that's what it is. He was surprised, standing in the cold utility room, to find that the actual thing was smaller than the feared thing. Not small. But smaller.

He went to find his phone to call the emergency line. He found it in the kitchen.

He found Marcus there too.

Marcus was sitting at the kitchen table in a sweatshirt and socks, phone in hand, clearly not sleeping. He looked up when Sibafuzi came in. They looked at each other.

"The furnace," Marcus said. Not a question.

"Yeah."

"I heard the click. When it stopped."

Sibafuzi sat down across from him at the kitchen table. Two of them in the dark cold kitchen with the city-sleep quiet of Bishop Street outside.

He called the emergency HVAC line. They'd send someone at eight. There were some things he could do in the meantime — he was told them, he did them, he came back to the kitchen. The house would be cold until morning. They had the fireplace.

Marcus had not moved. He was still there when Sibafuzi came back, which was a choice.

Sibafuzi looked at his son. Fifteen. Here at two in the morning in a cold kitchen in a house they'd been in for five days in a town neither of them had chosen. And staying.

He sat down.

"You want to get the fire going?" he said.

"I'll do it."

Marcus got up and went to the living room. Sibafuzi heard him: the log, the grate, the scratch of the match, the slow building breath of the fire finding its footing. He came back and sat down. They could feel the warmth starting from the other room.

"I said something to you," Sibafuzi said. "On Day Four. When I came upstairs with your phone."

Marcus looked at the table. "I know what you said."

"I want to undo the last one." He said it without preamble, the way the journal man had written about his mistake: *look at it clearly. understand exactly what happened.* "I don't even know who you are. I said that. And it's the one I can't justify. The furnace, the school — I was scared and I was wrong but I can find the line from scared to stupid for those. That one I can't."

Marcus was very still.

"I know exactly who you are," Sibafuzi said. "I've known since you were two. You're the person who makes the playlist like it's a document. You're the person who went back to the court and sat there for an hour and didn't go to Jordan's house because you were figuring something out. You're the person who was already awake at two in the morning and heard the furnace stop and stayed in the kitchen instead of going back to bed." He paused. "I know who you are. I said the wrong thing. I'm telling you the right thing now."

Marcus sat with it. His eyes on the table, then on the window, then somewhere else.

"The Jordan thing," he said.

Sibafuzi waited.

"There was a situation. Before we left." He didn't fill it out, didn't name Kwame, didn't describe the court or the escalation. "I knew something I should have said earlier. I didn't. And then when I said it it was too late and it got complicated. I don't know if Jordan knows that I knew earlier. The voice note has been on my phone for eleven days and I haven't listened to it because I don't want to find out."

Sibafuzi looked at his son.

He thought about the journal man's mistake entry. *I made the error of trusting the version I wanted over the version that was actually there. The exact paragraph where I stopped asking the harder question.* He thought: Marcus has already done the harder thing — he already knows which paragraph it was. He's been sitting with that for eleven days. That was not a small thing. That was most of the work.

"You're going to listen to it," Sibafuzi said.

Not a question. Not a command.

Marcus nodded. Slowly.

"Not tonight," Sibafuzi said. "But soon."

"Soon," Marcus agreed.

They sat in the cold kitchen. The fire in the living room had found its rhythm. The warmth was coming through now.

"We should get everyone," Marcus said.

Sibafuzi looked at him.

"Warmer in the living room," Marcus said. A shrug. "Might as well."

Sibafuzi stood up. He went upstairs and knocked on doors, gently, the apologetic knock of a man who had done his best to let everyone sleep.

The furnace. Come downstairs. Bring a blanket.

They gathered in the living room. All of them. Nali with her stone, Priya in the green sweater she'd had since before Marcus was born,

Zara with her notebook already in hand, Mateo bundled in his blanket like something being carried. The fire. The dark outside. The cold. The house holding them.

Nobody was angry. Nobody said: why didn't you fix it sooner. Nobody did the version of this that made it about anything other than what it was: a cold house, a fire, a family inside it, one night.

Mateo fell asleep on the rug with his head on Priya's knee. Nali and Priya talked quietly in the language they had. Zara wrote. Marcus leaned his head back against the sofa and watched the fire.

Sibafuzi sat in the armchair and looked at his family in the firelight and thought: this is also what it is.

All of it. The cost and the cold and the managed thing and this.

They'd been sitting in the living room for an hour when Zara looked up from her notebook.

"The packing entry," she said.

Priya looked at her.

"He wrote something about the furnace. At the end, before the closing. I wrote it down." She opened the notebook. Found the page. Read it back quietly — the secondary ignition, the panel, 1969, the key stiff, you have to press and hold. The key on the ledge, small, brass, no label.

Sibafuzi was already up.

He went to the front door. The ledge. The small brass key had been there since they moved in — he'd noticed it the first day, put it down as unimportant, a leftover.

He took it.

He went to the basement.

The panel was on the east side of the unit. He found it by feel in the dim light — a seam in the casing, painted over in the same flat grey as everything else. He pressed on the right side, the way you opened things in this house. It gave.

The secondary ignition was behind it. Stiff, the way his father had left it in 1969. Sibafuzi pressed and held.

The flame caught.

He stood in the basement and listened to the furnace run.

He went upstairs.

"Well?" Priya said.

"Fixed," he said.

Nobody said anything for a moment. Then Mateo, already half-asleep against Priya's side, said: "He knew we'd need it."

Nobody asked who.

The furnace man came in the morning anyway — Sibafuzi had called the number, the man was coming. He looked at the secondary ignition and said: I haven't seen one of these in twenty years. Your guy knew what he was doing.

Sibafuzi nodded.

"Yeah," he said. "He did."

Sibafuzi stood in the utility room listening to the furnace run properly and breathed.

Just breathed.

He was asleep in four minutes.

He woke up ready.

SOMEONE TO LOOK UP TO

A Novel

Parts Four, Five, and Six

* * *

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Fourth Day

The snow had stopped in the night.

Sibafuzi found out at six in the morning when he looked out the window and saw a sky with some color returning to it. Not blue yet — more a deep grey edging toward something — but different. Changed. The road was still buried, the cars still shapes, but the sky was doing something new and he stood there with his tea and watched it happen the way you watch something you hadn't been sure would come.

He'd called Alex the night before.

After dinner, after the kids were sorted, he'd gone out to the garage with his phone and stood in the cold with the door pulled most of the way shut, the garage light on, surrounded by boxes he hadn't dealt with yet. He'd stood there for a minute before dialling, just holding the phone, thinking about what the journal man had said about the lecturer: I knocked on his door. I told him what I wanted to say. I just said it.

Alex had picked up on the third ring and said: you're a hard man to reach.

Alex had said, about twenty minutes in, after the real things had started:

You know what I think about you?

Sibafuzi had said: no.

Alex had said: *I think you're the most capable person I know who most consistently underestimates what he's capable of. I've thought*

this for fifteen years. I've never said it because you would have told me I was projecting.

Sibafuzi had been quiet.

Alex had said: *Am I projecting?*

He'd said: no. Probably not.

Alex had said: *The house sounds right. The week sounds right. Call me when you're back.*

That was most of it. There had been other things — the families, the work, the running updates of two people who had known each other since they were twenty-two and had accumulated enough shared history to have their own shorthand. But that was the centre of it. That was what he'd gone to sleep with and woken up with.

You consistently underestimate what you're capable of.

He was forty-one years old. He had been aware of this tendency, obliquely, for years — aware the way you're aware of a habit you haven't decided to address yet. He was deciding to address it.

Not grandly. Not with a resolution or a plan. Just: noticing when he was doing it. Choosing the other version instead. The version that said: you are capable of this. Do it.

He put his mug in the sink.

He went to knock on Marcus's door.

He stood outside Marcus's door.

He could hear him — the faint sound of music through the headphones, the specific floor creak that meant Marcus was on the floor, which was where Marcus did his thinking.

He raised his hand to knock.

He thought about what he wanted to say. The email. The school. The handed-in versus not-handed-in, the practical version, the consequence version. He had it ready. Clear and fair.

He thought about the other thing. The words he'd said on Day Four. *I don't even know who you are.* He'd been carrying that since he'd said it, the specific weight of the thing you can't unsay, the thing

that stays in the air of a room. He didn't have a clean version of that conversation ready. He knew what he wanted to say but not how to say it without it landing wrong.

He thought: not yet.

He lowered his hand.

He went back downstairs. He made breakfast. He made enough for two.

Marcus came down twenty minutes later on his own. He sat at the table. He ate.

They didn't speak. But the silence was not the closed kind.

Not yet, *Sibafuzi thought*. But closer.

He'd find the moment.

And Sibafuzi had said: I know. I know I am.

And then they'd talked for forty minutes — real talk, the kind he hadn't done in longer than he'd been honest about. Work, and where it was going, and what the move had cost him and what it had given him and what he was trying to figure out. Alex had listened the way he always listened, which was completely, and had said things that were true and a few things that were uncomfortable and a few things that made Sibafuzi laugh in the way you laugh when something is funny and also accurate. By the end of it something had loosened in his chest that had been tight for longer than he'd admitted.

He'd come back inside and Priya was still up, reading at the kitchen table with the lamp on, one of those nights she needed a few more pages before she could sleep.

"Good call?" she said.

"Yeah."

She nodded and went up. He'd stood in the kitchen for a while, just standing in it, listening to the house tick and settle around him. The furnace doing its thing. The old pipes. The sound of a house that had been kept and was being kept again.

Now it was six in the morning and the sky was doing something new.

His house. Still smelled a little like other people.

Getting less so.

* * *

Nali was up not long after him.

She came into the kitchen and looked at him standing at the window and didn't say anything, just went to the kettle. He moved to give her access to the cups. She knew where everything was now — she'd mapped the kitchen that first week, quietly, the way she mapped all rooms, and now moved through it without hesitation.

"You called him, Fuzi," she said. Not a question.

"Last night."

"Good." She poured for both of them without asking. "How is he?"

"Good. Same. Better than I thought."

Nali handed him his cup and kept her own.

"You've been holding that one for a long time."

"I know."

The journal is doing something to you, she said. Not accusingly. Just noting it the way she noted things.

He'd been thinking about his father for three days without finding a way to say it.

Not because it was painful, exactly. More because it was complicated in the specific way of things that contained both good and bad in proportions that shifted depending on when you looked at them. His father was not a simple story. He was also not a villain, which was the thing that had taken Sibafuzi the longest to understand — that someone could leave in the way his father had left and still have been, in other ways, worth something. That the leaving didn't cancel everything that came before it. That a person could be both.

He'd been eight when his father left. Not quietly, not with a conversation, not with anything Sibafuzi could look back on as a proper goodbye. One week his father was there, the smell of his coat in the hallway, the particular sound of him getting up in the night to check on things, the way he laughed at his own jokes before the punchline, which had always driven his mother mad. The next week he was not there. The coat was gone. His mother stood in the kitchen and said some things that Sibafuzi had been too young to fully decode but had understood in the way children understand things before they have the vocabulary for them: *he went*. That was the essential fact. *He went*.

He had been gone for four years before the letters started. By then Sibafuzi was twelve, and twelve was old enough to receive a letter from a father you'd last seen when you were eight, and to understand that the letter was both an offering and an inadequacy at the same time. He'd read the letters. He'd kept them. He had them still, in a box in a cupboard in the house they'd left, which meant they were in that house right now while he was in this one, and he kept meaning to bring them with him and kept not bringing them, which he'd decided was fine, which he was not certain was fine.

His father had come back into his life at twenty-two. Not physically — he was in Canada by then, which turned out to be the reason he'd gone, the thing that had seemed impossibly large at the time and now seemed like simply a thing that happened, a man making a decision in a different era with different information and different desperation. He'd come back through a phone call, and then another, and then something that was not quite a relationship but was not nothing. Not enough. But not nothing.

He had his father's hands. He'd noticed this recently. He'd been doing something with a tool — putting up a shelf, something small — and he'd looked at his hands and thought: those are his hands. The shape of the knuckles. The way the left one held the screwdriver

slightly differently from the right. He'd seen his father working once, on a visit at twenty-five, and had watched his hands without knowing he was filing the image.

The journal man had written about picking up the torch. *I picked it up. That's how it works.*

He thought about the torch his father had put down. Not the bad parts — the leaving, the years of nothing, the coat gone from the hallway. Those were real. He didn't need to pretend they weren't. But also: the hands. The way he laughed before the punchline. The fact that he came back when he could. The fact that the letters were in a box that Sibafuzi had carried through six houses and not thrown away.

You could inherit the bad parts. You could also inherit the good ones. The trick — the work, the actual lifelong work — was choosing which parts you were going to carry forward and which parts you were going to put down.

He'd been putting things down this week. Slowly. One at a time. The Alex call. The step on the porch, the board he'd been looking at for three days. The conversation with Marcus that had cost him something to have, which was how you knew it was the right one.

The journal was doing something to him, yes. It was showing him the parts he'd been carrying that didn't need to be carried. Not throwing them away. Just: setting them on the shelf. Looking at them. Deciding what to do with them later, when there was more time and more room.

Give it time, Fuzi, his mother had said, the first morning, about the house.

He was beginning to think she was talking about more than the house.

"Is it obvious?"

"To me." She sipped her tea. "Not to the children. They're watching their own things."

Sibafuzi looked at her. His mother. Seventy-three years old, standing in a kitchen that was beginning to be hers in a house full of people she'd moved herself into because they needed her and she'd known it before they did. She'd called him from Lusaka at the start of November and said: I think I should come. He'd said you don't have to. She'd said I know. And then she'd come.

"Nali."

"Mm."

"Thank you. For coming."

She waved a hand like the thanks was beside the point — not dismissing it, just making clear she hadn't done it for thanks. But she was pleased. He knew that. He knew her face.

"Where else would I be?" she said. "Now. What is for breakfast."

He stood at the window for a long time.

The sky was doing something he'd been watching it do for an hour — deciding. The particular November sky above Collingwood had a quality he was beginning to recognise: it didn't commit to moods. It held several at once. Right now it was simultaneously gray, pale gold at the eastern edge, and in one precise section above the escarpment, a blue so clean it looked like a mistake. He kept watching that section, the clean blue, expecting it to be covered by the gray that flanked it. It didn't get covered. It stayed.

He thought about the call to Alex.

He'd been not-calling Alex for seven months. That was the honest version. Not just not getting around to it — consciously not calling, managing a small daily avoidance that he'd been polite enough with himself not to fully name. Alex had called three times in the spring. He'd texted back each time. Short texts, warm enough, the language of *I'm here, just busy*, which was code for *I'm here but I don't have the capacity for the real version of this yet*.

He'd called last night and Alex had picked up on the third ring and said *you're a hard man to reach* without any edge in it, just as a fact,

which was Alex's specific gift — the ability to state things that could wound without using them as wounds.

They'd talked for forty minutes. About real things. Not the managed things, not the update-the-record things, but the actual things underneath. Alex was three years further along a life that looked on the surface like Sibafuzi's — the family, the work, the choices with long consequences — and there was a specific comfort in talking to someone who was further along the path and could report back. Not wisdom. Just:

I've been here. Here's what it looks like from here.

He'd come back in and Priya was at the table and he'd said *good call* and meant it in both senses simultaneously and she'd known that and nodded and gone up, and he'd stood in the kitchen in the way he stood in kitchens when he needed a room to hold him for a bit, listening to the house at night, the pipes, the third stair, the attic hatch doing its cold-night expansion, and he'd felt something that he didn't yet have a name for. Something to do with the journal, with the way the journal was making him look at things differently — not at the world, at himself in it. The journal man had been trying his whole life, visibly, in writing, failing and getting up and trying again, and what was strange was how reassuring this was. Not inspiring, exactly. More like: *this is what it looks like. This is the normal texture of it. You've been assuming it should look different.*

He was ready for today in a way he hadn't been ready for any day this week.

He couldn't articulate it more precisely than that, and he'd stopped needing to articulate things more precisely than was honest.

He heard Nali on the stairs. He turned from the window to meet her.

It happened in the kitchen, which was where things happened in this house.

Sibafuzi had been going through his email — catching up, two days of it since the snow, the usual stack with nothing urgent except the one from the school forwarding officer. He'd almost missed it. It was from the new school, the Collingwood school, a courtesy copy of something they'd sent to both parents: a mid-term progress note flagging Marcus in two subjects for incomplete work submission.

Not failing. Not in trouble. Just — not handing things in.

He'd sat with it for ten minutes in the kitchen while the house was quiet. Then he'd gone upstairs.

He'd knocked. Marcus's voice: *yeah*.

He'd opened the door. Marcus was on the floor with his headphones on, which he took off when Sibafuzi came in, and Sibafuzi had held up his phone with the email open and said: *what is this*.

Marcus had looked at it and said nothing.

And something came loose in Sibafuzi that he had been managing carefully for two weeks — the furnace and the mortgage and the move and the argument about paint and the long silence between him and his son and the call to Alex and two nights of journal entries about men who kept trying even when things were hard — all of it came loose at once and came out not as what it actually was but as what was in front of him, which was a school email about a fifteen-year-old not handing in his assignments.

He said: *You have one job. One. And you can't even do that.*

He said: *You think this is hard? Try paying for it.*

He said, and this was the one he would think about later, the one he would carry: *I don't even know if you care about anything.*

Marcus looked at him. Not angry — anger would have been manageable. He looked at him with the closed expression, the one that meant the door was shutting, and Sibafuzi could see it shutting in

real time and couldn't stop it.

"Okay," Marcus said. Quietly. Just that.

Sibafuzi stood there for a moment with the phone still in his hand and the words already in the air where they couldn't be taken back.

He went downstairs.

He stood in the kitchen in his coat and thought: that is the third time.

Not the third time he'd snapped. He wasn't a man who snapped often — that was not the particular shape of his failures as a father. The third time he had said something that came from somewhere other than the truth. The first time Marcus had been eight and had broken something and Sibafuzi had said *I can't do anything right now, I can't*, and had meant the broken thing but Marcus had heard something else and had gone very still in the way that was worse than crying. The second time Marcus had been twelve, the second move, a school night, and Sibafuzi had said *I need you to not be difficult about this* and the word *difficult* had landed wrong and he'd known it the moment it left his mouth.

And now this. *I don't even know who you are.*

He had a theory, which he'd been developing quietly for about five years, that the worst parenting happened at the intersection of exhaustion and something older — some unexamined thing carried from further back than the current situation. The email wasn't about the email. The three weeks of managing, the mortgage, the furnace anxiety, the not-calling Alex: all of it had been sitting in him at compression. And Marcus's face in the doorway had been the specific face that unlocked the specific pressure.

He didn't think this excused it.

He'd read the journal man's mistake entry last night. *I made the error of trusting the version I wanted over the version that was actually there.* He'd understood that sentence personally, immediately, in the way you understood sentences that had already

described something true in your life before you'd found the words for it.

He was forty-one years old. He had been a father for fifteen years. He loved his son with the specific helpless force of it, the love that had no beginning he could locate, that had simply been there in the room the first time he'd held him in the hospital with the smell of the place still on him and the light coming through the blinds at a particular angle he would never forget.

He also, sometimes, got it wrong. In specific ways. At specific moments. Three times he could name with the quality of a person who has filed things carefully because he intends to be answerable to them.

The journal man had filed his too. He'd written them down. He'd kept them in the blue cloth book.

Sibafuzi took his coat off. He put it on the hook.

He was going to fix this — not now, not by forcing a conversation Marcus wasn't ready for, not by making his own guilt into a burden his son had to carry. The journal man's rule: *look at it clearly. Understand exactly what happened. Then do the other thing.*

He was going to do the other thing.

He just needed to find it.

He stood in the kitchen in his coat — he'd put his coat on for no reason, some vestigial impulse — and he stood there with the knowledge of what he'd said and the knowledge that it wasn't really about assignments and the knowledge that none of that made it unsaid.

Priya found him there ten minutes later.

She read him in one look. She didn't ask. She put her hand on his arm — just there, just briefly — and said nothing, because there was nothing to say yet, because this was the kind of thing that needed time before it needed words.

He took his coat off. Put it on the hook.

"I said something stupid," he said.

"I know."

"He's not going to—"

"Give it time," she said. "Fuzi. Give it time."

He nodded. He finished his tea. Then he went to find the journal because the journal was there and he needed somewhere to put himself that wasn't the middle of his own kitchen.

* * *

Mateo, who had been drawing at the table the whole time, counted the number of times his dad looked at the ceiling while he was standing there. He got to seven. Then he stopped counting because counting seemed like it was making something worse, and making things worse was the thing he most didn't want to do. He put down his pencil. He pushed his drawing — the one he'd been working on, the figure and the house and all the people in it — across the table toward his dad's empty place.

He went upstairs and knocked on Marcus's door.

After Dad and Marcus had their thing — Mateo didn't fully know what it was, he'd been drawing at the table, he'd heard it — he counted the number of times his dad looked at the door to Marcus's room. He got to nine before he stopped. Nine times in one evening. He wasn't going to tell Marcus that. But he thought Marcus might like to know, sometime, if there was a way to say it that didn't embarrass anybody.

"Marcus."

Nothing.

"I drew a picture of you. I put you in the house."

A long pause.

"Okay," Marcus said. Different tone to the one he'd used with Dad. Not the closed one.

"You want to see it?"

Another pause.

"Yeah. Bring it up."

Mateo went back downstairs, collected his drawing. Looked at it. Decided it was good enough. Went up.

* * *

Mateo woke up on the sofa under Marcus's blanket and seemed completely unbothered by not being in his bed.

He'd migrated there on Night Three, after those entries from when he moved into the house, after Sibafuzi had read that entry about the blank page and put his arm around him on the sofa. He'd simply not gone back upstairs. Nobody had said anything about it. He'd been sleeping on the sofa every night since with a contentment that suggested the sofa had been the right answer all along and it had just taken him a few days to find it.

"I slept here," he said, when Zara found him.

"You did."

He thought about this. The serious consideration he gave everything.

"It was good."

"The blanket was Marcus's."

Mateo looked at the blanket. Then at the stairs, as if Marcus was up there somewhere.

He folded it. Badly. But folded it.

"I'll give it back," he said.

Monde had been sleeping at the foot of the sofa, which nobody had planned and which had become, like most things with Monde, simply the way it was. The puppy looked up at Mateo. Mateo looked at the puppy.

"He slept here too," Mateo said.

"I see that."

"It was good for both of us."

Zara scratched behind Monde's ears and went to find breakfast.

* * *

They were all in the living room by mid-morning.

Priya had the journal. She'd been quiet all morning in a way that wasn't bad — the quiet of someone who'd been thinking carefully about something overnight and hadn't finished yet. She'd read ahead the previous night, just a few pages, enough to know the shape of what was coming.

"This next part," she said, holding the journal but not opening it. "It's the longest. And some of it is —" She looked at Sibafuzi. Then at the children. "It's the part where things get harder before they get better."

"Hard how?" Mateo said.

"Adult hard," Nali said. "You'll understand the feeling even if not all of the details. Just listen."

He accepted this. He was good at accepting things that were offered to him honestly.

Priya opened the journal.

THE JOURNAL

Age 23 to 32

She found the place and started.

* * *

September

first proper job.

actual salary.

I keep checking my account like it might have been a mistake.
the work is fine.
some of it is interesting.
some of it is just — work.
I didn't know that before.
that even good work has parts that are just work.
I think I thought I'd love every bit.
I don't.
I love enough of it.
that turns out to be enough.

* * *

November

there's a man at work. I'll call him Ray.
not his real name.
he's been here fifteen years.
he doesn't manage me but he's the one people go to.
not because of his title.
because of how he thinks.
he asks the question nobody else thought to ask.
in a meeting today he said one sentence.
one sentence.
and the whole room shifted.
I've been thinking about it since.
not the sentence.
the fact that he had it.
that he'd been sitting on it and he knew exactly when to put it
down.
I want to be like that one day.
I want to have the sentence.

* * *

"Ray," Sibafuzi said quietly.

Priya looked up.

"He changed the name."

"I know." Sibafuzi was half-smiling. "But still."

"What's the sentence?" Mateo said. "What did Ray say?"

"He doesn't tell us," Zara said. "That's the point. It's not about the sentence. It's about the person who has it. Who has been thinking long enough and carefully enough to have it when it's needed."

Mateo thought about this. Decided to accept it.

"Okay."

* * *

January

I've been noticing something.

the people I admire at work are not always the most successful.
some of them are.

but some of the most successful ones I don't admire at all.

and some of the ones I do admire haven't gone as far.

I'm trying to figure out what the difference is.

I think it's — what they did to get there.

or what they didn't do.

who they stayed being.

I'm filing this for later.

I'm going to watch and see if I'm right.

* * *

March

I met someone.

her name is Selin.

I'm not going to overwrite this because the last time I wrote about
someone like this I was twenty

and everything I wrote sounds like someone trying to win something.

so I'll just say.

she came to a talk at work.

she wasn't supposed to be there.

wrong room.

she stayed anyway.

we talked after.

she said three things that made me think.

I haven't stopped thinking.

that's a good sign I think.

or a bad one.

can't tell yet.

* * *

Priya looked up from the page. She was smiling a little.

"Wrong room," she said.

"Ay," Nali said. A warm sound.

"That's how things happen," Sibafuzi said. He said it to the fire.

"Wrong room."

Marcus was watching his dad. Something careful and interested in how he was sitting.

* * *

June

Selin.

that's it.

that's the entry.

I could write more.

I'm choosing not to.

some things are better kept whole.

* * *

That autumn

we argue.

I want to write that down before I only write the good bits.

we argue about real things.

she thinks I'm too careful sometimes.

too slow to say what I mean.

I think she moves before she's thought it through.

we're both right.

we're both wrong.

we're figuring it out.

it's uncomfortable and it's also — the most honest I've ever been
with someone.

which I didn't know I was missing until I had it.

* * *

"I like that he wrote the arguing bit," Zara said.

"Why?" Mateo said.

"Because he said he would. He said before I only write the good
bits. So he wrote the real bit too."

"He's keeping himself honest," Sibafuzi said.

"With himself," Priya said. "That's the hard one."

A small silence. The fire.

"Being honest with yourself," Nali said, "is the whole game.
Everything else comes from that. Or doesn't come."

* * *

Two years in

Ray got passed over for something.

someone less good got it.

I won't write more than that.
I watched Ray the day after.
he came in.
did his work.
asked the good questions.
said the things that mattered.
I went and found him at the end of the day.
I said I thought that was wrong.
he looked at me for a moment.
he said — I know. but I'd rather be the person who does good work
and loses
than the person who wins doing something I don't respect.
I said — does it not get to you.
he said — it got to me last night.
then I went to sleep.
then I came in.
that's how it works.
I've been thinking about that ever since.
it got to me last night.
then I went to sleep.
then I came in.
that's not nothing.
that's actually everything.

* * *

Sibafuzi had gone very still.

Priya paused. She didn't look at him. She just waited.

"Read it again," Marcus said. Quietly.

Priya read it again. The last part.

"It got to me last night. Then I went to sleep. Then I came in.
That's how it works."

Marcus had his knees pulled up, arms around them. Staring at the floor — not in a checked-out way. A thinking way.

"Is that what you do, Dad?" he said.

Sibafuzi looked at him.

"With work. When it goes wrong. Is that what you do?"

"I try to."

"Does it work?"

"Mostly. Not always." A pause. "Sometimes it gets to me the next day too."

"And then?"

"And then I come in anyway."

Marcus nodded slowly. Filed it. You could see him doing it — taking the thing and putting it somewhere deliberate.

Nali was watching her son with the expression she'd worn watching him his whole life. Taking stock. She had a quality of attention that he'd grown up under and never fully got used to — not uncomfortable, not pressuring, just completely present.

* * *

The same year — winter
there's a colleague.

Daniel.

we started the same time.

different track to me.

last month he quit.

just quit.

moved somewhere.

doing something completely different.

I heard about it and my first feeling was — good for him.

my second feeling was envy.

proper envy.

not of the thing he's doing specifically.
just — the decision.
the clean break.
the fact that he knew what he wanted and went.
I don't know if I want what he went to.
but I know that feeling.
wanting to be someone who knows.
I'm going to sit with that.
not act on it.
just sit with it.
I think sitting with things honestly is also a kind of bravery.
smaller.
but still.

* * *

"Envy," Zara said. Like it was interesting, like she was examining an object.

"Why is that interesting?" Marcus said.

"Because people don't usually say that. They say I was happy for him and leave it there."

"He said both," Priya said. "Happy for him first. Then envy."

"The order matters," Nali said.

"How?" Zara said.

"Because envy that comes after genuine happiness for someone — that's clean envy. Envy that tells you something about yourself. Not bad envy. Useful envy." She tilted her head. "Bad envy wants the person not to have the thing. Clean envy just wants the feeling for yourself."

Zara wrote it down. Marcus watched her write it.

"I had that," he said. Half to himself. "When Jordan started at the academy."

Nobody filled it.

"I was happy for him," Marcus said. "And then I wasn't. And then I hated that I wasn't."

"Clean envy," Nali said gently. "It tells you what you want. Not what you want to take."

Marcus looked at her for a long moment.

"Yeah," he said. "Okay."

* * *

Four years in — spring

Selin and I moved in together.

I keep writing single lines for the things that matter.

I think I'm scared to expand them.

like the more I write the more there is to lose.

which is backwards.

writing it doesn't make it more loseable.

it's already everything.

okay.

we moved in together.

she put a plant on the windowsill that I didn't choose and now I love.

we have one kitchen.

she hogs the good pan.

I let her.

it's the best I've ever felt.

* * *

Priya laughed. Short and warm.

"She hogs the good pan."

"I hog the good pan," Priya said to Sibafuzi.

"You do," he said.

"Do you let me?"

He looked at her. The real smile — the small one, the actual one.

"Every time."

Something passed between them. Quick. Small. Theirs.

Zara pretended to look at her notebook.

* * *

That winter

Ray is leaving.

different company. better title.

he deserves it.

I told him what he meant to me.

I've learned to say the thing.

I said — you changed how I think about this work.

he said — you were already thinking that way.

I just gave you somewhere to put it.

I've thought about that a lot.

maybe that's what the best people do.

they don't give you something new.

they show you what was already there.

they give you somewhere to put it.

Twenty-three

I want a house someday.

not a rental.

somewhere I can fix things and the fixing is mine.

somewhere the sounds at night are familiar because I made them
familiar.

somewhere I've earned the right to say: I know this place.

I don't know how long that takes.

I think it takes years.

I think years is the right amount of time.

I'm in no hurry.
but I want that.
I want to know a place the way you know a person.
I want the place to know me back.

* * *

Sibafuzi put his hand over his mouth. Looking at the floor.

Nali looked at him. She let him have it — didn't fill it, didn't look away, didn't say anything that would make it smaller than it was. She just stayed present, the way she'd learned to stay present with him when he needed it. The way she'd been doing it since he was small.

"Dad?" Zara said.

"I'm fine," he said. Voice steady. "Keep going."

Priya kept going.

* * *

Year six — autumn

something has been wrong for a while.
me and Selin.
not a thing.
just — a drift.
we still talk.
we still laugh sometimes.
we still know each other.
but we've been moving in slightly different directions.
not fighting.
not broken.
just — slowly pointing away.
I've known it for months.
I think she has too.
neither of us has said it.

I don't know which one of us will.
I don't know which would be harder.
saying it.
or waiting.

* * *

The room had shifted.

Mateo had gone quiet — he'd felt the tone change the way he felt most things, directly and completely, without the filter that older people developed. Marcus had gone still in a different way than before. More careful.

Priya was reading but not reading aloud yet. She'd looked ahead. Just one page. Then she'd looked at Sibafuzi.

He'd seen her look. He'd nodded. Go ahead.
She read on.

* * *

November

Selin said it.
she was right to.
we sat for a long time.
not arguing.
just — being honest.
which was the hardest and also the kindest thing.
she said — I think we've been trying to want the same things.
and I think we don't.
I didn't argue.
I knew.
I've known.
we held on for a bit after.
I won't write that part.

that part is just ours.
then I left.
I walked for a long time.
ended up somewhere I didn't recognise.
took me a while to find my way back.
I think that's about right.

* * *

Priya looked at the next page. She looked at it for a moment.

"There's nothing," she said quietly. "Just the date. Nothing written."

Nobody said anything.

"That is the entry," Nali said. Softly.

Zara was looking at her notebook but not writing. Her pen still.

Mateo had moved close to Sibafuzi on the sofa without anyone tracking it. Just ended up there. Sibafuzi put an arm around him without looking down.

Monde settled against the sofa.

* * *

Three weeks after that
still here.

* * *

Priya read those two words and stopped.

The fire. The snow-light through the window. The quiet house on Bishop Street.

"Still here," Marcus said. Like he was checking they had all heard it.

"Still here," Zara said back.

Nali didn't say anything. Her eyes were wet. She didn't wipe them. She just sat there and let it be what it was — she'd learned, over a life of things, that not everything needed to be held together. Some things you let come through.

Sibafuzi was looking at the floor. His hand on Mateo's shoulder, Mateo leaning into him.

"Sibafuzi," Priya said softly.

He looked up at her. She held the journal out to him. Open.

He looked at it. Then at her.

"You read it," he said.

She nodded. She read it.

* * *

A month on

I've been thinking about what I was.

and what I am now.

they're not the same.

which I think is right.

I was someone who needed a particular kind of person.

I didn't know that until I had one and then didn't.

now I know.

I also know that I was loved well for a time.

that doesn't go away.

it becomes part of what you're made of.

I'm grateful.

even now.

especially now.

I think grateful is the thing on the other side of grief.

you don't get there straight away.

but if you keep going you find it.

I found it.

not all the way.
but I found the edge of it.
that's enough for now.

* * *

Six months on

I am not the same person who moved in with Selin.
I'm also not different in the ways I was afraid I might be.
I thought grief might take something permanently.
it didn't.
it took some things temporarily.
and left some things.
harder things.
better things.
I'm quieter now.
not sad quiet.
thinking quiet.
I like it.
I think this is who I actually am.
maybe I needed all of that to find out.

* * *

"He's alright," Marcus said.

"He is," Priya said.

"More than," said Nali. She was wiping her eyes now, quietly, the way she did housekeeping. "He did the work. Not everyone does the work. He did it."

"What's the work?" Mateo said.

"Feeling it. All of it. Not hiding it or rushing it. Just — going through."

"Like a tunnel," Mateo said.

"Exactly like a tunnel. You can't go over or under. You go through. And the other side is different. That's the work."

Mateo nodded. Reached for the figure on the cushion beside him. Held it.

* * *

The year after

I met Nadia at a thing I nearly didn't go to.

I've been trying to go to things I nearly don't go to.

it's a rule I made for myself after everything.

Nadia was there.

we talked for a bit.

she was easy to talk to.

not in the way that means nothing.

in the way that means something is already right.

she didn't ask me to be anything.

that sounds small.

it wasn't.

* * *

Months later

I'm going to try not to compare.

Nadia is not Selin.

Selin was not Adaeze.

they're all just people.

themselves.

and I'm a different version of myself each time.

I don't want to get it wrong by dragging the old into the new.

so I'm trying to just — see her.

as she is.

she's patient.

I didn't know I needed patient.
I need patient.
she's also funny in a way that sneaks up on you.
like you're already laughing before you knew the joke was coming.
I like that a lot.

* * *

Priya laughed at that one. Soft and real.
"Funny in a way that sneaks up on you," she said.
Sibafuzi was looking at her.
"What?" she said.
He shook his head. But he was smiling — the small real one.
Nali looked between them and said nothing, which was exactly
right.

* * *

A year with Nadia

I've been thinking about what love is when you're older.
not old.
just older than you were.
it's quieter.
it's not less.
just quieter.
less about the feeling and more about the choice.
every day you choose.
I choose.
not because I have to.
because I want to.
that difference matters.
I think when you're young you think love is something that
happens to you.

and it is, at first.
but then it becomes something you do.
and the doing is better.
the doing is the whole thing.

* * *

Priya put the journal down on her knee.
She sat with it for a moment. Just sat.
"Priya," Sibafuzi said.
She looked at him.
He didn't say anything. He just held her eyes for a moment the way
you hold something you're reminding yourself to value —
deliberately, with full attention, not looking past it.
She nodded once. Something small and entire.
"Keep going?" Marcus said from the floor. His voice careful. Like
he knew what room he was in.
"Keep going," Priya said.

* * *

That winter
I've been thinking about what I want.
not what I want from work.
not what I want from Nadia.
just — what I want to be.
I keep coming back to the same thing.
I want to be someone people can point at.
not pointing famous.
just — pointing like my mum pointed at that neighbour.
someone doing something that costs them something.
and doing it anyway.
I don't know what my version of that is yet.

but I want to find it.
I want to be worth the pointing.
that's what I want.

* * *

Zara had stopped writing.

She was looking at the journal with an expression that meant something had just settled into place for her — the specific look she got when pieces connected, when the pattern became visible.

"That's the whole book," she said. "What he just wrote. That's the whole thing."

Nobody argued with her.

"He's been building to that his whole life, my dear," Nali said. "Since he was small. That woman on his mother's street. The neighbour. She planted something in him before he was born, through his mother. And here it is." She touched her own chest. "Here it is."

"He doesn't know what his version is yet," Marcus said.

"No," said Nali.

"Does he find it?"

"Keep reading."

* * *

Spring — the year after

Nadia said something last night.

she said — I see you.

not like a big thing.

just in the middle of something else.

we were washing up.

she said — I just want you to know. I see you.

I put down what I was holding.

I said what do you mean.

she said — the way you try. the way you think about things.
the way you're always trying to be better than you were.
I see it.
I didn't know what to say.
I said thank you.
she said you don't have to thank me.
I said I know. thank you anyway.
she laughed.
we finished the washing up.
I'm going to keep that.
forever, I think.

* * *

Priya's voice had gone quiet reading that one.

She finished it and the room stayed still for a moment. A full, heavy, right kind of still.

"I want someone to say that to me," Zara said. Not sad. Just honest.

"I see you," Mateo said immediately. Looking at her.

Zara looked at him. Something moved in her face.

"Thanks, Mateo."

"I see you too," he said to Marcus. Then to Sibafuzi. Then he looked at Nali. "And you. I see all of you."

The room had gone very warm, very suddenly.

Marcus put his hand briefly on top of Mateo's head. The way older brothers do. The gesture that means: I received that and I acknowledge it and I'm going to pretend it's casual. Mateo accepted it like it was currency.

Nali made a sound that wasn't any language. Just feeling, come out.

Sibafuzi looked at the ceiling. His jaw. The complicated thing.

Priya picked up the journal.

"Almost there," she said. "Last few entries of this era."

* * *

End of the year

I turned thirty.

I thought I'd feel something dramatic about that.

I didn't.

just — the day.

Mum rang first.

Dad second.

Dad never rings first.

he said sorry I missed you.

I said you didn't miss me, I'm right here.

he laughed.

I think he meant he rang late.

I think I knew that.

I let him off.

he's my dad.

I let him off everything.

I don't think I used to.

I think I grew into it.

forgiving your parents for being people is a thing that takes time.

March

I've been thinking about my dad again.

He retired last year.

Built himself a workshop in the garden from scratch. Just decided one day that was what he was going to do and did it. He's been making furniture ever since. A bench first. Then a table. Now a cabinet he's been working on for six weeks — I've seen it when I call, he sets the laptop up so I can see it. He's sixty-seven years old and he

looks like someone who has finally arrived somewhere they've been heading for a long time.

I keep thinking: why didn't he do this thirty years ago. What did he spend thirty years waiting for.

But then I think: it doesn't matter. He found it. Even at sixty-seven. Even when most of it was already done. He found the thing and he started doing it and that's the whole story, isn't it. You can start any time. You can begin at sixty-seven. The beginning isn't the point. The beginning is just when you stop waiting.

Sibafuzi put the journal down.

Not closed it. Put it down on the cushion beside him with it still open, like he wasn't done with it but needed distance from it.

"That's not right," he said.

The room went quiet in a different way.

"Which part?" Priya said carefully.

"The part where it doesn't matter that he waited thirty years." He looked at the journal. "It matters. The thirty years matter. You don't just — the beginning isn't just when you stop waiting. The waiting has a cost. He's saying it doesn't."

Zara was watching him. Her pen had stopped moving.

"Maybe he means it for himself," Priya said. "Not as a general—"

"He's writing it like a rule. Like he worked something out." Sibafuzi shook his head. "He didn't work it out. He was thirty-whatever years old watching his dad build a cabinet at sixty-seven and calling it arriving somewhere. His dad spent thirty years in the wrong thing. That's thirty years he didn't do the thing he was supposed to do. That means something. You don't get those back."

Nobody said anything.

"I'm not saying he shouldn't have found it," Sibafuzi said. His voice was flat, not angry — something more exhausted than angry. "The workshop. Good. Genuinely good. But you can celebrate the

finding without pretending the not-finding didn't happen. He's pretending it didn't happen."

Marcus was looking at him.

"Maybe," Marcus said slowly, "he knows it happened. Maybe that's why he had to write it that way."

Sibafuzi looked at his son.

"If you already know the cost," Marcus said, "maybe you write it without the cost because you need to get to the other side of it. Not because you think it's not there."

Silence.

Sibafuzi looked at the journal. At the entry, open on the cushion beside him.

He'd been carrying something for thirty years. Not the same thing. But something. And he'd put it down recently — or started to — and he was only now seeing the shape of what the carrying had weighed. He didn't know how to write about that yet. Maybe when you couldn't write about it honestly you wrote around it, the way the boy had. You wrote to the other side.

"Maybe," he said.

He picked the journal back up.

"Keep going," he said. "I'm not done with it. I'm just — keep going."

Priya looked at Marcus. Marcus looked at his hands. But something in the room had shifted: the journal wasn't holy. It was just a person, trying, getting some things right and some things not, writing toward something he could feel but not fully see. Same as everyone.

That made it more trustworthy, not less.

I'm there now.

it feels good.

that's all I have to say about thirty.

* * *

Sibafuzi laughed. Short, surprised, a little helpless.

"What?" Marcus said.

"Forgiving your parents for being people." He shook his head.
"Took him thirty years."

"Is that slow?" Zara said.

"No," said Nali firmly. "For some people it is never. Thirty is fast."
She looked at Sibafuzi. "For some people thirty is very fast."

Sibafuzi looked back at his mother. Something between them — old and specific and none of the children's business and all of it, at the same time, somehow everything.

"I know," he said.

She nodded.

* * *

Two years later — May

she's here.

born 4.47 in the morning.

Nadia did something I will never be able to describe.

I watched it happen.

she was incredible.

then they put her in my arms.

the baby.

our girl.

she looked at me.

I know they say newborns can't really see.

she looked at me.

I'm telling you.

she looked at me like she already knew me.

like she'd been coming to find me.

I'm going to try to be worth that.

that's the whole plan now.
that's everything.
I'm going to try to be worth that look.

* * *

Priya stopped.

She wasn't going to cry. She was just stopped.

Mateo had climbed up onto the sofa properly and was pressed against Sibafuzi's side, both of them looking at the fire. Sibafuzi's arm around him.

Zara was looking at Nali.

Nali was looking at the journal with an expression that had a lot of years in it. All the houses. All the mornings. All the looking up and putting her hands on walls.

"Nali," Zara said softly.

"Hm."

"Is that — is that how it felt? When Dad was born?"

Nali was quiet for a long moment.

"Yes," she said finally. "Exactly like that. You look at them and you think — you've been coming to find me. You just took the long way." She looked at Sibafuzi. Then at Marcus. Then at Zara. Then she looked at Mateo for a beat longer than the others. "All of you. Each one. You found us."

Mateo looked at her from inside Sibafuzi's arm. His eyes bright.

"Even me?" he said.

"Especially you," Nali said. Firm. Complete. The one word that meant everything it meant. "Especially."

Mateo leaned his head back against Sibafuzi's ribs.

Sibafuzi pulled him closer.

Nobody said anything for a while. The fire crackled. The snow-light through the window. The house around them doing what

Nali had said good houses did.
Holding them.

* * *

Three months on
I've been thinking about who I was.
the boy in the doorway.
watching his parents in the kitchen.
just wanting to stay.
I do the same thing now.
different doorway.
Nadia with the baby.
early morning.
the light coming in.
I stand there and I don't say anything.
I just want to stay in it.
some things don't change.
I used to think that was sad.
now I think it's the opposite.
the best things — the things that made you — they stay.
not the same.
but recognisable.
you can trace the line.
from the boy on the floor to the man in the doorway.
same feeling.
same need.
different life.
and it's enough.
it's more than enough.
it's everything.

* * *

Priya closed the journal.

She held it in both hands in her lap for a moment.

The room was very quiet. Mateo was almost asleep against Sibafuzi. Marcus had his head back against the sofa, looking at the ceiling with the expression he wore when he was trying to hold something still long enough to feel all of it. Zara was sitting with her notebook closed in her lap, pen in hand, not writing. Just sitting. Nali had her eyes closed — not sleeping. Somewhere else, briefly, the way she sometimes went.

Sibafuzi was looking at Priya.

She looked back.

"Hey," he said.

"Hey," she said back.

It wasn't a whole conversation. It was just those two words. But those two words had more in them than a whole conversation would have held, and they both knew it, and the room knew it, and Marcus heard it and looked at his parents for a moment before looking away.

He was smiling.

* * *

That evening Sibafuzi found the cassette tape.

He'd picked it up off the coffee table — it had been sitting there with the other things from the box all this time, passed over, unlabelled — and turned it in his hands. A standard cassette in a cracked plastic case. Could be anything. Music. A voice. A song someone had needed to keep.

"Nali," he said. "Did you bring that little tape player? The old one?"

She looked at him over her reading glasses.

"You told me to travel light."

"I know."

"So no. I did not bring the tape player." She looked at the cassette. Then at him. "You can't listen to everything, you know. Some things you just have to wonder about."

Sibafuzi turned the cassette over. Unlabelled. Waiting.

He put it back on the table.

"Maybe we'll find one," he said.

"Maybe," Nali said. "Or maybe you keep it. And wonder. That's allowed too."

* * *

THE JOURNAL

Age 33 to 43

Priya turned the page.

"New era," she said.

She read the heading. Looked up at Sibafuzi.

He was already looking at her.

"The House," Mateo said. Reading it upside down. He could read most things upside down. "Which house?"

Nobody answered. Because something had shifted in the room — something small but definite, a change in atmosphere, the way pressure drops before weather arrives. Zara had her pen ready. She didn't know why yet. But she had her pen ready.

"Keep going," Nali said.

We've moved.

Nadia found the house.

I want to be clear about that.

I drove up and down the street three times before I went in. small town on Georgian Bay, base of the escarpment.

I said: are you sure.

she said: yes.

I said: it's far from everything.
she said: it's far from everything we were trying to get away from.
that's different.
she was right.
she's usually right.
the house is on a street called Bishop.
Victorian.
the porch sags slightly on the left side.
there are two silver maples in the front that in October do
something that has no name in English.
I asked around. the town has a word.
the word is: theirs.
I'm trying to learn what that means.
Year three in this house
the furnace died in January.
I want to document this because I handled it worse than I should
have.
I knew it was old. I had been watching it the way you watch old
things — with the particular vigilance of someone who knows they
can't afford for it to fail but can't afford to replace it either.
it failed.
three days before Nadia's parents were due to visit.
I handled it by standing in the basement for twenty minutes not
moving.
then I called the number.
the man came.
the part was available.
the cost was significant but not impossible.
I had the money for it.
I hadn't known I had the money for it until I needed it.
I've been thinking about this.

I had been so certain the failure would break something — that the cost would be the cost that undid the whole structure — that I'd made the fear bigger than the fact.

the fact was a broken furnace and a bill.

the fear was everything I'd built collapsing because of a furnace.

the fear was not proportional.

I'm trying to get better at keeping the fear proportional to the fact.

I'm not all the way there.

I'm working on it.

Sibafuzi put his head down.

Not dramatically. Just — his chin to his chest for a moment, looking at the floor.

"Fuzi," Priya said.

He didn't answer for a second.

"The furnace," he said.

"I know."

He looked at her. Then at the journal.

"He was afraid of the same—" He stopped. "Not the same thing. But the shape of it. The same shape of the fear."

"I know," she said again.

He looked at the journal. The man who had lived in this house. Who had stood in the basement for twenty minutes not moving before he called the number. Who had written it down because he knew what he was doing wrong and couldn't stop himself and wanted to be honest about the gap between knowing and doing.

"He fixed it," Marcus said. From the floor.

Everyone looked at him.

"He called the number," Marcus said. "And it was expensive but he had the money. And he fixed it."

Sibafuzi looked at his son.

"Yeah," he said.

"So you'll fix it. When it happens."

He meant: *if*. Or maybe he meant: *when*. Either way the sentence held.

"I'll fix it," Sibafuzi said.

Mateo nodded, satisfied, and went back to his drawing.

"Keep going," Nali said.

Mateo had gone completely still.

He was looking at the journal in Priya's hands with the expression he used for things that required full attention — both hands on his knees, sitting forward.

"Bishop," he said.

"Yes," Priya said.

He turned and looked at the window. The east-facing kitchen window, the one that caught the morning, the one Sibafuzi had been standing at since the first day. He looked at it for a moment. Then back at the journal.

"He was here," he said.

"He was here."

Mateo absorbed this completely. Filed it. Then:

"The silver maples are still there," he said. "I see them every morning."

The room was very quiet.

"Keep going," he said. "Please."

The house has a history I'm still learning.

built before the last century.

you can feel it in the walls.

not weight — something else.

presence.

like the rooms have been used well and remember it.

the study has shelves that someone built in.

floor to ceiling.

good wood.

level.

the kind of shelves that say: I built these for a life, not a rental.

I stood in there the first week and thought: someone was happy here.

not happy without difficulty.

happy despite difficulty.

there's a difference and rooms know it.

Sibafuzi put his hand over his mouth.

It was a small movement. Not dramatic. He did it the way you do it when something has arrived that you weren't prepared for and you need a moment before it gets to your face.

Priya looked at him.

"What?" Marcus said.

Nobody answered. Priya was looking at Sibafuzi. Sibafuzi was looking at the journal.

"I said those words," he said finally. Very quiet. "I built these for a life, not a rental. I said them. On the phone. Before we arrived."

The room held that.

"Not those exact—" Priya started.

"Those exact words."

She stopped. She knew it was true. She'd been in the kitchen when he'd called his brother and said it. Those words.

Zara was writing.

Nobody spoke for a moment.

Nali had the stone in both hands. She was looking at her son.

"Keep going," Sibafuzi said. His voice was steady. He needed to know what else was in there.

The street has a church at the end of it.

St. Andrew's.

Presbyterian.

built 1889.

I know the year because it's carved into the stone above the door, which I've walked past enough times that I know it the way you know

the furniture in your own house.

it has a particular light in the evening.

the steeple catches the last of the sun about fifteen minutes after everywhere else has gone grey.

I've been watching it for three months.

I don't know what to do with that.

I don't go in.

but I watch the light on it.

that feels like something.

maybe enough.

She is six months old.

she's been in this house for six months.

I keep thinking: this is the world to her.

not small town on Georgian Bay.

not a specific house on a specific street.

just: the world.

the east window in the mornings — that's what light is.

the sound of the silver maples in October — that's what autumn sounds like.

the creak of the third stair — that's what coming home sounds like.

she'll carry all of this and never know she's carrying it.

the way I carry things from my first house and still don't know the half of them.

Priya stopped.

"The east window," she said.

She was looking at it. The window she'd been making soup in front of for three days. The window Sibafuzi stood at every morning.

"He watched the same light," Marcus said.

"His daughter watched the same light," Zara said. "Before she could even name it."

Mateo was already at the window. He'd gotten up without anyone noticing and gone to stand at it. He looked out at Bishop Street, at the

silver maples, at the church at the far end with its steeple beginning to catch the last of the afternoon.

He stood there for a moment.

Then he said, very quietly, to himself or to the room or to no one in particular:

"The light is still here."

He came back and sat down.

The room was so still you could hear the fire.

"Keep going," he said.

The Hendersons moved in March.

three cars.

I helped with the boxes.

they're going to Hamilton.

work, he said.

I said: there's no work here?

he looked at me like I'd asked something that was beyond answering.

he said: this kind of work, no.

I helped with the last boxes.

we shook hands.

I watched the cars go.

Bishop Street felt wider after.

I don't know how a street can feel wider.

but it did.

The Nguyens six months later.

the bakery on Pine has been replaced by a coffee thing from somewhere else.

it has a sign in a font that means: we know you want this to feel like somewhere else.

the old sign had the baker's name on it. Kowalski. thirty years. his daughter ran it after him.

I still go in.

the coffee is fine.

I don't say anything about the sign.

what would I say.

Marcus had been very still through those entries.

He was on the floor by the fireplace, knees up, arms resting. He was looking at something in the middle distance, not the fire, not the journal, something between them.

"He watched it happen," he said.

"The town," Zara said.

"People leaving." He paused. "And he stayed."

"He chose it," Priya said.

Marcus nodded slowly. Not agreement — something more complicated. The nod of someone who has left, who knows both sides of it.

"The people who stay," he said. "They know something."

Nali looked at him over her reading glasses.

"Yes," she said. Simply. No elaboration.

Marcus looked at the fire.

I've been thinking about what it means to stay somewhere.
not philosophically.

just: what it actually means.

on a Tuesday.

you go to the same post office.

you say good morning to the same woman who has worked there
for twenty years.

she knows your name.

not because you're interesting.

because you kept coming back.

that's all it takes to be known somewhere.

you keep coming back.

Year two

I know people now.

not many.

but enough.

the man at the hardware shop on the main street. his name is Gerald. he's been there since before I was born.

he doesn't remember my name most times. but he remembers what I've been working on. every time I come in he asks: how did that go. and I tell him. and he says what I should have done differently. he's always right.

the woman who walks the retriever on Bishop Street at six every morning. we nod. we've been nodding for two years. we've said good morning approximately four hundred times. I still don't know her name. I don't think that matters. the nod is the thing.

the librarian at the branch on Pine who has strong opinions about what I should be reading and has been right three times out of five, which is a better average than most people I know.

I used to think you needed a lot of people to feel known somewhere.

I was wrong.

you need a few people who know the specific things about you that matter to them.

Gerald knows I'm bad at measuring twice.

the retriever woman knows I'm always up early and always carrying something.

the librarian knows I need to be told what to read or I'll just read the same kind of thing forever.

that's enough.

that's being known.

"The retriever woman," Mateo said.

"What about her?"

"She's still on this street. I see her. Every morning. A different dog now. But the same woman. Same time."

The room let that land.

"Year two for him," Sibafuzi said. "He wrote that entry in year two."

"He was here for ten years," Marcus said. "So she's been doing it for at least — " He counted.

"At least twenty years," Zara said. "Probably more."

Mateo looked at the window. Toward the street. The morning dog walk he'd been watching every day through the east window, the woman with the gray hair and the retriever who pulled left at the corner.

"She knew him," he said. They all knew what he meant.

"And she doesn't know she's in his journal," Zara said.

"Most people don't know they're in someone's journal," Nali said.

She turned the stone over once.

"That doesn't mean they're not."

Spring, year four

the lilac.

I give up.

it does what it wants.

it has grown so far over the fence that two of the cedar panels are now subjects of the lilac.

in May it blooms for approximately nine days and during those nine days the entire back garden smells like a specific kind of joy that I've been trying to describe for four years and cannot.

Nadia says: stop trying to describe it. just come outside.

she's right.

I've been learning this lesson for eleven years and I'm about sixty percent of the way there.

Priya laughed. Just briefly. The specific laugh of reading something that is both funny and true.

"Sixty percent," she said.

"Same as me," Sibafuzi said. Dry.

She looked at him. He was looking at the journal with an expression she recognized from seventeen years of marriage: the expression of a man who has found himself in a book he didn't write.

She took his hand.

He held on.

Keep going, she didn't need to say.

He was already reading.

I used to think that was small.

I think now it might be the whole thing.

The house has a sound at night.

not alarming.

not a haunting.

just: the sound of a thing that is old and has held a lot and is still doing it.

the pipes.

the third stair.

the specific creak of the attic hatch when the temperature drops.

I know all of these now.

I know them the way I know Nadia's breathing beside me.

not consciously.

as fact.

as the given texture of things.

when I don't hear them I notice the absence.

that's when you know a place has become home.

not when it's familiar.

when its silence is louder than its sounds.

She is four

she has started coming to find me in the study.

not for anything.

she just comes in and looks at what I'm doing and then goes and does something nearby.

she doesn't need me to interact.

she just needs to know I'm in the same room.

I've started thinking of this as the highest form of trust.

not needing anything from someone.

just needing them present.

I had this with my father, for a while, before he left.

I remember the version of it I had. Sitting on the floor in the doorway of whatever room he was in. Not wanting to talk or be noticed. Just wanting to stay.

same feeling.

different doorway.

"He wrote it," Marcus said. Very quiet. He was looking at the journal.

Priya had stopped reading.

"He wrote that sentence," Marcus said. "Same feeling. Different doorway. He wrote it about his own daughter."

Nobody had to say the other part. They'd heard Zara read it back, the first day — the early entry, the boy sitting on the floor, the not wanting to change the thing he was looking at.

"He was his own father's son," Nali said. "And his daughter's father. At the same time. As we all are."

The fire. The room. The three generations in it.

Zara wrote something. Read it back silently. Nodded.

Mateo had his hand on the figure.

He didn't say anything. He was in both doorways at once and knew it.

Year seven in this house

she asked me today how long we're staying.

I said: as long as we can.

she said: forever?

I said: I don't know about forever. But long.

she was quiet. then she said: good.

she went back to what she was doing.

I sat with that.
good.
like it was simple.
like she was nine and had figured something out that had taken me
thirty years.
maybe staying is simple and we make it complicated.
maybe long is enough.
maybe long is everything.
Sibafuzi looked up from the journal.
He looked at Mateo, who was six.
"How long are we staying?" he said.
Mateo looked at the east window. At the silver maples. At the
church steeple visible above the fence line, pale in the winter sky.
"Long," he said.
He turned back to the room.
"Long is good."
Something shifted in Sibafuzi's face. Not dramatically. Just:
something he'd been carrying, set down.
"Yes," he said. "It is."
"Keep reading, Fuzi," Nali said.
He kept reading.
The garden is doing what it wants.
there's a lilac at the back fence that I attempted to govern in year
one.
it ignored me completely.
year two I stopped trying.
it's enormous now.
in May it does something that I have no words for.
Nadia says: we can cut it back.
I say: absolutely not.
she looks at me.
she knows.

the lilac is not mine and I am not the lilac's but we have an understanding.

it stays.

I stay.

we're both doing the same thing.

Nali made a sound. The specific one — not a word, just a sound, the one that meant something had gone somewhere it needed to go.

"The lilac," Zara said. She was looking toward the back garden through the window. The enormous leggy lilac at the back fence, the one she could see from the kitchen on her tiptoes. "He grew the lilac."

"He let it grow," Nali said. "Different thing."

She looked at the stone in her hand.

"I found my stone near the back fence," she said. Quietly. Not to anyone. Just saying it to the room, because the room deserved it.

The room held it.

There's a boy on our street.

nine, ten, somewhere there.

I know him to wave to.

he comes past on his bicycle every day after school.

every day, he waves.

not just a hand — a whole-arm thing, committed, like waving is something you do properly or not at all.

I wave back.

we've never spoken.

it's been two years.

I've been thinking about that.

about what that is.

it isn't friendship.

it isn't nothing.

it's something that doesn't have a name because nobody thought to name things that don't grow.

but I'd notice if it stopped.

I'd notice on the first day he didn't come past.
maybe that's the name for it.
the thing you'd notice if it stopped.

"The thing you'd notice if it stopped," Zara said. She was writing.
She kept writing for a moment after she said it.

Sibafuzi was looking at the journal.

"That's it," he said. "That's what a hero is. The thing you'd notice if it stopped."

The room understood that. You could feel it understood — the particular quality of silence that follows a thing that was already true but needed to be said to become fully true.

"The house," Priya said.

"Yes."

"The town. The church at the end of the block."

"Yes."

"The light through the east window."

Sibafuzi looked at the window. The light that was still there. That had been there when he was born, in the sense that light like that had always existed. That would be there when he was gone, in the same sense.

"Yes," he said.

Mateo was looking at the figure. Ray. On the windowsill.

"People too," he said. Checking.

"People too," Nali said. "All the same thing."

Mum came to visit.

she walked through the house the way she does.

I watched her from the hall.

she put her hand on the wall in the east bedroom.

left it there a moment.

I know that gesture.

she's done it her whole life.

she does it in houses she wants to understand.

she came back out and said: good bones.

I said I know.

she said: more than that. can you feel it?

I said I think so.

she said: it's been loved.

she had my daughter on her hip and she looked around the front room and she said it the way you say things that are true and also too large to explain.

it's been loved.

I thought about all the other families.

all the other people who had stood in this room.

all of them trying.

all of them failing a little, succeeding a little, mostly just going about it.

the room held all of it.

rooms do.

Priya stopped. Her eyes were wet. She didn't look up.

Nali was looking at the wall. The same wall. She had put her hand on it, when she arrived, on the first day. She had felt what the journal man's mother felt. She had said the same words.

Sibafuzi looked at his mother.

She looked back.

Something passed between them that had no language. Not in any language. Just between a mother and her son, in a room that had been loved, on a street that was still itself, in a small town that had stayed.

"Read the rest," he said. Very quiet.

Priya read the rest.

Ten years in this house.

I didn't mean to count.

Nadia pointed it out.

she said: ten years in this house.

I looked up from what I was doing.

I said: has it been.
she said: it has.
we both went quiet.
not because ten years is a long time.
because it isn't.
ten years in a house you love is not a long time.
it's the time it takes to really start knowing it.
I know it now.
I know the third stair.
I know the way the east window catches October at an angle it
doesn't catch any other month.
I know the creak of the attic hatch.
I know the lilac.
I know Bishop Street in every weather.
the church at the end, its steeple catching the last light fifteen
minutes after everywhere else.
I know the sound of this house in the night when it is full and
when it is not.
I know what it is to have somewhere.
not everyone gets that.
I know that now.
I didn't know it for years.
now I do.
I've been thinking about what my mum said about doing
something that costs you something.
she meant people.
she was talking about people.
but I've been thinking about it in this house for ten years and I
think she meant more than she knew.
places do it too.
a town that doesn't go when everyone else goes.
a house that holds what it's given.

a street that stays a street even when the shops change and the faces change and the young move away for the work that's somewhere else.

a feeling.

a particular morning in September, the light through the east window at that angle.

a lilac that does what it wants in May.

the sound of the third stair.

these things persist.

they don't stop being themselves when the world stops noticing them.

they're just there.

holding.

I think that's heroism.

I think it's the same thing.

I think my mum was right about people and also right about more than she knew.

some things just persist.

and the persistence is the whole thing.

and that's enough.

it's everything.

Priya stopped reading.

She looked at the journal in her hands.

The room was very still.

Outside, Bishop Street held what it held. The silver maples. The church. The east window with its particular light. The third stair that creaked. The attic hatch. The lilac at the back fence, enormous, leggy, doing what it wanted. The stone Nali had found in the garden, warm in her hand from being kept close.

All of it persisting.

All of it still there.

Mateo looked at the window.

"The light is still here," he said.

He'd said it before. He said it again because it was still true.

"Yes," Nali said. Soft. "It is, my dear. It is."

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Fifth Day

The road was beginning to show through.

Not clear. Not passable. But you could see the dark line of it under the white — asphalt returning to itself, doing the slow work of being a road again. By tomorrow, maybe. By the day after, definitely. Sibafuzi stood at the kitchen window with his tea in the early morning and watched it with the feeling of something you've been told to expect and are now seeing and still find surprising.

He'd slept properly. He couldn't remember the last time. Not the managed sleep of someone managing everything, but actual sleep — full, uninterrupted, the kind that left you feeling like you'd been somewhere and come back. He'd woken at six and lay there for a few minutes listening to the house and thinking about nothing specific and it had been, unexpectedly, fine.

The house still smelled a little like other people.

Getting less so.

Down the block, St. Andrew's was beginning to be visible again too — the snow still thick on the roof, the steeple still white-capped, but the parking lot beside it was starting to show the lines of the spaces. He found himself looking at it differently than he had that first week. Less as evidence of something diminished and more as evidence of something still going. Someone had been in there on Tuesday night with the lights on. Someone was still in there, doing the work of keeping it.

That felt important this morning. He wasn't sure why.

* * *

Priya found him there.

"Morning."

"Morning." He moved to give her the window.

She looked at the road. She had her mug against her chest the way she did when she was thinking about more than one thing at once.

"Day after tomorrow maybe."

"That's what I thought."

She stood beside him. Not touching — just beside. The specific proximity of two people who have been in the same space long enough that the not-touching is as communicative as the touching.

"Are you — okay? With going back?"

He thought about it honestly. Not what he was supposed to say. What was actually true.

"Yes and no."

"Yeah," she said.

That was enough. They stood there for a bit, watching the road come back, and the church at the end of the block come back with it.

* * *

Marcus came down without being called, which was new.

He ate his cereal and looked at the table and thought about the week.

Not strategically. Just — let himself look at it the way you look at a thing that's almost over and has turned out to be different from what you expected.

He'd expected this week to be bad. Not catastrophically — he wasn't dramatic, that wasn't his register — but simply: bad in the way transitions were bad. Friction, unfamiliarity, the particular specific

loneliness of being somewhere you haven't yet understood. He'd been in enough transitions to know the shape of them.

This week had not been that shape.

He wasn't sure what shape it was yet. He'd need more distance to name it. But the things he'd been carrying — not Jordan specifically, but the weight of the previous months, the combination of the move and the thing with Kwame and the silence and the not-telling and the decision not to knock on that corner and what it cost him not to — some of that weight had shifted. Not gone. Shifted. Changed position. Sitting differently on him than it had on Sunday when they drove north on the 400 and he watched the city disappear behind him.

The journal had done that. He hadn't expected the journal to do anything — he'd assumed it was for the adults, for Nali and his parents, a thing about their generation, their sense of time and mortality and meaning. But the journal man had been fifteen once. Had sat in rooms not knowing how to be in them. Had watched people he admired and tried to reverse-engineer what they had. Had done wrong things and been wrong about why, and found out later. Had carried things too long and then, one day, put them down.

He'd turned his phone face up last night.

He hadn't called Jordan yet. But the phone was face up, which was not nothing. The phone being face up meant he'd decided it was possible. That was where he was. The decision-it's-possible stage, which came before the deciding-to stage, which was fine, that was the right order.

He looked at Mateo making his way efficiently through his cereal, the figure beside his bowl, the October morning notebook he'd been using for drawings on the table beside the figure.

His brother. Six years old and watching everything and understanding more of it than anyone knew.

"Mateo," he said.

"Yeah."

"You're alright, you know."

Mateo looked at him with the direct gaze he used when he was deciding whether something was a compliment or an observation.

"I know," he said. And went back to his cereal.

She washed up the breakfast things alone, which she preferred some mornings.

Not because she didn't want anyone — she did, in a general way, always. But washing up alone was the closest thing she had to formal thinking. Her hands in the warm water. The sounds of the house above her. No one needing a response from her. The particular freedom of a task that occupied the body and left the mind entirely its own.

She thought about what the week had given her.

It had given her: Sibafuzi at the porch step. The way he'd said it, the clean version — *I said something I shouldn't have. I'm sorry*. No wrapper on it. She'd watched Marcus take it. She'd watched the thing move through her son, the stiffness in him, and then the loosening. Not resolution — she knew not to mistake loosening for resolution — but the beginning of the condition in which resolution would someday be possible. That was enough. That was enough for today.

It had given her: Nali in the kitchen at night. The sound of her moving, the sound of the kettle, the sound of the stone on the counter. Nali who had come because Nali always came when she was needed, without being asked, without naming it, because that was who Nali was and always had been and Priya had known it since she was twenty-five and sitting at a dinner table being looked at by this woman who saw things clearly and said: *yes, that's how it is*.

It had given her: the journal. The man in the journal, his whole life on those pages, the trying and the failing and the getting up and the trying differently. The way the family had gathered around it like a fire. The way it had done something she hadn't known she needed — shown them a way of talking to each other about the things they didn't

usually talk about. Not directly. Through him. Through his specific honest struggling life.

She dried her hands.

She walked the garden one more time on the last morning.

Early, the others still inside. The frost on the cedar fence. The enormous lilac at the back, bare now in November but present, occupying its corner of the world with the commitment of something that had made a decision about where it was going to be and intended to honor it.

She stood near the back fence. The same place she'd stood on the first morning when she'd found the stone. The stone was in her pocket. It had been in her pocket every day of this week, a small warm constant.

She stood and looked at the garden in the winter morning. The silver maples visible above the roofline. The church steeple just above the fence line, the cross at the top pale in the early light.

She thought about the journal man standing here. He'd written about this garden — the lilac, the cedar fence, the way the light came in at the east end in the late afternoon. He'd stood in this garden for ten years. His daughter had grown up in this garden. He'd learned the particular moods of this space the way you learned a place you'd committed to.

She'd lived in eleven houses. She had not lived in all of them long enough to know them. Some had been stops, not homes — places she was between other places. Some had been homes she'd been asked to leave. Two had been homes she'd chosen and then lost.

This one was not hers. It belonged to her son and her son's family, and to whoever had been here before, and to whoever would come after. But she'd spent a week in it and a week was enough, sometimes, to know the quality of a place. The way you could meet a person once and know whether they were someone you'd want to have in the world.

This house was someone she wanted to have in the world.

She put her hand on the back fence, briefly, the way her mother had put her hand on walls.

It's been loved, the journal man's mother had said about this house.

Yes, she thought. It has.

She turned and went back inside. She put the kettle on. She stood at the window while it boiled and looked at the kitchen that was almost entirely her son's kitchen now — the spice cupboard organized Priya's way, the drawer with the batteries for the cassette player still sitting open from Day Two, the mug tree with its specific arrangement of mugs that she'd spent five days learning to read — and she felt what she felt at the end of a stay somewhere good.

Not sad. Not ready to leave exactly. Just — full. The way you felt after the right kind of meal. Satisfied in the way of someone who'd had enough, which was different from someone who was done.

Sibafuzi came through and she poured his tea and they stood together at the window and the morning arrived over Bishop Street the way it arrived every morning: first the steeple, then the trees, then the whole street opening into the day, the same as it always had been, the same as it would continue to be, long after they'd gone, holding what it held.

She thought about Deepa. She was going to call on Thursday. Not maybe-Thursday. Thursday. She was going to say: *I've been a bad correspondent and I miss you and I want to tell you about this week*. Deepa would say: *finally*. Priya would say: *I know*. And they'd be back in the red kitchen in about four sentences, which was the gift of a friendship that had been built for the long run.

She put the dishes away.

She heard Nali in the hallway — the specific footstep pattern, the pause at the landing. She heard Sibafuzi in the garage, the purposeful sounds of a man who had decided what to do today and was doing it.

She heard Mateo say something to himself at the table, something she couldn't make out, something addressed to the figure — a running commentary, the kind he'd been giving since he was three, the private narration of a person who processed out loud. She heard Zara's pen moving. She heard Marcus, somewhere above, moving around his room with the slightly different energy of someone who has decided to stop lying on the floor.

All of it. Every sound. The specific acoustic map of her family in this house.

She put the last glass away.

She thought: *I'm beginning to know this place.*

She went to join them.

He walked to the hardware shop on the main street on the afternoon of Day Five.

Not because he needed anything urgently. He had a list — the screws for the porch step, a tube of weatherproofing compound, sandpaper in two grades — but he could have ordered any of it. He went because the snow had cleared enough to walk and he wanted to know what this town was like on foot, in winter, on an ordinary Wednesday afternoon.

It was quiet. Not empty — there were people, the occasional car, a woman with a retriever coming the other way who nodded at him as if they'd done this before, which they hadn't, which was just the town's way. The main street had the look of a street that had been through harder seasons than this and was still here, still open, still carrying on. He passed the coffee place that had been there since before he was born, judging by the sign. The bookshop with its hand-lettered window. The insurance broker. The empty unit that had been something and would be something again.

He liked it.

He hadn't expected to. He'd come to this town for practical reasons — price, distance, the school review, the size of the garden, the

garage. All solid reasons. None of them aesthetic. He'd told himself he didn't need the town to be beautiful. He needed it to be functional, safe, manageable.

It was those things. But it was also, he was finding, something else. It had a quality he'd learned to look for in the houses he visited for work, a quality that was not the same as charm or prettiness or historical significance. More like: a town that had been through things and kept its shape. A town that remembered what it was even in the difficult years.

He thought about the journal man. Driving up and down the street before going in. Asking around about the maple trees, the word for what they did in October. The retriever woman on Bishop Street, four hundred mornings of nodding.

He thought: I'm going to learn this town.

Not rush it. Not force it. The way you learned a house — by being in it, by showing up, by letting it reveal itself to you at the pace it chose.

He went into the hardware shop. Gerald was behind the counter, which he always was, which was the quality of a man who had decided exactly where he was supposed to be and had been there ever since.

"New in town?" Gerald said, which was how he opened with everyone. He would say this to Sibafuzi for approximately six months, until one day he wouldn't, because by then it would be obvious he wasn't.

"Just moved in," Sibafuzi said. "Bishop Street."

Gerald nodded. "Good house," he said. He said it the way you'd say it about a person you respected. "Good house on that street."

"I'm finding that," Sibafuzi said.

He got what he needed. He walked home. He started on the window seal in the study — the one that let the draft in on a north wind. Small job. Right tools. The house one small thing closer to

being theirs.

Marcus was at the table with his phone when it rang.

Not a text. Not a voice note. A call.

He looked at the screen.

Jordan.

He picked it up before he'd decided to. That was how it happened sometimes — the body acting before the mind had finished the committee meeting.

"Hey," he said.

"Hey."

Priya was at the counter. She heard it and went still in the particular way of a person who knew not to turn around. She made herself busy with something that did not require looking.

"How's the new place?" Jordan said.

"Cold," Marcus said. "Good. Both."

A pause.

"I heard from Terrell," Jordan said. "About what you said. To him."

Marcus stood up and walked into the hallway. He kept his voice even.

"Yeah."

"I've been trying to figure out how to — I've been sitting with it."

"Me too."

"You knew," Jordan said. Not a question. Not an accusation exactly. More like: the thing that needs confirming before anything else can move.

Marcus looked at the front door. Bishop Street outside. The covered porch, the silver maples, the steeple of St. Andrew's.

"Not all of it," he said. "Not the full picture. I knew Kwame was carrying something and I knew Terrell knew and I thought it would pass." A pause. "I left it too long."

Jordan was quiet.

"And then when you said it," Jordan said, "it landed like — it landed at the wrong moment."

"I know."

"And I've been trying to decide if the timing made it wrong or if it was the right thing at the wrong time, which is a different thing."

"It was the right thing at the wrong time," Marcus said. "I've been over it. I waited too long. I knew I was waiting too long when I was doing it." He stopped. He had not said this out loud to anyone. The sound of it, spoken, was smaller than it had been inside. More workable. "I should have said it earlier. I didn't. That's the honest version."

Silence on the line. The specific silence of someone taking something in.

"Yeah," Jordan said finally. "Okay."

"Okay?"

"I mean — yeah. I already knew that. I just needed you to know that I knew." A beat. "Kwame's fine. You know that?"

"I know."

"So — it landed weird and you took too long but the thing you said was the thing that needed saying and Kwame is fine."

"Yeah."

"Then we're okay, man." Said simply. Not as a gift — as a fact. "We were always going to be okay. I just needed to hear you say the actual thing."

Marcus leaned his shoulder against the wall. The specific relief of something that had been abstract made concrete. The weight that had been there since the court, since the last morning, since eleven days of the voice note sitting on his phone.

"I'm going to be in the new school after break," he said.

"I know."

"It's fine. It's going to be fine."

"I know that too," Jordan said. "You're you. You're going to be fine wherever."

Marcus looked at the hallway. The key ledge by the door — the journal man had written about that key ledge, the one that had been there since before any of them. He'd hung his keys on it the first day without thinking.

"Come visit," Marcus said. "When it's warmer. It's a good town."

"Yeah?"

"Good hardware shop."

Jordan laughed. It was the real laugh, the one Marcus had been not sure he'd hear again.

He stood in the hallway after he hung up.

He was thinking about something the journal man had written — not the famous line, not the one everyone had responded to. A smaller one, from the university section, the journalist years: *if you want to be found in a new place, you can't be hiding in the old one. the new people can only see what you bring with you.*

He'd been bringing something hidden. For eleven days. The story he couldn't tell anyone here because he hadn't resolved it there.

It was resolved.

Not perfectly — there was no perfect version of it, he'd made an error and Kwame had nearly been hurt and the timing had been wrong. But the thing between him and Jordan was resolved. The weight he'd been carrying since the last day at the court, the weight that had kept him at one degree of remove from everything in this house, from the journal and the family around it and the new town and Jamie at school — it was gone.

He could be here now. Fully here.

He hadn't understood, until it was lifted, how much of himself he'd been holding back.

They talked for another ten minutes. About ordinary things. Jordan's sister. The team. Terrell's unlikely transformation into

someone who handed in his homework. The kind of conversation you had when the actual conversation was over and you were just being people again.

He came back to the kitchen.

Priya was doing something at the counter that she had probably been doing for exactly the length of the call.

"Good?" she said.

"Yeah."

She turned around. She looked at him for a moment — the look she'd been doing his whole life, the one that meant: I see you, I'm here, I'm not going to make this a thing. She nodded once.

"I'm making tea," she said. "You want some?"

"Yeah," he said. He sat back down.

He put his phone on the table. Face up. Stayed face up.

She told him on Day Five, in the evening, when the others were occupied and it was only the two of them in the kitchen. She'd been waiting for the right moment since the first morning and the right moment had been available approximately four times since then and she had walked past each of them. She was done walking past them.

He was washing up. She came and stood beside him at the sink the way she'd been standing beside him at various sinks for forty years.

"I want to tell you something," she said.

He turned off the tap. Looked at her.

"I've been watching you for forty years," she said. "Doing exactly what you're doing this week. Walking into a new thing and making it yours." She paused. Chose the words carefully. "You do this with everything. You've done it since you were seven. A new country. A new school. A new city. A new house. You walk in and you look at it and you find the thing that's yours in it and you commit. Every time."

He was looking at her.

"I should have said it more," she said. "I said it in my head, many times. I should have said it out loud."

"Mum—"

"No. I'm saying it. You are going to stand here and let me say it." She said it without any particular gentleness. This was not the place for gentleness. "You are someone who shows up. You have always been someone who shows up. Your father had that too — that part, that one part, I want you to have it and not spend your life deciding whether you're allowed to."

His face. The thing that moved through it.

"You're allowed to," she said. "You got the good parts too. You carry them."

She was done. She'd said it. She went back to the table with her tea.

He stood at the sink for a moment. Then he dried his hands. He came and sat down across from her.

He didn't say anything. He didn't need to.

They sat together in the kitchen while the house went about its evening around them, and outside Bishop Street was quiet and dark and Bishop Street's particular self, and Nali drank her tea and did not need anything more from the moment than the moment.

Marcus laughed.

He made himself toast, quietly, and ate it standing at the counter, and the house was around them both, warm and smelling like itself now, mostly itself, and outside the snow was finally starting to go.

Zara came downstairs on the morning of Day Five with the cassette in her hand and a look on her face that meant she'd been up early doing something purposeful.

Priya looked up from the journal.

The cassette tape was on the coffee table. It had been there for five days. They'd all been looking at it for five days.

"He knew what was on it," Marcus said.

"Yes."

"He told us what was on it."

Sibafuzi was looking at the cassette. He picked it up. Turned it over. The cracked case, the soft paper insert, the worn-away writing.

"We still can't play it," Zara said.

The room was quiet.

Then Nali said: "Wait."

She stood up. Went upstairs with a purpose that suggested she had known for several days that this moment was coming and had been waiting for it to arrive.

They looked at each other.

She came back.

She was carrying a portable cassette player. Yellow, battered, the kind that had been everywhere once and was now only in attics and the bottom of bags packed by people of a certain generation. She set it on the coffee table beside the cassette with the air of someone producing the obvious answer to a question everyone had been asking.

Sibafuzi stared at it.

"I thought you didn't bring the tape player."

"I didn't say I didn't have one." She sat down. "I said I didn't bring it. Those are different things."

"Nali." He gestured at the player. "That was in your bag this whole time."

"It has been sitting there very patiently."

"You told me to travel light," he said.

"I did travel light. Everything I brought has a purpose." She looked at the player. "It turns out."

Marcus was looking at the Walkman with an expression that mixed recognition and archaeology — he knew what it was, distantly, the way you know something that predates you.

Mateo said: "What is that?"

"It plays tapes," Nali said.

"Like that tape?"

"Like that tape."

Mateo looked at the Walkman. Then at the cassette. Then back at the Walkman, recalibrating his understanding of what old things were capable of.

"Does it need batteries?" Zara said, already practical.

"It does."

Sibafuzi went to the kitchen. Came back with four double-A from the drawer where batteries lived. He handed them to Nali. She opened the battery compartment — it resisted briefly, the way things resist when they haven't been opened in years — and loaded them.

She held up the headphones. The old foam kind, the adjustable band crushed on one side, the wire wrapped around itself approximately twelve times over what appeared to be several years. Zara unraveled the wire with patient precision. One side was intact. The other ear produced — when she put it experimentally to her ear — a sound that was technically sound but could have been anything.

"One good side," she said.

"How do you know which is good?" Mateo said.

"You listen," Nali said.

She clicked the cassette in — the particular satisfying mechanism of cassettes, the click that meant: something is about to happen. She pressed play.

The wheels turned.

The room held.

* * *

The question of who listened first resolved itself the way questions resolved when Mateo was in the room.

He said: me.

Not asking. Not negotiating. Just: me. With the full quiet certainty he applied to the things that mattered most.

Everyone looked at each other and agreed.

He took the headphones. Zara showed him the good side. He settled it against his ear, both hands on the band, and went completely still.

His face was entirely open. Not a face doing listening. A face that had stopped being a face and was just receiving. He listened for two minutes, maybe three — nobody counted because counting would have broken something. His lips moved once, very slightly, as if he was considering speaking. He didn't speak.

He took the headphone off.

He looked at the table. The cassette in the player, wheels still turning.

"There's a man reading something slowly," he said. "Like he's being careful with the words. And then a small voice says again. And then he reads it again." He picked up the figure — Ray, the figure he'd been calling Ray all week — and held it. "And then the voice gets quiet. And then there's a silence. And then there's a song."

He held the headphone out.

"You have to hear the song," he said.

* * *

Zara went next. She had her notebook on her knee before she put the headphone on. She listened. Her hand moved on the notebook page. You could see the pen moving but not what it was writing. When she took the headphone off she looked at what she'd written. Then she closed the notebook.

She passed the headphone to Marcus without speaking. He took it. Leaned back against the wall, closed his eyes. During the reading and the again and the second reading he stayed still in the way he stayed still when something was going in rather than being processed. When the silence came he stayed still too. Then the song started. He opened

his eyes. Looked at the ceiling — his music-listening posture, the one he used when he needed the ceiling to hold still while he heard something. He kept looking at the ceiling. He took the headphone off after the song ended and held it in his hand for a moment without moving. Then passed it to Priya.

She put it on. The man's voice, reading — she listened with the part of her that cataloged things, the part that was always noting. The small voice, again. She smiled. He read it again. The silence when the child went under — she held still for that. Then the song. Her face did something. She was not quick enough with whatever she usually used to manage it. She didn't look at Sibafuzi. She took the headphone off and held it a moment. Passed it.

Sibafuzi took it. Held it to his ear. He listened with his face completely still — the quality of his stillness that his children knew, the one that meant he was doing real work somewhere behind his eyes. The reading. The again. The laugh — the man's laugh, warm and surprised, the laugh of someone who had not been expecting to be delighted and then was. The silence. The song. He listened to the whole song. Then he sat with the headphone loose in his hand and looked at the window. The church at the end of the block, its steeple visible in the last of the afternoon light. He sat like that for a moment. Then he passed it to his mother.

Nali took the headphone in both hands. She settled it against her ear. She closed her eyes immediately.

The reading: you could see her hearing it, something in how her face settled — not into emotion but into recognition, the way you recognize a voice you've been imagining and find that the real thing is close to what you thought.

The child's voice, asking again: her expression did something private and brief.

The silence.

Then the song.

She went very still. Not the receiving stillness — a different one. The stillness of someone who has encountered something they already knew, that had been living in them in some form before it arrived in sound, and who is now hearing it confirmed.

A man's voice. Guitar, unhurried. The kind of song that had been worked out at close range before anyone was listening — not a performance, a reckoning. It built slowly, not with drama but with accumulation, more of itself, the voice coming closer to something with every line. The lyrics were about a place — a specific place, named, the kind of specificity that should only work for people who'd been there but didn't, because the feeling under the geography was the thing everyone knew: loving somewhere, the particular quality of light there, the weight of what it meant to stay and to leave and to love both. It sounded like small towns. It sounded like a specific hour of a specific evening in a place where you were known. It sounded like, Sibafuzi thought without being able to explain why, like the inside of this house.

Nali listened all the way through.

She opened her eyes.

"He had good taste," she said.

A beat.

"Play it again," she said. "From the beginning."

Marcus laughed — the real kind, surprised into it. "That's what the girl said. On the tape."

Nali looked at him steadily. "Yes. Because when something is worth hearing, you hear it again."

* * *

The second time was different.

The first time you're discovering. The second time you're confirming, and that's its own thing — you hear with the

foreknowledge of where it's going, and that changes the texture of every moment before you get there.

The second time the man's voice reading was warmer. The second time the child's again landed in a different place. The second time the silence was something you'd been in before and were returning to.

And the second time the song, coming through the cracked case and the old foam headphones and the single working earpiece, moved through the room differently. The first time it had been his. The second time it had started to become theirs.

Monde had come to the middle of the room at some point and sat there, upright, as though he were part of the listening. He looked at each person in turn. Then he went and lay down with his head on Mateo's foot and stayed there.

When it finished the second time, nobody reached for the headphone.

They sat with it.

Outside, the snow was still, and Bishop Street was still, and at the end of the block St. Andrew's sat in the late afternoon with its light going.

"He was sitting in the dark with her while she slept," Mateo said. "And then he put on that song."

"Yes," said Priya.

"That's a good thing to do," Mateo said. Quietly. Definitely.

"Yes," she said. "It is."

"We should play it again later," she said.

Nobody disagreed.

He made himself toast, then looked at the cabinet, then made Mateo cereal without being asked and put it at Mateo's place and sat down with his toast. Mateo came in still holding the blanket from the sofa — he'd been sleeping there every night now by choice, and Monde had taken to sleeping at the foot of the sofa as though the arrangement had always been this and he'd been waiting for the

household to work it out.

Mateo saw the cereal waiting.

"You made mine," he said.

"I could see you coming."

Mateo sat down and ate. After a moment he looked across the table at Marcus with the direct gaze he used when he was checking something.

"Marcus."

"Yeah."

"Was Jamie the one in the journal? The boy who didn't care about what people thought?"

Marcus looked at him. The expression of someone deciding how to answer something.

"Why?"

"Just wondering."

Marcus was quiet for a second. Then:

"Maybe."

Mateo nodded like that was a satisfying answer. Went back to his cereal. He had the gift of knowing when a question was answered.

Mateo noticed that every person in the family held the journal differently. Mom held it like a cup — both hands, slightly raised, like it might still have something hot in it. Nali held it flat and still, like a tray. Dad, when he read from it, held it in one hand and kept the other free, like he needed one hand to hold the journal and one hand free for whatever the journal made him feel. Marcus, when he'd had it briefly, had held it low on his lap, between his knees, like he was protecting it from something. Zara held it by the spine and never the pages, which meant she understood something about old books. He held the figure the same way he always held things he didn't want to damage. He thought they were probably doing the same thing.

* * *

Nali came down slowly that morning. She'd slept long and wasn't rushing. Her hip was stiff — she'd felt it when she woke, the particular complaint of a winter morning, and had stretched it quietly in her room before coming down.

She sat in her chair and accepted her tea from Sibafuzi and looked around the room at all of them in the morning. Just looked. Taking it in. The specific quality of her attention — not cataloguing, not assessing, just present.

"Five days," she said.

"Five days," Sibafuzi said.

"Ay." One sound. Like five days was both nothing and everything and she was holding both at once.

Zara was already on the floor with her notebook, flipping back through what she'd written. Checking it. Her pen tapping the page in the way it did when she was thinking.

"How much is left?" she said.

"Two more eras," Priya said. "Maybe a bit more."

"And the letter," Marcus said.

Everyone looked at him.

"The letter in the box. Nobody's opened it yet."

He was right. It had been sitting there on the table with the other things, untouched since Priya had set it aside on the first day. Nothing on the outside. No name. Just waiting.

Nali looked at it.

"After," she said. "The letter is for after."

"How do you know?" Zara said.

"Because I know." She settled deeper in her chair. "Now. Who reads today."

Sibafuzi picked up the journal from the coffee table.

Everyone looked at him.

"I'll do it," he said.

Priya nodded. Didn't say anything. She could feel what it meant — him reaching for it, him being ready.

Sibafuzi opened the journal.

THE JOURNAL

Age 44 to 55

Sibafuzi read slowly at first. Finding the pace of it.

* * *

She is eight months old

she's figured out how to pull herself up.

she does it holding on to everything.

the sofa, the coffee table, my leg.

she pulls up and stands and gets this look.

pure disbelief.

like she can't believe she did it.

like she keeps expecting to fall and she hasn't yet.

I feel that a lot lately.

pulled up.

not quite sure I've done it.

waiting to fall.

but still standing.

I think it's the same feeling.

I think she's teaching me things already.

* * *

Mateo had been watching Sibafuzi read. When Sibafuzi stopped, Mateo said:

"Is the baby the one who put the box in the attic?"

The room turned toward him.

"What?" Zara said.

"You said someone put the box up there. Nali said it was the man's daughter. And the daughter grew up. So — is the baby her? The same person?"

Silence for a moment.

"Mateo," Marcus said slowly.

"What?"

Marcus looked at Nali. Nali looked at Mateo with something unmistakable on her face — the expression of someone watching a child be exactly and completely themselves.

"Yes," Nali said. "I think so. That baby is the same person who put the box there for us."

Mateo processed this.

"So she's real."

"She's real."

"She grew up in this house."

"In this house."

Mateo looked around the room — the walls, the ceiling, the fireplace, the built-in shelves in the study visible through the doorway. The east-facing window. The little key ledge in the hall.

"Keep reading, Dad," Zara said quietly.

Sibafuzi kept reading.

* * *

Her first word

dada.

that's all.

that's everything.

dada.

I've been saying it to myself for days.

She is five

she drew me.
she handed me a piece of paper and said I drew you.
it was me, I think, with a cape.
the cape went all the way to the ground.
I was flying or standing, it was hard to tell.
either way I was going somewhere.
I said — what am I doing.
she said — you know.
I said — I don't.
she said — yes you do.
and walked away.
I've been folding and unfolding this all week.
I don't know what to do with it.
I'm going to keep it forever.
I'm going to try to be worth it.
She arrived on a Tuesday.
I want to get this down before the specific quality of it fades.
not the facts.
the quality.
the way the room changed.
there was one version of the room before she was in it.
then there was a different room.
same four walls. same light through the window. same city
outside.
but the room had reorganized itself around this new fact and it
would never go back.
I've been thinking about this for twenty-two hours.
the things that change the room.
not everything does.
most things happen and the room stays the room.
but some things happen and the room is different.
the few things in my life that have done that:

the morning my dad left.
the lecture room at university.
the day I met Nadia.
and now this.

the room changed.

I'm going to try to be worth the room it made.

Priya had stopped reading.

Not for long. A moment. She was looking at something in the middle distance that was not in this room.

Sibafuzi was watching her. He knew this expression — had seen it at specific moments over seventeen years. The expression of his wife touching something that was also touching her.

"Fuzi," she said softly.

"Yeah."

"The day I told you I was pregnant with Mateo."

He remembered. The kitchen in the old flat, the particular evening light, the way she'd said it and he'd gone completely still and then stood up and the room had reorganized.

"I remember," he said.

"The room changed," she said.

He looked at her. She was still looking at the middle distance.

"It did," he said.

She nodded. Picked up the journal.

"Sorry," she said to the room. She wasn't, quite. None of them were. This was the right pace for it.

She read on.

She is three and a half

I've been recording the bedtime stories.

I know how that sounds.

but I'm already forgetting what she sounded like at two.

and I don't want to forget three.

I pressed record one evening without telling her.

I read the same short book we always read.
she said — again.
I read it again.
halfway through the second time she was asleep.
I left the recorder running.
I went and put on a record I love — quietly, so she wouldn't wake
— and came back and sat with her in the dark while she slept.
the tape just kept turning.
when I played it back later I heard us.
her voice asking for again.
my voice doing it.
the silence when she went under.
and then the music coming through, slightly dim, slightly perfect
— the way music sounds through a wall, or from another room, or
from a long time ago.
I keep playing that part.
the silence, and then the song.
I don't know how to explain why I can't stop.
something about the order of it.
something about the silence having the shape of her sleeping, and
then the song filling it.
I made a copy of the tape.
the original stays here.
with the other things.
She is twelve
she doesn't draw capes anymore.
she's past that.
she has opinions now, and the opinions are right, which is both
wonderful and terrifying.
she found me looking at the drawing one evening.
she stood in the doorway.
she said — why do you still have that.

I said — because I want to.
she looked at me for a second with the expression she has now, the
one that means she's deciding whether to say the thing.
she said — I still think that.
and left.
I stood there for a long time.
dada.
it means nothing and everything.
I called my dad.
I said she said dada.
he was quiet for a moment.
then he said that's the best thing.
that's the very best thing.
I said I know.
he said enjoy every bit.
I said I will.
I am.
I really am.

* * *

Work — the same year
something at work.
there was a decision.
I won't write it all out.
but someone was asked to sign off on something they shouldn't
have.
and they did.
and I watched it happen.
I didn't say anything.
I've been thinking about that for weeks.
why I didn't say anything.

I think I was afraid.
afraid of the cost.
and the thing is — I know what the cost would have been.
not enormous.
just uncomfortable.
just some people being unhappy with me for a while.
that's all it would have cost.
and I didn't do it.
I think about Ray.
I think about what he would have done.
I know what he would have done.
I'm filing this.
I won't forget it.
I won't let myself.

* * *

Sibafuzi stopped.

He looked at the page for a moment. Then he kept reading. But something had shifted in how he was sitting — something he'd taken on, something he was carrying in the new way you carry a thing that has just been named.

Priya was watching him.

Zara was watching the fire.

Marcus was watching his dad read and not saying anything, knowing it wasn't the moment.

* * *

That winter

the news.

I've been thinking about what it does to you.

reading it all.

all the time.
it's like being handed a list every day of everything wrong.
and the list is real.
the things on it are real.
but the list is also — the whole thing.
like there's nothing else.
I don't think that's true.
I think there's a lot else.
I just have to remember to look.
so I'm trying to look.
the woman at the school gates who always holds the door.
nobody makes her.
she just does.
the man at the shop who asks how you are like he means it.
the neighbour who brought our bins in when the wind blew them
over.
small things.
maybe not small.
maybe exactly the right size.
I'm trying to look.

* * *

"I do that," Priya said. "With the news. I have to put it down sometimes."

"Everyone does," Nali said. "The ones who pretend they don't are lying to themselves."

"But he doesn't stop," Zara said. "He just looks at the other things too."

"Yes," said Nali. "That's the bit. You can't unsee the bad things. But you can choose where else to look." She glanced at Sibafuzi.
"Read on."

* * *

Spring

there's a journalist.

I started reading her work maybe a year ago.

she writes about things nobody else is writing about.

not because they're not happening.

because it's uncomfortable to write them.

because it costs something to publish them.

last month something she published made a lot of people very
angry.

important people.

the kind of people who could make things difficult for her.

she published it anyway.

I read it twice.

then I found her name and I went and read everything she'd
written.

she doesn't flinch.

I don't mean she's fearless.

I think she's probably afraid.

she publishes anyway.

that's different from fearless.

that's better than fearless.

I wrote her a letter.

old fashioned, I know.

I don't know if she'll read it.

I said — thank you for not flinching.

that's all.

I needed her to know someone saw it.

* * *

Zara had stopped writing and was just listening.

"He wrote her a letter," she said.

"Mm," said Nali. Something satisfied in it. "He learned."

"From the lecturer," Zara said. "Two years later, the corridor. He learned to say the thing."

"Yes." Nali pointed at her. "You see? Nothing is wasted. Everything he did, everything he learned — it doesn't disappear. It comes back when you need it."

Marcus was leaning against the wall with his arms folded — not closed off, just thinking.

"She probably needed that letter," he said. "The journalist."

"Why?" Zara said.

"Because when you're the only one doing something, you wonder if it matters. You wonder if anyone's noticing. And then someone writes you a letter and says I see you, it matters. And you can keep going." He paused. "He gave her something."

The room sat with that.

Nali looked at Marcus with the expression she'd been collecting all week. The one with years in it. The one she reserved for things she wanted to keep.

Sibafuzi read on.

* * *

Her third birthday

she blew out the candles and then immediately tried to relight them.

she wanted to do it again.

and again.

I understand that completely.

some things you want to do over and over.

not because the first time wasn't enough.

because it was exactly enough and you want more of exactly enough.

my dad cried a little.

he's been crying more lately.

not sadly.

just — things affect him more than they used to.

I love it.

I love that he's at the age where things can just get to him.

where he doesn't hold it.

I want to be like that one day.

I think it takes courage.

letting things get to you.

not fighting it.

just letting it.

* * *

Sibafuzi's voice had changed a little on that entry. Just slightly. Something rougher in the texture of it.

Nali was looking at the wall somewhere above the fireplace. Not the entry. Just the wall. Her jaw working slightly, like she was chewing something down, managing something.

"Nali," Mateo said.

"I'm fine."

"I know," he said.

Then he got up from the rug and went and sat on the arm of her chair. She looked at him. Then she put her arm around him and pulled him down into the chair beside her. Too small for two people. They managed.

Monde went and lay down in front of the armchair, as if completing something.

* * *

Work again

I said something.
in a meeting.
something I wasn't sure I should say.
it was uncomfortable.
it made some people unhappy.
I said it anyway.
walking out I thought — that cost me something.
something small.
but something.
and then I thought about Ray.
and I thought — okay.
okay.
I did the thing.
it cost a little.
I'm still here.
this is how it works.
I understand it now.
in my body.
not just my head.
it went in.

* * *

"He did the thing," Marcus said. A quiet satisfaction in it.

"He did the thing," Priya said.

"Why didn't he before?" Mateo said from the armchair, looking at the ceiling.

"He wasn't ready before," Nali said. "You can't rush the ready. You just have to keep doing the small things until one day the bigger thing is possible. He was doing the small things all along."

"Like practice," Mateo said.

"Exactly like practice."

* * *

Autumn

I went to something.

a talk.

someone I've been following for a while.

she works in local politics.

I know.

local politics.

but she's been doing something real.

actually trying.

in a room where most people have given up trying and are just going through the motions.

she stood up and said something that half the room didn't want to hear.

it was true.

it was necessary.

I could see it cost her.

you could see it cost her.

and she said it anyway.

I was near the back.

people started talking back.

loud.

she didn't flinch.

she waited.

then she kept going.

I wanted to say something.

stand up.

I don't know.

something.

I didn't.
I clapped.
I clapped hard.
walked out.
I've been thinking about it for a week.

* * *

Sibafuzi stopped.

He read that last part again. To himself this time. Then he put the journal in his lap.

Nobody said anything for a moment. The room waited.

"I clapped," he said. Not to anyone. Just saying it. Holding it.

"He wanted to do more," Zara said gently.

"He didn't though," Marcus said. Not harshly. Just straight.

"No." Sibafuzi shook his head. "He didn't."

"Why?" Mateo said.

Sibafuzi looked at his youngest son. The full honest eyes. The question genuinely asked, genuinely wanting to know.

"Because standing up feels like it'll cost you something. Even when you can't name what. And sometimes you do it anyway and sometimes you don't. And the times you don't — you keep them." He looked back at the journal. "He's keeping this one."

"Is that bad?" Mateo said.

"It's not bad," Nali said carefully. "It's honest. And honest is where you start from." She looked at Sibafuzi. "Keep going, my dear."

Sibafuzi kept going.

* * *

Later that week

I've been sitting with the clapping thing.

I think what I was afraid of was getting it wrong.

saying the wrong thing.
making it worse.
which — maybe.
but.
she was up there by herself.
and I had a voice.
and I kept it in my chest.
I think the truth is — I was afraid.
just afraid.
no better reason than that.
I keep thinking about what I would have said.
you're right.
just that.
two words.
you're right.
it wouldn't have changed the room.
but it would have changed her day.
maybe.
and it would have changed me.
definitely.
next time.
if there's a next time.
I'm going to say the thing.

* * *

Marcus was very still.

Priya noticed. She always noticed.

"What?" she said to him, quietly.

He shook his head. Then changed his mind.

"I kept my voice in my chest once. At the old school. Someone was getting it in the corridor and I — I walked past." He looked at the

floor. "I think about it."

Nobody said you should have or you were young or it's fine. All of those would have been wrong. They just let him have it.

"You're remembering it," Nali said finally. "That means it matters to you. The ones it doesn't matter to — they don't remember. You're not one of those."

Marcus looked at her.

"Next time," she said. Same words as the journal. She'd heard them too. "You say the thing."

He nodded. Once. Solid. The kind of nod that meant something was being kept.

* * *

His parents — that year

Dad came to stay for a week.

I haven't talked about them much lately.

which means things have been okay.

you write about things when they worry you.

but he came to stay.

and something was different.

slower.

not bad different.

just slower.

he gets tired faster.

he took a nap in the afternoon, which he never used to do.

I watched him sleeping.

just for a moment.

and something went through me that I can't name.

time, I suppose.

just time.

the same feeling as the doorway.

wanting to hold it still.
can't.
just watch.
be glad you're watching.

* * *

Mum on the phone

she said something I've been thinking about.
I'd told her something that had gone wrong at work.
something I was beating myself up about.
she listened.
then she said — you know you're a good man.
I said Mum.
she said no. I'm telling you. you know that, don't you.
I thought about it.
I said — I think I do.
she said good.
because I've been watching you your whole life and I know.
and I need you to know too.
I cried after we hung up.
properly.
like something releasing.
I don't think I knew I needed to hear it.
she knew.
she always knows.

* * *

Sibafuzi's voice had gone rough on that entry. Not breaking. Just rough, the way a surface goes when something moves across it.

He got to the end of it and stopped. Put the journal on his knee.
Looked at the ceiling.

Nobody moved. Nobody spoke. The room just held the quiet.

Then Mateo, still in the armchair with Nali, said very gently:

"Dad."

"Hm."

"You're a good man."

The room. The fire. The snow-light coming through the window, a little thinner today, the world beginning to return. This house they hadn't known a week ago and were beginning to know.

Sibafuzi put his hand over his eyes for a moment.

"Mateo," Priya said. Not a warning. Just his name. The full weight of what she felt about him in three syllables.

"He needed to hear it," Mateo said simply. "Like the man in the journal."

Nali pressed her lips together. She was looking at Mateo the way you look at something rare that has been given to you completely without warning.

Sibafuzi took his hand away from his eyes. He looked at Mateo.

"Thank you," he said. The same words as the journal. The weight of them.

Mateo nodded seriously. Like it was taken care of. Like it was simply something that needed doing and he'd done it.

Zara looked at Marcus. Marcus looked at her. Some silent thing passed between them — siblings, a whole conversation without words.

Sibafuzi picked up the journal.

He kept reading.

She was watching her husband read.

She did this occasionally — not obtrusively, just attending. He read differently from her. She read ahead, her eyes moving slightly faster than her voice when she was reading aloud, already at the next sentence while the current one was still in the room. He read in the present tense. He was always where the words were, not past them.

She'd noticed this the first time she saw him read something that mattered to him, in the second month of knowing him, over a letter he'd received that she wasn't prying into. The quality of his attention. Entirely with the thing.

The journal was doing that to him now. Every entry. He held it slightly closer than was necessary, and he read each line as if it had been written directly at him, which she supposed, in some way, it had been.

She thought about what those entries were doing. The journal man in his thirties, in this house, with his daughter and his work and his particular ongoing project of understanding what it meant to try to be worth something. The entries not triumphant — the specificity of his failures, the workshop at sixty-seven, the way he'd stood up in that room and offered everything he had and the room had not been quite ready. The way he'd sat with that for years. The way he'd written: *I think the right response to that is to keep going rather than to recalibrate downward.*

She'd been recalibrating downward.

Not catastrophically. Just — gradually. The move, the upheaval, the question of whether the work she'd been doing was pointing anywhere, the routine that had been interrupted and hadn't yet been re-established, the chair by the window she hadn't found yet. All of it adding up to a smallness she hadn't named.

She was naming it now.

The right response is to keep going rather than recalibrate downward.

She kept that.

She made a note of it in the margins of her mind, in the place where she kept things she was going to take out and act on.

She watched her husband read, his whole attention in the present tense of the thing, and she thought: I'm going to find the chair by the window. Not the same one. A new one, in this town, in this house. I'm

going to find it and I'm going to do the work that needs the chair.
She was ready.

* * *

She is seven
she asked me today who my hero was.
out of nowhere.
we were just walking.
she said — dad who's your hero.
I didn't answer straight away.
she waited.
she's patient like her mum.
I said — I have a few.
she said who.
I said — your grandpa and grandma.
people I've worked with.
a journalist I've never met.
a woman I saw speak once and never saw again.
my mum.
she said — is that a lot.
I said — for real heroes? no.
for real heroes that's about right.
she thought about that.
then she said — am I your hero.
I said — you are.
she said — how.
I said — because every single day you just get up and try.
without thinking about it.
you just try.
and that is the whole thing.
she said okay.

like that made sense.
then she walked on.
I needed a minute.
she didn't notice.
I didn't mind.

* * *

Priya laughed first. Short and wet. She pressed her fingers to her mouth.

"She asked if she was his hero," Zara said.

"And she is," Sibafuzi said. He looked up from the journal. He was smiling and it was the kind of smile that had too much in it to be just a smile. "Of course she is."

"Am I someone's hero?" Mateo said.

"Yes," said four people at once.

Mateo looked at each of them, checking, as if he needed to verify the count.

"Okay," he said. He seemed to find that reasonable.

Nali squeezed him. He let her.

* * *

This year

I've been noticing how few of them there are.

the real ones.

not the famous ones necessarily.

just the ones doing the thing.

paying the price.

still going.

there's the journalist.

there's the woman from the talk.

there's a teacher at school who stays late every single day.

nobody asks him to.
he just does.
there's a man I see sometimes at the community place.
volunteers.
been doing it fifteen years.
doesn't talk about it.
just does it.
there are some.
not many.
but some.
I used to think the world was full of people like that.
I don't think that anymore.
I think they're rare.
and I think that's why they matter so much.
scarcity.
and I think — if you're lucky enough to see one.
you tell them.
you say the thing.
you write the letter.
you stand up in the back of the room.
you say you're right.
you say I see you.
because nobody else might.
and they need to know.

* * *

The room was still for a long time after that one. Not the held-breath kind. The settled kind.

The fire had gone low again. Nobody moved to fix it.

"He found his version," Zara said eventually.

"Of what?" Priya said.

"Of the thing he wanted. From the entries when he was in his thirties. He said he wanted to be worth the pointing. To be someone doing something that costs them something." She turned back through her notebook, found it. "He said 'I want to be worth the pointing.' And then this era he's — pointing at others. Making sure they know. Writing letters. Saying the thing. That's his version."

Silence.

"Ay," Nali said softly. "Ay, Zara."

Marcus was looking at his sister. Slowly he started nodding.

"Yeah," he said. "Yeah that's right."

Sibafuzi looked at Zara with something that took him a moment to recognize in himself.

He looked at the journal in his hands.

"Last one," he said. "Of this part."

* * *

Her ninth birthday

she didn't want a party.

she wanted to go somewhere.

just us.

so we went.

long drive.

nowhere special.

just a place she'd seen in a book.

we got there and it was smaller than the picture.

she said — oh.

I thought it would be bigger.

I said sometimes that happens.

she said is that bad.

I said no.

small can still be good.

she thought about that.
then she ran at it anyway.
full speed.
like the size didn't matter.
like the point was just to run at it.
I stood and watched her.
Nadia came and stood beside me.
she took my hand.
we just stood there.
watching her run.
the two of us.
that's what I have.
right there.
that.
that's the whole thing.

* * *

Sibafuzi closed the journal.

He closed it carefully, like closing something that mattered. Set it on the table.

He looked at his hands for a moment.

Then he looked up at Priya.

"That's us," he said. Simple. Just a statement.

"That's us," she said back.

That was enough.

Outside the sky was doing something — moving, shifting, the afternoon light going golden in that particular way it does in Ontario at the hinge point of winter, when the worst of it starts to ease just slightly, enough to remind you that it won't always be winter, that winter has an end.

Mateo looked at the figure in his hand.

"I know his name," he said.

Everyone looked at him.

"I've known for a bit. I was waiting to be sure." He held the figure up. "His name is Ray."

The room.

Sibafuzi looked at his son.

"Ray," he said.

"Because he shows up," Mateo said. "And he has the sentence. Even if nobody knows what it is."

Something moved across Sibafuzi's face. The complicated thing. The thing with too much in it.

Nali made the sound. The one with no language.

Marcus had his head down. Smiling to himself.

Zara wrote it in her notebook. The name. Just the name, on a line by itself.

"Ray," Mateo said again, satisfied. He set the figure on the arm of Nali's chair so it was facing the room.

Facing all of them.

* * *

They ate dinner late that night.

Priya and Sibafuzi made it together again, side by side at the counter without needing to talk about who was doing what. They just moved around each other and it worked and neither of them pointed at it — it was too new and too good to point at, the way you don't look directly at certain things in case the looking changes them. At one point Priya said, without looking up from the pot: "Good call last night, Fuzi." He said nothing. She didn't need him to.

Marcus came to the doorway of the kitchen and said: can I help? And Priya handed him a knife and a handful of potatoes and he sat at the table and did it without complaining, which was also new. She

could feel it — the change in him, something done differently now. Not fixed, not resolved, not the end of anything. Just the beginning of a different direction.

Nali sat at the kitchen table and told a story about a man from when she was growing up in Livingstone — a neighbour who fixed things for everyone on the street. Not because anyone asked him to. Just because something needed fixing and he could fix it, and that was enough reason.

She found Nali in the kitchen, alone, after everyone had gone to their rooms.

Nali was at the table with her stone and her tea, not reading, not doing anything except being in the quiet. She'd been a long time with the quiet recently — not withdrawn, not absent, but doing the specific work that required quiet. Zara knew that work. She did it herself.

She sat down across from her.

Nali looked up.

"You've been waiting," Nali said. Not accusingly. Just: I know.

"You said not now," Zara said. "So I waited."

Nali put the stone on the table. Looked at it. Then looked at her granddaughter — this particular granddaughter who missed nothing and asked questions that were always the right questions and wrote everything down, who had been watching her grandmother's face all week with the patient thoroughness of someone assembling something whose purpose she didn't yet fully know.

"What did you notice?" Nali said.

"Day Two. When Marcus read the journal man's entry about the journalist. You went still. Not the usual still. The other one."

Nali nodded slowly.

"I knew a line," she said. "I heard it — read it — a long time ago. Maybe fifteen years. An article. A woman writing about ordinary courage, people who do the unremarked thing. There was a line in it. I cut it out. I had it on the wall in my kitchen for years. Your father

teased me about it." She paused. The stone turned over in her hand. "When Marcus read that entry — where the journal man says he wrote to the journalist — I thought: that's her. That's the article. Same words."

Zara was very still. Pen in hand. Not writing. Just present.

"What was the line?" she said.

Nali was quiet for a moment. She'd been carrying this since Day Two, waiting for the right moment, which was now, which was here, with her granddaughter in the night kitchen with the snow going soft outside.

She said it.

She said: *"When someone's doing something that costs them something and they do it anyway — you feel it. Even when you're small. You always know."*

The room held it.

"That's the journal man's mother," Zara said. Her voice was careful. Like handling something that might not survive rough treatment.

"Yes. He wrote it to the journalist. She used it in her article. I read the article and put the line on my wall. And I had no idea." Nali shook her head slowly, something like wonder in it. "I had that line on my wall for years. His mother said it to him when he was a child and he held it for his whole life and then he wrote it in a letter and it got into that article and then it was on my wall in Lusaka and I was saying it to Sibafuzi when he needed to hear it." She looked at the stone. "The things we pass on. We don't know where they've been."

Zara was looking at her grandmother. Something was building in her face — not quite crying, the thing before crying, the thing where you've understood something real.

"Nali."

"Mm."

"That means the line went from his mum to him to the journalist to you to us. It's in us now."

Nali looked at her granddaughter. This child who had stood at the bottom of a painted staircase and known what she knew and waited until she was ready and then gone up. Who would write all of this down. Who would carry it forward in ways none of them could see yet.

"Ay," she said softly. Just that.

She reached across the table and put her hand over Zara's.

"Write that down," she said. "That one. Write it down carefully."

Zara wrote it down.

"He sounds like the journal man's dad," Zara said.

"Does he?" Nali tilted her head. "Maybe. Or maybe all the good ones are a bit the same. Not the same person. The same thing in them."

"What thing?" Marcus said.

Nali thought about it properly. She never answered that kind of question quickly.

"They see what needs doing," she said. "And they just do it. Not for the credit. Not even thinking about the credit. Just — there's a thing that needs doing and I can do it. So." She opened her hands. "So."

"Did he know you admired him?" Zara said.

"I don't know. I was very young." A pause. "I hope someone told him. I hope someone said the thing."

Zara wrote something in her notebook. Nali watched her write it and didn't ask what.

* * *

That night, before bed, Sibafuzi found Marcus in the hallway.

Marcus was standing by the coffee table, holding the photograph from the box. He'd picked it up and was looking at it by the lamp — the man and the woman, young, formally dressed, looking at each other instead of the camera. Someone had taken this picture at a moment when they'd forgotten to look at the camera, or chosen not to.

"Do you think that's them?" Marcus said. "His parents."

"I think so."

"He loved them a lot."

"He did."

Marcus looked at the photo a moment longer. Then he set it back on the table.

"Dad."

"Yeah."

Marcus looked at him. Direct. The way he almost never was — the way he'd been only a handful of times, the kind of directness that meant something had been decided.

"I know I've been hard to live with. Since the moves. Since all of it."

Sibafuzi looked at his son. Fifteen. Nearly a man. Still a boy. Both at once, in the particular painful beautiful way they are at fifteen, and it was the most incredible thing to stand next to if you let it be.

"You haven't been easy," Sibafuzi said. Honest. No wrapper on it.

Marcus nodded. Expected that.

"Neither have I," Sibafuzi said. "We're even."

Marcus looked at the photograph.

"The journal man," he said. "He forgave his parents. For being people."

"He did."

"I think I can do that."

Sibafuzi put his hand on his son's shoulder. Not speaking. Not filling it.

Marcus let it stay there.

That was the whole conversation. That was all of it. That was enough.

* * *

Fifty-one

I've been in this house for eighteen years.

I want to say something about that.

not the practical things — I know the practical things. I know the name of the crack in the garage floor and the note I made about fixing it in spring, repeated now for five years. I know the exact sound the heating makes when the temperature drops below minus ten. I know the corner of the kitchen window where the seal has started to go and the specific quality of the draft from it on a north wind.

but that's not what I want to say.

I want to say: I know this house the way I know Nadia.

not completely — you never know anyone completely, and trying to is a category error. but with the specific intimacy of long presence. the way you know someone's breathing in the dark. the way you know which footstep on which stair means they're coming downstairs at three in the morning because something is wrong, versus the stair they use when they're just going to get water.

the house has that now.

we have it of each other.

I've been trying to work out what I think about heroism.

I've been working on it my whole life.

I thought, when I was young, it was about the moment. the dramatic act. the thing you'd tell someone.

I don't think that now.

I think it's about the sustained thing. the long slow undramatic thing.

showing up. continuing. not giving up on the people and places you've committed to.

being here when it's unremarkable. being here when the remarkable thing is that you're still here.

I've known people who did this.

Mum. Nine hundred Wednesdays.

Ray. The saved seat, ten thousand times.

Nadia. Every morning for twenty-six years.

This house. One hundred and twenty years of people being in it and loving it and leaving it for whoever comes next.

the long thing.

that's the whole thing.

When the final section ended, nobody moved for a while.

The fire had gone down to embers. Someone should have put more wood on. Nobody got up.

Marcus was the one who finally moved. He stood, crossed to the fireplace, put two logs on. The fire took. The room went warmer.

He sat back down.

Nobody said thank you. It wasn't that kind of moment. It was just what needed doing, and he'd done it, and now there was more fire, and that was enough.

Sibafuzi was looking at the journal. He had his reading glasses in his hand, turning them, a habit.

"The long thing," he said.

"The long thing," Nali said.

He looked at her.

Something passed between them. Not words. The specific communication of a mother and a son who had been doing this for forty years — not the shorthand of habit but something quieter, the kind that had gone past words entirely into something that just was.

"I've been thinking about what I want the long thing to be," Sibafuzi said. To the room. Not to her.

Priya looked at him.

"This," he said. Simply. "This is what I want the long thing to be."

He didn't gesture. He didn't need to. The word *this* in this room, in this house, on this evening, contained everything that needed containing.

Mateo, who had been nearly asleep for an hour, opened his eyes.

"Long," he said, with great satisfaction, and closed them again.

Zara wrote something in her notebook. The pen moved for a long time.

Marcus looked at his hands. He looked at the fire he'd just fed. He looked at the journal on the table — this whole man's life, the trying and the staying and the long slow undramatic work of being in the world — and he thought about what his own long thing was going to be.

He didn't know yet. He was fifteen. He had time.

But he was beginning to know the shape of the question.

And knowing the shape of the question, he understood now, was how you started.

* * *

CHAPTER NINE

The Sixth Day

She was the first one down.

She went to the kitchen in the dark, not turning on the overhead light — just the lamp above the cooker, which was enough. She stood at the counter for a moment and listened to the house.

The bag was where she'd left it on the first day. At the bottom of the overnight bag she'd packed for the week, beneath the folder of work she hadn't opened and the book she hadn't read: a small cloth drawstring bag, dark blue, slightly worn at the pull. She'd packed it without thinking, the way she packed it for every house they moved into. Her mother had done the same thing — carried her small kit from house to house, not making a ceremony of it, just: this is what you do.

She set the small brass plate on the counter. Put the square of camphor on it. Her mother had bought it in blocks from a shop in the city, the smell of the shop itself a particular kind of clean. Priya bought it online now, in a small tin. The camphor was the same.

She lit it.

The flame was small and blue at first, then white. She picked up the plate — it didn't get hot, the camphor burned clean — and walked slowly through the downstairs rooms. Not hurrying. Not saying anything. The living room, where the ashes of the last fire were still in the grate. The hallway, the key ledge, the narrow stair. The study where the box sat on the shelf.

Her parents had been devout in the way of their generation — morning puja, fasts she'd stopped keeping at seventeen, prayers she'd long since let go of. But this she'd kept. Not from belief exactly. More from the recognition that some things were true regardless of whether you could explain them. Her parents had walked through every new house this way and the houses had become theirs. She had tried it with the first house she and Sibafuzi had rented, not sure if it would feel strange, and it hadn't felt strange. It had felt like paying attention. Like saying to the house: I know you've held other people. I'm going to try to hold you well too.

She came back to the kitchen. Put the plate on the windowsill and let the camphor finish.

Then she put the milk on. A measure of whole milk, the cardamom pods pressed open with the flat of her thumb, three cloves, a small curl of cinnamon. Her mother had added jaggery; Priya used honey, which her mother had said wasn't right, and she'd said she knew and had kept doing it anyway. The heat low. Not boiling. Just warming through.

She stood at the window while it came up.

The garden in the last-day light. Cedar fence. The enormous bare lilac at the back. The church steeple just visible. The world coming back.

She heard the creak of the small stair. Mateo.

He came to the kitchen doorway and stopped. Looked at the plate on the windowsill, the thin thread of smoke still rising from the last of the camphor. Then at her.

She looked back.

He came and stood beside her at the window. Neither of them said anything. He looked at the garden.

After a while she poured some of the milk into a small cup and handed it to him. He took it with both hands. They stood together while the house finished waking up around them.

She woke early and went through the notebook from the beginning.

She did this occasionally with notebooks — went back to the first pages to understand what shape the thing had taken. Sometimes you didn't know what you were writing until you read it back. Sometimes the notebook was smarter than you were, recording the pattern before you'd understood it was a pattern.

She sat on her bed with the dawn light through the window — the east-facing window, the one that caught the morning first — and she read what she'd written.

Page one: the first day. The attic. The shelf. The box. *Hidden but not locked. Left, not forgotten.* She'd been asking the question from the start.

Page three. *He noticed things that cost him nothing to notice, and they meant something.* She'd underlined this twice, which she only did with things she was going to come back to.

Page seven: the bit about the crew, about Darius, about the room where nobody was trying. *The best rooms are the ones where nobody's trying. How do you make that room? You stop trying first.* Her own addition, the inference she'd drawn. She still thought this was right.

Page twelve, the professor and the margin note. *You're being deliberately vague here. Either you don't know what you mean, or you're afraid of what you mean. Either way, fix it.* She'd written below it, in her smaller handwriting: *This is going in my head forever.*

Page fifteen: the journal man at thirty, the workshop at sixty-seven, the question of whether trying was enough if the years had been hard. Marcus's challenge. Her own note: *The journal is fallible. That makes it real. Trust the fallible things.* She'd thought about this for two days and still believed it.

Page nineteen: Nali on the stone. The women who had carried things. The chain from Esther Imakando to here.

Page twenty-two: the cassette. *The silence having the shape of her sleeping, and then the song filling it.* She'd written it out exactly, the way she wrote things she wanted to keep word for word, even though that was usually not her method. Some things you didn't want to paraphrase.

Page twenty-six. *Every house makes you bigger.* Mateo had said it, in the way Mateo said things — as if he'd just remembered something obvious. She'd written it down immediately.

Page thirty: *The light going out through the glass. Not in.* Mateo reading the drawing. She'd been the first one to understand what he meant, and she'd written it and underlined it and was still thinking about what it meant, not as an analysis but as a fact about how you carried things with you, outward, into the world.

She reached the current page.

Tomorrow — no, today, this morning — they were reading the last entries. The packing entry. The letter. And then they were done.

She thought about what done meant.

It didn't mean the journal was over. It would stay on the shelf in the study. Whoever came to this house next would find it. The chain continued.

She closed the notebook. Put it in her bag.

She went downstairs to be part of the last day.

The road was back.

Sibafuzi saw it properly when he opened the curtains that morning. Dark asphalt, wet and real, running the full length of Bishop Street. The cars had their shapes again. Someone a few houses down had their engine running, white exhaust in the cold morning air. Farther along the block, St. Andrew's Presbyterian stood with its steeple cleared, the snow mostly slid off the stone now, the parking lot visible and empty and clean.

He stood at the window for a while.

He'd known it was coming. He'd been watching it come back all week, a little more each day, the way you watch something you've made your peace with even if you hadn't wanted to. Tomorrow they'd go back out into it — work, school, the ordinary machinery of the life they'd built. Today they still had today.

He thought about the church. He'd been thinking about it differently since yesterday. Not as evidence of a town diminishing — he still thought that was true, that there was a real emptying out happening in Collingwood, families heading south, the town finding a new shape that wasn't quite the old one — but as evidence that some things kept going anyway. Someone was in that building on Tuesday evenings with the lights on. Someone was still showing up. He understood that now in a way he hadn't understood it on moving day.

He thought about the journal.

He thought about Mateo saying: you're a good man.

He put the kettle on.

He smelled it at the bottom of the stairs.

He'd come down expecting the usual morning — the cold near the floor, the smell of the previous day's fire. Instead there was something else. Clean first, then underneath that something warm and specific. He stood on the bottom step for a moment.

The kitchen doorway. He went to it.

The small brass plate was on the windowsill. A faint residue of ash. Priya at the window with her mug. Mateo beside her with a small cup. Both of them looking at the garden.

He didn't ask.

He stood in the doorway a moment. The smell was familiar in a way he couldn't trace. Not Priya's usual cooking, not quite. But close to something that lived in the same region of his memory — mornings in Nali's kitchen when he was small and she had things on the stove before the day started. The smell of being looked after before you

knew you needed it.

He thought: it smells like ours.

He came and stood at Priya's other side. Put his hand briefly on her shoulder.

She put her hand over his without turning around.

They stood there, the three of them, and watched Bishop Street come all the way back.

He stood at the window for the last time in this week's particular way.

Tomorrow he would stand here and it would be different — the road clear, the normal life resumed, the window becoming a window again rather than whatever it had been this week. A portal. A held space. The location where he came to think things through before he'd earned the language for them.

He had a lot of language now that he hadn't had on Sunday. Not the language of insight, not the dramatic kind — no revelations, no moments of clarity that divided a life into before and after. Just words for things he'd already known but hadn't been able to say. Words for the specific weight he'd been carrying. Words for what it meant that Marcus had come and helped hold the porch board. Words for what it had meant to stand in a hallway with his son and say sorry without a wrapper on it. Words for the journal man, this person who'd lived in this house and tried and failed and tried again and eventually got somewhere worth being, and who was gone now, and who had left his daughter's drawing on a shelf in the eave because he'd understood that things you'd carried your whole life deserved to be carried forward, not just kept.

He thought about his own father's hands. He looked at his own. Same shape. Same knuckle. Same slight difference between left and right.

He thought: *you can carry the good parts forward. That's allowed.*

He'd spent a long time — more than he'd known until this week — being careful about the parts he inherited. Careful in the wrong direction. Being so focused on not carrying the bad parts that he'd been tentative about the good ones too. As if the whole inheritance were suspect. As if it were safer to hold it at arm's length than to go through it and choose.

He was going to go through it and choose.

Not today. Today they were going to read the last journal entries and open the letter and go home tomorrow. But after this week he was going to sit with the box of his father's letters that was in a cupboard in the house they'd left and was being held by his brother's wife who was looking after the post, and he was going to go through them. Not to resolve anything. Just to choose: this part forward. This part down.

The kettle came to a boil. He made the tea.

Outside, Bishop Street was clarifying. The snow had passed its peak and was beginning the process of returning to itself — the dark line of asphalt showing through, the rooflines emerging from white, the church at the end of the block visible again in the early light with its steeple pale against a sky that was deciding, this morning, to be actually blue.

He stood and looked at it for a while.

He thought: *I'm glad we came here.*

He thought: *I'm glad we're here.*

Present tense. Both.

* * *

Nobody needed telling that this was the last day.

They could all feel it — the way you feel the last day of something good. Not with dread exactly, just with a kind of sharpness. Everything a little clearer, a little more noticed. Even the way the morning light came through the east-facing window seemed more

itself today, more deliberately golden.

Nali made tea and sat in her chair and looked around the room at all of them without saying anything for a long while. Sibafuzi caught her doing it.

"What?" he said.

"Nothing." She sipped her tea. "Just looking."

He understood that completely.

* * *

Mateo came down with the figure. Ray. He'd been carrying it since the naming but something was different this morning. He set it on the coffee table next to the box and sat down across from it and just looked at it for a while.

Zara watched him.

"You okay?"

"Yeah."

"What are you doing?"

"Looking at him." He tilted his head. "I think he should stay here."

"What do you mean?"

"In the house. He came from the house. I think he should stay."

Zara looked at the figure. The bent cape. The hands worn pale from being carried.

"He's yours though," she said.

"I know." Mateo looked at it steadily. "But I think it's right."

Zara opened her mouth. Then closed it. Some things you didn't argue with.

"Okay," she said.

Mateo nodded. Decided. He picked the figure up and held it while he ate breakfast, the way he always did. But something about it had changed. He was holding it differently — the way you hold something when you've already decided you're going to let it go and

you're doing it slowly so it doesn't feel sudden.

* * *

Priya had the journal.

She'd been holding it since she came downstairs, turning it over in her hands. Not reading. Just holding it — the cloth cover worn pale at the spine, the elastic closure gone slack with age. All these entries inside. All these days.

Sibafuzi sat down beside her.

"Alright?"

"I don't want it to be over," she said.

"I know."

"That's strange, isn't it. It's someone else's life."

"It's not strange." He looked at the journal. "It doesn't feel like someone else's."

She looked at him. The man she'd been arguing with about paint a week ago. The man she'd been moving around like two separate weather systems. The man who'd put his hand on her knee without looking and she'd covered it with hers, and the room had felt it, and Marcus had felt it, and she knew something had shifted and it was still shifting.

"No," she said. "It doesn't."

She opened it to where they'd left off.

"Last part," she called out to the room.

Everyone came.

THE JOURNAL

Age 56 onward

Priya read the heading and the room settled.

* * *

Somewhere in there

I've started writing shorter.
not because less is happening.
because more is.
you stop trying to catch everything.
you just write the thing that matters.
the rest takes care of itself.

* * *

This year

she called.
just to talk.
I don't always write when things are good.
I should.
today I am.
she called.
just to talk.

* * *

Marcus had gone very still.

He was sitting on the floor by the fireplace, same as every day now. He'd stopped pretending to be anywhere else about three days ago — had simply arrived each morning and taken his place and stayed. He was watching his hands.

"Marcus," Mateo said.

"Shh."

"But —"

"I know," Marcus said. Quiet. "I know."

He looked at his hands. Then at the journal.

He looked at his hands. Then at the journal.

"I'm going to call him again," he said. Quietly. "Not about the thing. Just to talk."

Priya read on.
it there. Face-up.
Priya read on.

* * *

Mum

I don't want to write this.
and I'm going to write it.
because I've been writing everything.
and this is the most important thing.
so.
Mum.
she went quietly.
the way she did everything.
no fuss.
on her own terms.
I was there.
I held her hand.
I told her.
I said everything.
I didn't leave anything in my chest.
I said it all.
she knew.
I know she knew.
but I said it anyway.
I'm glad I said it anyway.
she did things because they needed doing and she could do them.
Wednesday mornings, for fifteen years.
I keep thinking about those children.

some of them would be adults now.

some of them can read because she sat with them on a Wednesday morning.

she gave them something and moved on and never connected herself to it.

the medal is the only evidence she left.

a small bronze thing on a faded ribbon.

evidence of a hero who left no trail.

Mum died in February.

I'm not going to try to write about that yet.

I know it'll come.

but right now it's still a hole where a thing used to be and the edges haven't settled.

you can't write about a hole when the edges haven't settled.

Six months later

I went back to the house.

Soli had kept it as it was.

I walked through it.

I stood in the kitchen where she used to stand at the sink.

I put my hand on the counter.

I sat in her chair.

I went through her things, slowly, over three days.

I found the medal on the third day.

in a box in the wardrobe.

no note. no explanation.

the medal from the library where she volunteered for fifteen years.

every Wednesday.

I had to call Soli to ask what it was.

Soli said: she went every week. for fifteen years. the reading programme for children who were behind.

I said: why didn't she tell me.

Soli said: that's a good question. she was always — she just did things. without making a thing of them.

I sat in her chair for a long time after that call.

I thought about all the Wednesdays.

fifteen years of Wednesdays.

sixty Wednesdays a year.

nine hundred Wednesdays.

nine hundred times she got up and went and sat with children who were struggling with reading, and helped them, and came home, and said nothing about it.

nine hundred quiet ordinary acts.

no story about it.

no asking to be seen.

just: Wednesday.

just: the library.

just: showing up.

I've been sitting with the medal on the kitchen table for three days and I still don't know what to do with the weight of it.

The room was very still.

Marcus was not on the floor now. He was sitting in the armchair — he'd moved at some point in the last hour, without anyone noting it. He was sitting forward, elbows on knees, looking at the journal in Priya's hands.

"Nine hundred Wednesdays," he said.

"Nine hundred," Priya said.

"And she never said anything."

"Never."

He sat back. Looked at the ceiling. Then at Sibafuzi.

"Did you know?" he said. "Before the journal? Did Nana ever — "

He stopped. He realized as he said it. He looked at Nali.

Nali was very still.

"My mum," she said quietly. "Not the library. Different things. But yes. That way." She paused. "You don't know everything about the people you love. That's not — that's not a failure of the relationship. That's the relationship. They were their own person, doing their own work, with their own private list." She looked at the medal, on the table, where it had been since the first day. "You find out later. If you're lucky. Sometimes you don't find out. Sometimes you just carry the fact that there was more than you knew."

Mateo was looking at the medal.

"There's more than we know," he said.

"Always," Nali said. "That's not sad. That's interesting."

He nodded. Filed it. Turned back to the journal.

"She showed up," he said. "Nine hundred times."

"Nine hundred times," Nali confirmed.

"That's the thing you'd notice if it stopped."

Nobody needed to add anything to that.

Nobody spoke for a long while after that one.

The fire had gone low. Outside, the snow had settled into the kind of quiet that meant it was finished for now. The church at the end of Bishop Street sat in the late light with its steeple still.

The medal was on the table with the other things. It had been there all week. They'd looked at it every day. None of them had known what it was.

Now they knew.

Nali had her hand closed around her stone. Her eyes were open but she was somewhere else — somewhere the entry had sent her, some room of her own, some Wednesday morning she was thinking about.

"Fifteen years," Zara said. Quietly. Not to anyone.

"She just went," Marcus said. "Every week. And didn't say."

"She didn't need to say," Priya said.

"Why not?" Mateo said. He was looking at the medal with the concentrated expression he used when something didn't yet make

sense. "Why didn't she tell him?"

The room considered how to answer this.

"Because the telling isn't the point," Nali said finally. "You do the thing for the thing. Not for the telling." She paused. "Some people do things so others will see them do it. Your great-grandmother was not that kind of person." She looked at the medal. "That kind of person doesn't win medals. Because nobody knows to give one."

Mateo thought about this fully, the way he thought about everything that mattered.

"So the medal is for people who don't do it for the medal," he said.

Nali looked at him.

"Yes," she said. "Exactly that. You've said it perfectly."

Mateo nodded. Filed it. He'd been filing things all week. The file was getting full.

"Keep going," he said to Sibafuzi. "There's more."

Sibafuzi kept going.

say the thing.

always.

say the thing.

* * *

Priya stopped.

The room was very still.

Nali had her hand over her mouth. Her eyes were closed. The stone in her other hand.

Sibafuzi had stood up from the sofa at some point without anyone noticing. He was standing near the window. Back to the room. Not leaving. Just needing somewhere to put himself for a moment.

Mateo looked at Sibafuzi's back. He started to get up.

Zara touched his arm. Gently. Shook her head once.

Mateo sat back down. He understood. Sometimes people needed a minute at the window. He'd learned that this week.

Priya waited. She was good at waiting.

Eventually Sibafuzi turned back around. He sat down. He nodded at the journal.

"Keep going."

His voice was steady. He'd done the thing in the window. Worked it through.

Priya kept going.

* * *

Dad — the following year

Dad.

six months after Mum.

I think he was ready.

I think he'd done what he came to do.

he fixed everything he could fix.

he held the torch as long as he could hold it.

then he put it down.

I picked it up.

Going through their things

it took a long time.

there were boxes I hadn't known about.

a whole life in boxes, the way it always is.

most of it I knew what to do with.

some of it I didn't and so I've been sitting with it.

at the bottom of a box of papers there was a photograph.
folded in half.

I unfolded it.

two people at a table.

a gathering of some kind — there was food, other people in the background, the light of a specific afternoon.

they were not facing the camera.

they were facing each other.

my mother's mouth was open, mid-sentence.

my father was leaning toward her — not far, just slightly, the lean of someone who doesn't want to miss anything.

somebody caught that moment.

I don't know who.

I don't know if they knew what they were catching.

I turned it over. nothing on the back.

I stood in my father's kitchen for a long time looking at this photograph of two people in the middle of being alive together.

it's proof.

that they had moments that were only theirs.

that they were people before they were my parents.

that whatever complicated things came later — whatever they got wrong, whatever I got wrong — they had that.

that afternoon. that lean. that almost-missed moment someone caught by accident or by intention.

I'm keeping this.

I'm folding it back the way it was and keeping it.

Marcus was holding the photograph.

He'd picked it up from the coffee table without thinking, drawn to it the way you're drawn to things you've been circling. He was looking at it — really looking, now that he knew. Two people at a table, mid-conversation, not performing. His father's lean. The thing that existed before any of the rest of it.

He set it back down.

Very carefully. The same care Zara had used with the drawing.

He looked at Sibafuzi.

"That's them," he said.

"Yes."

"He found it in a box."

"Yes."

Marcus nodded slowly. He was thinking about something — you could see it working.

"He didn't know who took it," he said.

"No."

"But someone was paying attention." He looked at the photograph on the table. "Someone was in the room, and they were paying attention, and they caught it."

Priya looked at her son.

He didn't look back at her. He was still looking at the photograph.

"I think that might be the whole thing," he said. "Paying attention."

The room sat with that.

Nali turned the stone over in her hand. Didn't say anything. Which, with Nali, meant everything.

that's how it works.

I know that now.

that's exactly how it works.

* * *

"He picked it up," Mateo said. Very soft.

"The torch," Zara said.

Mateo nodded. He was looking at the figure in his hand. He turned it over once. Then held it still.

Nali had opened her eyes. She was looking at the journal. Her face was complicated and clear at the same time — the way faces get when they've felt a great many things and have stopped fighting any of them.

* * *

She is sixteen
she argued with me today.
properly.
about something real.
she was right.
I told her she was right.
she looked surprised.
I said — why are you surprised.
she said — you don't usually say that.
I said — I'm trying to do better.
she said — you're not bad at it.
I said — thank you.
she said — that's not exactly a compliment.
I said — I'll take it.
she laughed.
she laughs like Nadia.
I never get tired of it.
I never will.

* * *

Priya was smiling reading that one. Properly smiling.
"She sounds like you," Sibafuzi said to Zara.
"She sounds like she's right and he knows it."
"Yes," said Sibafuzi. "Like you."
Zara considered this. Accepted it.

* * *

The work now
I'm not in the room the way I used to be.
different role.
I'm the person now who stands at the back and watches.

and sometimes says the thing.
sometimes I have the sentence.
not always.
but sometimes.
I think about Ray.
the one I called Ray in here.
I called him last year.
we talked for a long time.
I told him.
I said — you gave me somewhere to put things.
he said — you had the things already.
I said I know.
thank you anyway.
he said — you're doing it too.
you know that.
I said — I'm trying to.
he said — same thing.

* * *

"Same thing," Marcus said quietly.
"Mm?" Priya said.
"Trying to and doing it. He said they're the same thing." A pause.
"I think he's right."
"Yes," Nali said. "He is."

* * *

Her eighteenth
she's going.
off.
her own thing.
I always knew this was the point.

the whole point.
raise them to leave.
I know.
she's ready.
I stood in the doorway of her room last night after she was asleep.
just stood there.
same way I always have.
not wanting to change the thing I was looking at.
she didn't know I was there.
I just wanted to stay.
just that.
just her.
for a bit longer.

* * *

Nali made the sound. The one with no language.

Priya had slowed right down reading that one — reading it and also standing in the doorway of it at the same time.

Sibafuzi reached over and took her hand. Not looking at her. Just taking it.

She held on.

"He's in the doorway again," Mateo said.

Everyone looked at him.

"Like when he was little. He sat on the floor in the doorway and just wanted to stay." He held the figure. "He's still doing it."

Zara opened her notebook. She found the entry — she'd written it down on the first day. She read it back quietly:

"I sat in the doorway on the floor. They didn't know I was there. I just wanted to stay. Didn't want to talk or ask for anything. Just that. Just them."

She looked up.

"Same feeling. Different doorway."

The room sat with that. The fire. The snow-light, gentler now, the thaw beginning to make itself felt in the quality of the light.

"Keep going," Nali said softly. "We're almost there, eh."

* * *

These days

the journalist is still going.

I still read everything she writes.

* * *

This week

I've been thinking about the list.

everyone I've looked up to.

everyone who's mattered.

Mum. Dad. Adaeze. Ray.

the journalist.

the woman at the talk who didn't flinch.

the footballer I watched when I was twelve.

the music that made the walk feel different.

the professor whose office I finally knocked on.

Nadia.

my daughter.

the ones who got up.

the ones who said the thing.

the ones who showed up to the football in the big coat.

the ones who said — you're right, keep going.

I've been so lucky.

not because they were perfect.

they weren't.

none of them.

but because they were trying.

and I could see it.

and seeing it made me try.

that's the whole chain.

that's all it is.

I'm leaving this house

I've been sitting with the question of whether to leave it.

the journal.

Nadia says: leave it. someone will find it and it will mean something to them.

I said: but I don't know who.

she said: that's the point.

I said: what if no one looks in the shelf.

she said: someone always looks in the shelf.

I've been thinking about that.

someone always looks.

not immediately. not obviously. but eventually.

a child who is serious about things.

a person who needs what the shelf has.

whoever you are: I'm glad you looked.

I want to say one more thing.

I don't know what brought you here. I don't know what you're carrying. I don't know if this house has been kind to you or difficult or both, which is usually how it is.

but here is what I know:

this house was loved.

we loved it. the people before us loved it. the people before them loved it back to the beginning, back to when someone first built it and stood in the empty rooms and said: this. this is where the life will be.

you're part of that now.

not because you own it or rent it or are passing through.

because you're in it.

the house is different because you're in it.

that's all it takes.

The room was very still.

Priya had stopped reading.

She held the journal in both hands, looking at the page. Something in her face that was not quite readable — the expression of someone receiving something they'd been waiting for without knowing they were waiting for it.

"That's it," Zara said softly. "That's the last entry."

The fire. The six of them. The journal in Priya's hands.

Mateo had his hand on the figure.

Nali had her hand on her stone.

Marcus was looking at the journal, and his expression was not the closed one and had not been the closed one for most of this day, which was something.

Sibafuzi was looking at the window.

The east-facing window. The light through it, going out, the way it always went: from the inside, outward, into whatever was waiting.

"She was right," he said quietly. "Nadia. Someone always looks in the shelf."

"Yes," Nali said.

He looked at his family. All of them in the room.

"We looked," Mateo said.

"We looked," Sibafuzi agreed.

He held on to that for a moment.

Then: "The letter."

And Priya reached for it.

we decided last month.

it's time.

not because it's wrong.

because it's right and we've done it and the house knows.

you know. the house tells you.

not unkindly.
just — it's time.

* * *

I'm going to leave some things here.
in the attic.
on the shelf I built.
behind the panel, in the box.
I want to explain them, in case you find them.
I don't know when that will be.
I don't know who you'll be or what you'll need.

* * *

the drawing.
she drew this when she was five.
she handed it to me like it was obvious and went away.
she's twenty-two now and she said: leave it for someone who
needs it.
I think she knows something I'm still learning.
the drawing is a cape and a house with the light going out.
I think it means: carry it with you. or maybe: keep it here where it's
safe.
I'm not sure.
leave that for whoever finds it.
Sibafuzi stopped reading.
He looked at the drawing on the coffee table. It had been there all
week — they'd all been looking at it all week — but now he looked at
it differently. The small figure with the cape. The house in the corner
with the light going out through the window.
Mateo was looking at the figure in his hand.
"He kept it," Mateo said.

"He did," Sibafuzi said.

Mateo turned the figure over. The worn paint on the hands. The bent cape. He'd carried this since they arrived — brought it through the door on the first day with his arm out, giving it the view.

"I still think that," Mateo said. Quietly. Not to anyone in particular. Nobody asked what he meant. They all knew.

Sibafuzi looked at his six-year-old son. Something moved through his face quickly and settled.

He kept reading.

* * *

the photograph.

my parents.

someone caught them in a real moment and I don't know who.

keep it as proof.

proof that people you love had whole lives you didn't see.

and that a moment doesn't have to be witnessed to be real.

it just has to happen.

it happened.

* * *

the medal.

my mother's.

she spent fifteen years reading to children who were learning to read.

every Wednesday.

she never told me.

I found out after she was gone.

I'm leaving this because it seems wrong to keep it in a drawer somewhere.

it should be somewhere people can find it and wonder about it.

it should do one more thing.

* * *

the cassette.

if you can find a machine to play it, play it.

it has her voice on it when she was small.

it has a song.

the song is the last thing.

when you hear the song you'll understand why I kept it.

some things you keep because the keeping is a way of saying: this mattered. this was real. I was here, in that room, while she slept, and there was music.

* * *

this journal.

I won't say more about it.

just read it.

* * *

one more thing.

practical.

the furnace.

my father put in a secondary ignition on the east side of the unit, behind the panel — 1969, the winter everyone lost power for four days and he decided that was not going to happen twice.

the switch is stiff. you have to press and hold.

the key for the panel is on the ledge by the front door. small. brass. no label.

I left it there when we moved in and I never took it off.

most people don't look deep enough to find it.

if you ever need it: you'll find it.

* * *

* * *

I don't know who you are.

I don't know what brought you to this house or what you needed when you arrived.

maybe nothing. maybe you were fine.

maybe something.

either way: here.

this is some of what it was, to be here.

in this house, with its east window and its back garden and the church at the end of the street.

it was good.

it was everything.

I hope it is that for you too.

Priya stopped reading.

She looked at the journal in her hands. Then at the things on the table — the drawing, the photograph, the medal, the cassette in the Walkman, everything arranged exactly as they'd arranged it, five days ago, without knowing. The way it had been arranged on the shelf.

She looked at Zara.

Zara was looking at her notebook. She had her pen in her hand but she wasn't writing. She was just looking at what was already there.

"He packed it for us," Zara said.

"He did."

"He didn't know us. He didn't know anyone. He just—"

"He knew someone would come," Nali said. "Not who. Just that someone would come and would need it." She had the stone in both hands. She looked at the journal. "That's faith. That's the specific kind. Not religious, not in any institution. In people. That someone would come. That whoever came would be worth the leaving of it."

The fire had gone very low.

Mateo got up from the rug. He went to the fireplace and put the last log on, the careful way Sibafuzi had shown him on the first day: back of the grate, let it catch from the coals. He waited until it caught. Then he came back and sat down.

Nobody had asked him to. He'd just seen it needed doing.

He sat back down cross-legged and looked at the table.

"I'm glad we came," he said.

It was a simple thing. Six years old and it was the right thing.

"Yeah," Marcus said.

"Yeah," said Sibafuzi.

"Keep going," Mateo said. "There's still more. Keep going."

The same year

someone new started at work.

fresh out of school.

nervous in the specific way of someone who is trying not to look nervous.

I recognised it.

I recognised it completely.

I watched Ray with this person for two weeks.

Ray didn't do a thing I would have noticed if I hadn't been watching.

but I was watching.

small things.

saved a seat at the table so the new person wouldn't have to choose.

asked a question in the meeting that gave the new person a chance to say the thing they'd been holding back.

not making a big deal of either.

just — paying attention.

and adjusting.

I asked him about it afterwards.

I said — you did a thing with the new person. I wasn't sure you'd noticed.

he said — of course I noticed. he looked terrified.

I said — how come you helped.

he looked at me like I'd asked something extremely obvious.

he said — because I was that person once. and someone did that for me. and I remembered.

he went back to his work.

I've been writing about Ray for three years now.

I keep writing about him because he keeps doing this — small, specific, targeted attention toward whoever in the room most needs it.

not heroic.

not noted.

not for credit.

just: I remember what it was to need that. so I do it.

I'm going to try to be more like that.

I think I need to try harder.

"He paid it forward," Zara said. She was writing.

"Not even consciously," Marcus said. He was sitting up straighter. "He just — did it because he remembered."

"That's how it works," Nali said. "The best way. Not a policy. Not a decision. Just a memory that makes you act."

She looked at Sibafuzi. He was looking at the journal.

"Someone saved you a seat once," she said. Very quietly. Not a question.

He didn't answer immediately.

"First week at a new job," he said. "I was twenty-four. I didn't know where to sit. A man named Leonard pulled a chair out and said come here, sit here, I'll show you how this works." He paused. "Leonard was the best of it. He was there for three years and then he moved on and I've never found him to tell him."

"You tell him now," Nali said. "In how you do it. That's how you tell him."

The room sat with that. The fire. The window. The journal in Sibafuzi's hands.

"Keep going," Mateo said.

Priya turned the page.

someone tries.

someone sees.

someone tries.

* * *

Priya had to stop for a moment.

Not for long. Just a breath. A deliberate one. She looked down at the list on the page — all those names, all those people he'd been watching his whole life, all those small true things he'd been carrying.

"His whole life," Zara said quietly. "He's been building that list."

Marcus was nodding slowly. Looking at the floor.

"Someone tries. Someone sees. Someone tries." He said it like he was learning it. "It just keeps going."

"Forever," Nali said. "If enough people do their part." She looked at each of them in turn — slow, deliberate, the way she looked at things she was keeping. "Forever."

* * *

Yesterday

I was in the garden.

she was playing.

she had a toy.

I don't know what it was exactly.

a figure of some kind.

small.

worn.
she was narrating something.
a whole story.
I couldn't hear the words.
just her voice going.
her hands moving the figure through the air.
I watched her.
and something —
everything.
all of it.
came up at once.
the market on my dad's shoulders.
the Saturday cartoons.
the torch.
Darius.
the lecture room.
the washing up.
Nadia.
Ray.
the clapping.
Eight
we had a power cut last night.
the whole street.
Dad got the candles out.
we sat in the kitchen for two hours with candles on the table.
Mum told a story about when she was little and the power went out
for a whole week.
Dad told a story about his own father.
I didn't know that story.
I didn't know Grandad had been a person who had stories.
I mean I knew.
but I didn't know.

it was different in the candlelight.
we were all closer together.
I've been thinking about what's different in the dark.
I think the dark makes it easier to say the things.
Nine and a half
the best thing about being nine and a half:
you're old enough to know things but young enough that people
still explain them.
in a year or two they'll assume I already know.
right now they still tell me.
I'm going to pay attention this year.
I'm going to ask questions while I'm still allowed to ask them.
"He was already thinking about time," Zara said.
"Nine and a half," Priya said.
"The part about the dark." Marcus, from the floor. Not looking up.
"Making it easier to say things."
The room sat with that.
The fire was the closest thing to candlelight in the room right now.
They were all in it — all closer together than they'd been in a long
time, in the particular dark of a buried street, an unplanned week, a
journal that had been waiting on a shelf for the right people to come.
"He figured that out early," Sibafuzi said.
"Some people do," Nali said. She was looking at the fire. "Some
people come to it later. Both ways work." A pause. "The important
thing is you come to it."
Eleven
Mum did a thing today.
the neighbour's kid — I don't know his name, he's seven or eight,
he's always outside — was sitting on the wall crying.
I walked past.
Mum, coming back from the shop, didn't walk past.
she sat on the wall beside him.

didn't ask what was wrong.
didn't do the thing adults do where they crouch down and say
come on what's the matter.
just sat on the wall.
for about fifteen minutes, I watched from the kitchen window.
eventually the boy said something.
she said something back.
then he went in and she came in with the shopping.
I said what was that about.
she said I don't know. something. he needed someone to sit.
I said why didn't you ask him what was wrong.
she said because if someone needed to tell me, they'd have
knocked on the door.
she unpacked the shopping.
she wasn't making a point.
it was just what she'd done.
I've been thinking about it all day.
the difference between going and helping and just being there.
maybe they're the same sometimes.
maybe sometimes sitting on the wall is the whole help.
Thirteen
Dad took me to the football on Saturday.
big coat, flask of tea, the standing section.
I've been to football with him every winter since I was five.
the game was ordinary.
we lost, which was not unusual.
on the way home I said why do we always go when they always
lose.
he said because what kind of person only shows up when it's good.
I said most people.
he said most people miss most of the good stuff that way.
I thought about that.

I'm not sure I understand it yet.

I think I will.

Family response to mother entry:

Sibafuzi had stopped reading.

He looked at the entry for a moment. Then he looked at his mother.

Nali was looking back at him.

"She sat on the wall," he said.

"She did."

"For fifteen minutes."

"She sat there because the boy needed someone to sit." Nali was very still. "Not to fix. Not to ask. Just to be there."

The room was very quiet.

Mateo was looking at the figure. He turned it over once. Set it down in front of him with the cape flat on the table, not upright, not flying — just resting.

"Like when you sit with someone who's scared," he said. "You don't say don't be scared. You just sit."

"Yes," Nali said. "Exactly like that."

"I do that," Mateo said.

Nobody laughed. He was right and they knew it.

"You do," Nali said.

Sibafuzi looked at his son.

His son who was six and who sat with scared people without saying anything about it afterwards and had apparently understood this specific thing — that sometimes sitting was the whole help — without anyone having told him.

He looked at the journal. Back at his son.

"Keep reading," Priya said quietly.

He kept reading.

the doorways.

all of it at once.

like it had been waiting.
like I'd got so used to it being there that I'd stopped seeing it.
and then she moved the figure through the air and I saw it.
I saw all of it.
I didn't say anything.
I didn't want to change the thing I was looking at.
I just wanted to stay.
she didn't know I was watching.
I just stood there.
just her.
just that.

* * *

Priya had stopped reading.

Not because she couldn't. Because the room needed a moment and she was giving it one.

Mateo was looking at the figure in his hand. Ray. He turned it over slowly. The bent cape. The worn hands. The small weight of something held for years by someone who needed it.

He looked at it for a long time.

Then he looked up at Nali.

"Nali."

"Mm."

"When I was holding it. This whole time. He was writing about someone like me."

Nali looked at him.

"Someone holding a figure," Mateo said. "Someone not knowing they were being watched. And all of it coming back to him at once."

Nali's eyes were wet again.

"Yes," she said. "Exactly like you."

Mateo looked at the figure one more time.

Then he walked to the east-facing window — the kitchen one that caught the morning, that Sibafuzi had told Priya about from the car after the viewing, that had been part of why they were here at all — and he set the figure down on the sill carefully. Standing up. Facing out.

He came back and sat down.

Nobody said anything. Ray stood at the window in the thin winter light, facing out, facing Bishop Street, facing the world coming back.

"The last one," Nali said to Priya. "Read the last one."

Priya found it. The final entry. She held it open.

She read it.

* * *

Today

today was a good day.

* * *

Nobody spoke.

The fire. The window. The figure on the sill.

The same words as the first entry. The first words. The last words. The whole thing.

Mateo was the one who made the sound this time. Not a word. Just something that came out of him, small and full, the sound of a child receiving something very large.

Zara had her notebook open but she wasn't writing. Her pen in her hand and she was just holding it. Some things you didn't write down immediately. Some things you just let be.

Marcus had his eyes closed. His head back. Not gone. Present in the way you are when you're trying to hold something still long enough to feel all of it — fifteen and trying hard not to be seen feeling this and feeling it anyway, completely, because there was no way not

to.

Sibafuzi looked at his mother.

Nali looked back at him. All the years. All the houses. All the mornings. All the things she'd watched him become — the boy in the kitchen learning which drawer held the good pan, the teenager who carried things without saying so, the man in the garage on the phone at midnight working something out.

"Good day," she said to him softly. The Silozi word in it. Not translated. Just said.

He understood. He always understood when she went back to it.

"Good day," he said back.

Priya looked at both of them. She didn't speak. She just held the journal closed in her lap and felt what the room was feeling and let it be exactly what it was.

* * *

They stayed like that for a while.

Just in it. Not hurrying.

Then Zara said:

"The letter."

Everyone looked at the table. The folded letter, sitting where it had sat all week. Nothing on the outside.

Nali nodded.

"Now," she said.

Priya picked it up. She unfolded it.

One page. Handwritten. A woman's hand — clear, unhurried, someone who'd thought carefully about every word and then written them without hesitation.

She read it aloud.

THE LETTER

To whoever finds this —

I grew up in this house.

I know you don't know that. You're standing in rooms that were mine for a long time, and they probably don't feel that way, and they shouldn't. They're yours now. That's how it should go.

My father kept that journal for most of his life. He gave it to me when he got old, along with some other things. He said — I want you to have this, but I think someone else will need it more. I didn't understand what he meant at the time. I think I do now.

When I had to let go of the house, I couldn't take the journals with me. Not all of them. The place I was going to was smaller. And I thought — I'll leave them here. In the house. Where he was. Where we were. I hid them well enough that they wouldn't be found by accident. I needed them to be found on purpose. By someone who was ready.

I don't know who you are. I don't know what brought you to this house or what you needed when you got here. But if you found the box, you were looking. And if you read the journal, you were ready.

My father was not a famous man. He didn't do famous things. He worked and he loved people and he tried and he failed and he tried again and he wrote it all down honestly and he got up the next day and came in. That's what he did. That's all he did.

It was enough. More than. It was everything.

He showed me how to look up. He showed me who to look for. He taught me that the looking — the noticing, the seeing, the saying the thing — is not small. It's the whole point. It keeps the chain going. Someone tries. Someone sees. Someone tries.

I've been the someone sees for a long time now. Watching for the ones who deserve it. Writing letters when I can. Saying the thing.

I hope the house is good to you. The bones are good. Someone who loved it very much built it carefully for people he didn't know yet. That's what the key ledge is. What the east window is. What the

shelves in the study are. Little things that only happen when someone is planning ahead for a stranger.

That's what this letter is.

Take care of each other. Say the thing. Write it down. Don't wait.

She didn't show it to anyone. That was a rule she'd decided on before she started: you write it for yourself first. You figure out what you mean first. Then, if it's worth giving to someone, you give it. But the first version is yours.

She wrote: *Things I know from this week.*

Then she made the list. The actual list, not the preliminary one, not the draft — the real one, the one she'd been accumulating since the first morning when she'd stood in the attic and seen a panel that didn't sit right.

The things you'd notice if they stopped — that's what heroes are.

The things you carry become someone else's things. You don't always know whose.

Houses remember what they've been given.

Nali's grandmother said something to Nali that Nali said to Dad that the journal man's mother said to the journal man that the journalist put in an article that Nali cut out and put on her wall that became part of how Dad thinks. Things go further than you know.

The light through the east window is still here.

Mateo sees everything. He just doesn't say everything he sees. This is wiser than saying everything you see.

Marcus turned his phone face up on Day Six.

You can start writing any time.

She put the pen down. Read it back. Added one more:

Pay attention. That's the thing. That's the whole thing. My great-grandmother said so.

She closed the notebook. Held it for a moment.

Then she opened it again and wrote, at the very top of the list, before all the others: *I started here.*

Date. The house on Bishop Street. The week of the snow.

She closed it again.

She put it in her bag with Mrs. Pemberton's book and the note that said *for the long journey*. She'd known when to read it now. She'd read it this week without opening it. It had been this week all along.

The house chose you.

With everything,

A daughter who got very lucky

* * *

Priya folded the letter.

The room.

Outside, a car went past for the first time all week. Just one. Moving slowly on the wet road, cautious, relearning what it was to drive on a street that was a street again. The sound of the world coming back.

Nobody said anything for a while. Some things needed a while.

Mateo was looking at the figure on the windowsill. Ray, standing in the thin light, facing out.

Then he said:

"The daughter. She was the baby."

"Yes," said Nali.

"She grew up in this house."

"Yes."

"And then she left the journal here for us."

"Yes, my dear."

Mateo looked around the room. The walls. The ceiling. The east-facing kitchen window. The little shelf by the door where Sibafuzi's keys had been sitting all week. The built-in shelves in the study. The lilac at the back of the garden.

"She grew up here," he said again. Like he was moving into it. Like it was a house he was entering one room at a time. "And now we do."

Nali pulled him close.

"Now you do," she said.

* * *

Zara had been very quiet.

She was looking at her notebook. All the things she'd written over the six days — page after page of it, the quotes and the questions and the things she hadn't wanted to lose. She turned to the last blank page.

She looked at it for a long time.

Then she wrote something.

"Marcus was watching her. "What are you writing?"

She looked up.

"The first entry."

He looked at her.

"Of what?"

"Mine."

The room looked at her.

"I'm going to keep one," she said. Simple. Like she'd always been going to and just hadn't known it until now. "A journal. I'm going to write my days. Who I look up to. What I'm reaching for. I'm going to write it honestly. The bad bits and the good bits. I'm going to keep writing even when there's nothing good to say, because he did, and it mattered."

Nobody said anything for a moment.

"Can I read it one day?" Sibafuzi said.

"Maybe," Zara said. "When I'm old enough that it won't embarrass me."

He smiled.

"Fair."

"What did you write?" Priya said. "For the first entry."

Zara looked at the page. Then she read it out.

* * *

CHAPTER TEN

Zara's Journal

First entry. Written in a new house. Sixth day of snow.

Today

We found a journal in the attic.

We read it all week.

It changed things.

I'm not going to explain how because if I explain it it'll come out wrong.

But it did.

We came here not really talking.

We leave talking.

The house is still not ours yet.

But it's getting there.

I've been writing down things from the journal all week.

Things I didn't want to lose.

Nali says the things that plant in you when you're young — you don't know they're growing.

And then one day you look down and there they are.

I want to know what's growing in me.

I want to watch it.

So I'm going to write.

Not for anyone.

Just to see.

Just to know.

My heroes so far:

Nali.

The man in the journal whose name we never learned.

His mum.

His daughter who left this for us.

Dad — I've been watching him this week.

He's trying.

You can see it.

Mum too.

And Marcus.

Marcus on the floor reading out loud when he thought we weren't paying attention.

That one especially.

And Mateo.

Mateo who named the figure.

Mateo who put it on the windowsill.

Mateo who said I see you to every person in the room.

He's six.

He already knows.

I want to be that.

I want to know the thing that young.

I'm ten.

Maybe I still can.

I'm going to try.

That's the whole plan.

Try.

Write it down.

Keep going.

* * *

She closed the notebook.

The room was very still. Not the heavy kind. The full kind. The kind where something has just arrived and there is room for it.

Nali was looking at Zara with everything she had.

"Zara," she said. Just her name.

Zara looked at her grandmother.

Nali opened her arms.

Zara got up and went into them, which she hadn't done in a while, the way ten-year-olds go back and forth between being too old and needing it. Today she needed it. She went right in.

Nali held her and looked over her head at Sibafuzi and Priya and Marcus.

Sibafuzi had his hand over his mouth again. The complicated thing. The thing with too much in it.

Priya was not bothering to hold it in.

Marcus was on the floor with his back against the sofa looking at the ceiling. Jaw working. Eyes bright. Being fifteen and trying very hard not to be seen feeling this and feeling it anyway, completely, because there was no way not to in this room on this day.

Mateo had gone to the window. He was standing next to the figure. Ray on the sill. Both of them looking out at Bishop Street, at the road that had come back, at the world coming back, at St. Andrew's on the corner with its cleared steeple pointing at the sky.

He put one finger on the figure. Just resting it there.

Then he said, without turning around:

"He started and ended with the same words. I think I understand why."

* * *

The road was clear by the afternoon.

They didn't rush.

Sibafuzi fixed the front step on the last morning.

He'd been looking at it since they moved in — the third board from the top, slightly splintered at the left edge, a year away from being a real problem. He had the tools in the garage. He just hadn't done it yet because doing it required committing to being here, in the way that fixing a thing meant believing there was a future in which the fixed thing would be used.

He was ready to believe that now.

He went out in the cold with his tools and crouched on the porch and started working on it, and he'd been at it for five minutes when the front door opened and Marcus came out.

Not for any announced reason. He just stood on the porch in his coat and watched for a moment.

Sibafuzi said nothing. He kept working.

"You need me to hold anything?" Marcus said eventually.

Sibafuzi looked up. His son, fifteen, hands in his pockets, asking the question in the specific way he asked things he wasn't sure about but was asking anyway.

"Yeah," Sibafuzi said. "Hold this side flat while I get the screw in."

Marcus crouched down beside him. Held the board.

They worked like that for a while — not talking, just working, the cold air and the sound of the screwdriver and the house behind them, the church visible at the end of the street, the snow beginning to melt from the branches of the silver maples.

When it was done Sibafuzi tested the board with his hand. Solid.

He sat back on his heels. Marcus was still crouching beside him.

"I said something I didn't mean," Sibafuzi said. "The assignment thing. What I said — that wasn't right."

Marcus was looking at the fixed board. "It wasn't completely wrong," he said. "I haven't been doing the work. That part was right."

"The other part wasn't."

Marcus was quiet.

"I know you care about things," Sibafuzi said. "I know that. I was — I was carrying something else and I put it down on you. That was wrong. And I'm sorry."

The word landed with the weight that word carries when a father says it to a son and means it without reservation, without a qualifier, without the structure that usually surrounds apology — not *I'm sorry* but, not *I'm sorry if*, just the plain thing, undefended.

Marcus nodded slowly. Still looking at the step.

"He did the same thing," Marcus said. "In the journal. His dad said something wrong and then didn't say anything for days and it just sat there."

"Yeah."

"He wrote about it. Couldn't put it anywhere else."

"Yeah."

A moment.

"Maybe I'll start writing stuff down," Marcus said. Quiet. Not quite serious, not quite joking.

Sibafuzi looked at his son.

"Yeah?"

"I don't know." He stood up. Shrugged in the way that meant yes, *probably*. "Maybe."

He went back inside.

Sibafuzi stayed on the porch a moment. Looked at the fixed step. The board would hold for years now, done properly, the right screw in the right place. Then he looked up at the church and the sky behind it, which was beginning to show something — not quite blue, not quite gray, something in between that meant the cold was thinking about breaking.

He stood up.

He went inside.

She said: yes, he's settling. I think he's going to be fine.

She heard him start moving again.

Zara wrote three more pages in her notebook.

Mateo played.

* * *

That evening, Sibafuzi put the things back in the box.

The photograph — the man and woman looking at each other instead of the camera. The medal. The cassette. The drawing, soft as cloth, the blue-crayon figure with the bent cape. The letter, folded once. The journal.

Priya had picked up the photograph a dozen times this week without opening it.

It was folded in half — had been since Zara brought it down from the attic. She'd kept it folded, face inward. Not consciously. Just hadn't unfolded it. There had always been something else to look at first, something else to hold. The journal. The medal. The Walkman. The cassette.

But on the last morning, the morning of the road coming back, she unfolded it.

She was alone in the living room, early, everyone else still asleep. The photograph was on the table with the other things. She picked it up. Unfolded it.

A man and a woman, not facing the camera. Facing each other, mid-conversation, the kind of photograph that happens by accident or by someone who knew what they were doing. The woman was laughing — not posed, actually laughing. The man was watching her laugh. Not laughing himself. Just watching her, with a look on his face that meant he'd been watching her laugh for years and it still looked like that.

Old photograph. The kind that was taken on film, with the particular grain and warmth of it.

She turned it over.

And there, tucked in the fold she'd been carrying for six days, was a letter.

Thin paper, small handwriting, the kind of handwriting that had been formed before everything was typed. Dated. Recent enough to make sense. Addressed to no one, with the salutation: *I don't know your name, and you never knew mine, but I want you to know this:*

* * *

She read it once. Then she called everyone downstairs.

They came in their own order — Mateo first, then Sibafuzi, then Nali, then Zara, then Marcus last, still in yesterday's clothes, who stood in the doorway and then, quietly, came in.

Priya read the letter aloud.

The journalist — she signed only her first name, K., and the name of the publication, the one Nali had gone still at — had received his letter not three months after he sent it, in a year she named, which was a long time ago now, later in the journal man's life. She'd been working on a piece about ordinary courage. Not military courage, not protest courage — the daily, accumulating kind. She'd been struggling with it. It wasn't landing. Then his letter arrived.

His letter described what his mother had said to him when he was small. She used it in the piece — anonymously, with his permission sought in a follow-up she'd never received a response to — and it became the line that everyone quoted from that article. She named the line. Zara's hand found Nali's hand under the table.

She'd found the address of this house — she'd been corresponding with the daughter, she said, for years, trying to reach the man who'd written to her, and then the daughter had told her that her father was gone, had been gone for a year, and she'd been too late. So she'd written to the house instead, to whoever was there, because she wanted whoever was there to know:

He changed something. His mother's words — through him, through me, through the piece I wrote — changed something. I heard from a woman years later who had read the article in the waiting room of a hospital where her daughter was very ill, and she had taken the line — the line about what it costs, what it looks like, how you know — and had read it to her daughter, who recovered, who carries it now, who told me she told it to her own child just last year.

He never knew. He wrote a letter to a stranger and never heard back and never knew. So I'm telling whoever reads this: he knew. He just didn't know that he knew.

The things we do in the dark, without an audience, without acknowledgment — they don't disappear. They go somewhere. They become someone else's. I am proof of it. I am not the last proof.

Thank you for reading this far. Thank you for being in that house.
— K.

* * *

Priya stopped reading.

The room held what it held.

Outside, Bishop Street had come fully back from the snow — you could see it from the window, the asphalt dark and real, the parked cars restored to themselves, the silver maples at the front with their load lightened. At the end of the block, St. Andrew's Presbyterian stood clear in the winter light, the stone cross at the top of the steeple pale against the sky, a Tuesday-morning light visible in the side window.

Nali had the stone in both hands.

Mateo said, to the room in general, without urgency: "So his mum's words are still going."

"Yes," Zara said. Her voice was different. "They're still going."

Sibafuzi was looking at his hands. He looked up. He looked at Marcus.

Marcus looked back at his father. He didn't look away.

Sibafuzi said: "I'm glad we're here."

Nobody had anything to add to that. Nobody needed to.

He put the lid on.

He looked at it for a moment.

Then he went and got the figure from the windowsill. Held it a moment. Ray. Bent cape. Worn hands. The weight of something held for a long time.

He placed it on top of the box.

"Dad," Mateo said from behind him. "You can't put him inside. He needs to be able to see."

"On top," Sibafuzi said. "Not inside. On top."

Mateo considered this.

"Okay."

Sibafuzi looked at the box with the figure on it. Ray on top of the journal on top of the letter on top of the photograph of two people looking at each other instead of the camera — two people who'd been loved by a boy who wrote everything down and grew up to be the man whose daughter had left all of it here for them.

"Where should we keep it?" he said.

The family thought about it.

Priya went to the study — the study off the hallway with the built-in shelves that someone had made carefully, had made for a life, had made for a stranger they'd planned ahead for. She cleared a space on the middle shelf. Eye level. Visible.

"Here," she said. "Where we can see it."

Sibafuzi carried the box to the shelf and set it down.

Ray on top. Facing the room.

The family stood together in the doorway of the small study — all of them, Nali with the stone in her pocket, Mateo with nothing in his

hands for the first time all week — and looked at it. The box on the shelf in the house on Bishop Street in Collingwood, Ontario, in the house with the good bones and the east-facing window and the key ledge and the lilac in the back garden and the church at the end of the block still going, still trying, still lit on Tuesday evenings.

"Good," Nali said.

That was the right word.

That was all of it.

* * *

They put the things back.

Not in the attic — on the shelf in the study. The built-in shelves, the ones Sibafuzi had loved from the first viewing, the ones someone had made carefully and not in a hurry. Priya placed each item with both hands: the journal, the drawing, the medal, the cassette in the Walkman, the photograph still folded, the letter from K. All of it on the second shelf, eye level, where you could see it from the hallway.

Sibafuzi stood in the doorway of the study and looked at the shelf.

"Whoever built these planned to stay," he said.

"You said that on the phone," Priya said. "The day you found the house."

"I know." He looked at the shelf. "I'm saying it again."

Nali put her hand on the wall. Not testing it this time. Just touching it.

"Good bones," she said.

Same words. Different weight.

* * *

Sunday night. The snow was mostly gone. The road was back — dark asphalt, real and ordinary, Bishop Street returned to itself. At the end of the block St. Andrew's sat in the dark with its steeple and its posted

schedule and its lights off, and tomorrow was Monday.

Sibafuzi stood at the kitchen window. Not running numbers. Not catastrophising. Just standing.

The furnace was fixed. The HVAC company had come on Thursday, and the part had been ordered, and it was done. The mortgage was the same number it had always been. But he was different. He wasn't managing the number tonight. He was looking at the garden.

He thought about his father's letters. Still in the old house, in that cupboard, being held by his brother's wife along with the post. He'd go get them. Not this week. Not next week. When he was ready. He knew now that he wanted them. He wanted to sit with them and choose — this part forward, this part down. That was enough for tonight. Knowing he wanted to was the beginning.

Priya came through.

They stood at the window together. The specific silence of two people who had been through something and didn't need to narrate it.

"Ready for tomorrow?" she said.

"Yeah," he said.

Not about the furnace or the mortgage. About the school run. The commute. The town. The life.

* * *

Monday morning. The house had different sounds now — the alarm, the kettle, the particular rush of a household finding its weekday rhythm for the first time.

Nali was in the kitchen. She'd been up since six, the way she always was, the kettle already done, the tea already made, the morning already managed without appearing to manage it. She was at the counter in her cardigan with the stone in her pocket, and she was not going anywhere. The back bedroom with the east-facing window

was hers. The chair in the living room was hers. The kitchen at six in the morning was hers. She was home. Not visiting. Not helping temporarily. Home. That fact sat in the room like the furniture — permanent, undiscussed, load-bearing.

Marcus came down in his school clothes. The collar, the dark pants, the costume he hadn't auditioned for. But his headphones were around his neck, not on his ears. That was different.

He sat down. Nali put a plate in front of him without being asked.

"Jamie's in my homeroom," he said. Not to anyone in particular.

Nali poured his juice.

"Good," she said.

That was enough. He ate.

Mateo came down with Ray in one hand. He walked to the east-facing window — the one that caught the morning, the one the journal man had written about, the one Sibafuzi had told Priya about from the car on the day he found the house — and he set the figure on the sill. Standing up. Facing out.

"He lives here now," Mateo said.

Nali looked at the figure on the windowsill. Then at Mateo. She said nothing. She didn't need to.

Zara came down with her bag. The notebook was in it — she could feel the weight of it, the specific weight of a week's worth of writing, which was different from the weight of a blank notebook the way a house full of people was different from an empty one.

She looked at the kitchen. At Nali at the counter. At Marcus eating. At Mateo's figure on the sill.

She looked at the house from the inside.

* * *

They left in their own order.

Marcus first. At the door he paused. He didn't look back. Then he looked back.

"See you later," he said.

"See you later, eh," Nali said from the kitchen.

He went.

Zara next, with the bag, with the notebook, with the list she was still adding to. She didn't pause. She knew this house now. She'd come back to it at four o'clock and it would be the same and she would be slightly different and that was fine. That was the deal.

Priya took Mateo to school. Sibafuzi walked them to the car. He kissed Priya — brief, standing on the porch, the specific kiss of a Monday morning, which was its own kind of important — and watched them pull out.

He stood on the porch. The porch step he'd fixed. The silver maples, bare, their branches clear against the sky. The church at the end of Bishop Street, St. Andrew's, 1889, its steeple in the morning light. The parking lot empty. The door with its posted schedule. Still open. Still going.

He went to work.

* * *

The house with no one in it but Nali.

She sat in her chair. The stone in her pocket. The journal on the shelf in the study. The figure on the windowsill. The light through the east-facing window, doing what it had always done — going out through the glass. Not in. Out.

She put her hand on the wall.

She sat with the house.

The house sat with her.

* * *

Mateo was first through the door that afternoon.

He always was.

He dropped his bag in the hallway — not on the hook, on the floor, because he was six — and he ran through to the kitchen where Nali was at the counter and the house smelled like something she'd been making all day.

"Nali. I need the notebook."

She looked at him.

"The one Zara gave me. Where is it?"

"On the shelf, my dear. In the study."

He went and got it. He sat at the kitchen table. He picked up a pen — a real pen, not a marker, the kind that made the kind of marks that stayed.

Nali was at the counter. She saw him. She didn't say anything. She watched.

He wrote slowly. The handwriting of someone still working out how letters go. The tongue slightly out, the way his father's tongue went out when he was concentrating, the way it had gone out in England thirty-something years ago when he was cutting cardboard with scissors on the floor of a flat his mother still remembered.

Nali watched him.

She had watched Sibafuzi do this. At nine, with bottle caps and cardboard. She was watching Mateo do it now. At six, with a pen and a notebook, in a house where a man had done the same thing fifty years ago and kept doing it for his whole life.

She turned back to the counter. Let him have it. The moment was his.

Mateo wrote:

* * *

Monday

today was a good day.
we live here now.
I don't know for how long.
but the house knows us and we know the house.
I think that is how it starts.

* * *

Someone tries.
Someone sees.
Someone tries.

* * *

* * *

CHAPTER ELEVEN

A Note from the Author

My parents moved from Zambia to Canada when I was twelve.

It was a staggered move — the kind that doesn't get told in one clean sentence. The children came first. My brothers split between my two uncles' homes in Toronto. I lived with my grandmother in Barrie. When my parents arrived, we moved to a small home in Cambridge, Ontario, on a street not far from a Bishop Street, near a church that looked very much like the one in this story.

We moved after a year, to a bigger home in the same area. That was the last move. The kids grew up and eventually moved out, one by one, in the way that children do when you've given them enough of a foundation to go.

When the last of us had gone, my parents passed the house on to another family. I don't know who they are. I don't know what they're like, whether they've found the things we left in the walls — not a journal, not a box in the attic, but the ordinary residue of a family that was there for a long time and tried hard and loved each other imperfectly and kept going. I have so much I would tell them if I could. About which window catches the morning. About the sounds the house makes in winter. About what it was like to grow up inside those rooms and become a person there.

But I didn't keep a journal. That is the truth of it. I didn't write it down. The house is the only thing providing lessons now — whatever it holds in the way the walls settle, in the creak of the stairs, in the

particular quality of the light through the kitchen window that I can still see when I close my eyes.

This novel is the journal I didn't keep.

This novel is not autobiography. But it is not invention either.

My father — whose middle name is Sibafuzi — is a considerate thinker who carried a great deal of weight and made things work. My mother always took care of the children first. My grandmother, who I lived with in Barrie, is the woman Nali is drawn from — the person who reads rooms before she enters them, who says the thing nobody else will say, who sat with you when you needed sitting with and never once made it about herself.

They are in this book because they are the heroes the book is about.

Not the Hollywood kind. The real kind — the kind that shows up on an ordinary Wednesday and does the thing that needs doing without asking to be seen. The kind whose heroism is so quiet you might not recognize it until years later, standing in a kitchen of your own, realizing you learned everything that matters from watching someone else live their life with care.

This book is a dedication to every hero who has been in mine.

Some of them have parallels in these pages. Many do not. The teacher who stayed late. The neighbor who brought the bins in. The friend who sat in the waiting room and said nothing because nothing was what was needed. The colleague who pulled out a chair and said sit here, I'll show you how this works. They exist. I see them. I have been trying, my whole life, to be worth the looking-up-to they gave me without knowing they were giving it.

If you recognized someone in this novel — in the journal man's mother, in Ray, in the woman who didn't flinch, in the figure on the windowsill — you were probably thinking of your own hero. The one who cost themselves something and did it anyway. The one you'd notice if they stopped.

That is not fiction. That is the truest thing I know.
Someone tries. Someone sees. Someone tries.
Thank you for reading.
— Pumulo